

July 15 deadline set for private schools to form fee panels

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has issued a strict directive to all private unaided schools to set up their School Level Fee Regulation Committees (SLFRCs) by July 15, 2026. Delhi Education Minister Ashish Sood said on Thursday that private schools in the national Capital will have to justify any proposed fee hike on 18 prescribed parameters, including infrastructure development, transportation, safety measures and staff recruitment, and satisfy parents that the increase is warranted.

The move follows the enactment of the landmark Delhi School Education (Transparency in Fixation and Regulation of Fees) Act, 2025, which aims to ensure full accountability and absolute transparency in how school fees are determined across the National Capital Territory (NCT) of Delhi.

The minister said the Delhi Government has directed all private unaided schools to constitute a School Level Fee Regulation Committee (SLFRCs) by July 15 under the Delhi School Education (Transparency in Fixation and Regulation of Fees) Act, 2025,

warning of strict action against institutions that fail to comply.

Sood said the Government is committed to making quality education affordable and accessible, and asserted that education is “a noble service to society, not a commercial business”.

Under the new framework, schools seeking a fee revision will have to place their proposal before the committee and justify the increase on 18 parameters prescribed under the rules, he said.

“These include expenditure on infrastructure development, transportation facilities, school buildings, safety

measures, lighting, staff recruitment and other institutional requirements. Schools will have to demonstrate that the proposed hike is linked to genuine improvements and is supported by financial records,” the minister said.

According to a statement, every private unaided school must constitute an SLFRC comprising representatives of

students’ guardians, teachers and the school management.

The selection of five guardian representatives and three teacher representatives will be carried out through a public, video-recorded draw of lots after giving a mandatory seven-day public notice.

The process will be monitored by a Government-appointed observer. “To protect public interest and maintain absolute fairness, any school management found trying to influence the rules will face severe penalties. This includes heavy fines, suspension of school recogni-

tion, or a formal Government takeover of the school’s management,” it stated.

School managements have been directed to submit their proposed fee structures for the next three years to the committees by July 31, it stated, adding that the proposals must be supported by audited financial statements for the previous three years certified by a chartered accountant. Unaudited or self-certified financial records will not be accepted.

The statement also said in compliance with interim orders of the Delhi High Court, private schools will

continue to charge fees at the same rate as in the 2025-26 academic session until their revised fee structures are examined and approved by the regulatory committees.

Any excess fee collected during the interim period will be subject to the final outcome of the court proceedings and will have to be refunded or adjusted accordingly. The Directorate of Education has instructed regional directors and district officials to ensure strict implementation of the new provisions, saying the interests of students and guardians remain the Government’s priority.

CM Rekha launches Delhi Next civic-tech drive, 60 pilots planned

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday launched Delhi Next, described as the country’s largest civic-tech innovation programme, at the Delhi Secretariat. On the occasion, she announced that unlike conventional hackathons, the top 60 selected solutions will be implemented as pilot projects within the relevant Government departments, with successful models then integrated into the Government system in phases so that citizens receive direct benefits.

The programme, titled Code, Create and Change, drew participation from startups, researchers, educational institutions, and young innovators across the country. The initiative aims to develop technology-based solutions for Delhi’s real civic and urban challenges across areas including urban infrastructure, waterlogging, traffic management, smart parking, air

pollution, waste management, the electric vehicle ecosystem, citizen grievance redressal, digital governance, and public services.

The programme ran in three stages. The first stage involved an awareness and outreach campaign that reached more than one crore young people across the country. In the second stage, over 2.5 lakh youth registered for the programme. An expert committee evaluated more than 5,000 technical proposals and shortlisted 1,000 participants for the next round. In the final stage, the top 60 teams gave live demonstrations of their working prototypes before the Chief Minister.

The Chief Minister said the biggest distinction

between Delhi Next and a conventional hackathon is what happens after the competition ends. She said selected solutions will not remain limited to demonstrations or prizes but will proceed to pilot testing with departmental support.

Each of the top 60 teams will be linked with the relevant Government department, mentored by experts, and given a clear roadmap for integrating their solution into the Government system. Each team leaves with a working Minimum Viable Product, a departmental mentor, a pilot implementation plan, and a roadmap for full integration.

The scale of participation distinguishes Delhi Next from most comparable Government-run innovation programmes. Getting 2.5 lakh registrations, 5,000-plus technical proposals, and 60 working prototypes demonstrated live before the Chief Minister at a single event represents a significant mobilisation of young technical talent around civic problems.

Treat failure as learning, not defeat: LG to Oman students

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Thursday hosted a group of young student winners from Oman at Lok Niwas, who had won the Shashtra Pratibha Contest organised by Vijnana Bharati at IIT Gandhinagar. On the occasion, the LG advised them to pursue careers aligned with their genuine interests rather than bending to external societal expectations, and to treat failure as a learning mechanism rather than a defeat.

The interaction centred on the students’ scientific curiosity, spirit of inquiry, and eagerness to learn. Sandhu emphasised that nurturing a strong scientific temper and analytical thinking among young minds is vital to building a solid foundation for research, innovation, and a future-ready society.

On career choices, Sandhu told the students to pursue what brings them genuine happiness rather than what others expect of them. He said their primary focus should be on achieving absolute excel-

lence in whatever field they choose, rather than selecting a path based on social or family pressure.

On skills, the LG stressed that academic knowledge alone is not sufficient in today’s world. He said the rapidly evolving global landscape demands that young people constantly acquire new and relevant skills to remain adaptable and effective throughout their careers. Classroom learning must be matched with practical capability that keeps pace with change, he said.

On failure, Sandhu was direct. He said setbacks should never be feared or treated as defeats. Instead, he described failure as an essential part of any learning process, one that ultimately makes an individual tougher, wiser, and more resilient.

Police trace 193 missing people, including 48 children in June

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

South-West Delhi Police traced and reunited 193 missing persons, including 48 missing or kidnapped children, with their families during June under its ongoing “Operation Milap”, officials said on Thursday.

According to the police, those rescued between June 1 and June 30 comprised 48 children and 145 adults. The district police made the recoveries through coordinated search operations involving local enquiries, analysis of CCTV footage, and extensive fieldwork. Deputy Commissioner of Police (South-West) Amit Goel said police teams displayed “dedication and professionalism” in the process.

The search operations involved circulating photographs of missing persons at bus stands, railway stations, and auto and e-rickshaw stands, as well as making enquiries with bus drivers, conductors, vendors, and local informers. Police also checked records at

nearly police stations and hospitals to establish the missing persons’ movements.

Officials said the district has recovered a total of 866 missing persons so far this year, including 226 children and 640 adults, between January 1 and June 30.

Among individual police stations, the District Missing Persons Unit (DMPU) traced the highest number of adults, recovering 57 missing persons. In contrast, the district’s Anti-Human Trafficking Unit (AHTU) traced 18 missing or kidnapped children. Kapashera police recovered 17 missing persons, including seven children, while Palam Village police traced 17 people, including six children. Vasant Kunj South police recovered 15

missing persons, including six children.

In June, one woman missing since 2019, two women missing since 2021, three persons reported missing in 2022, 16 persons from 2023, 20 adults from 2024, 34 persons from 2025 and 117 persons reported missing in 2026 were traced and reunited with their families.

DCP Goel said Operation Milap reflects the district police’s commitment to public service through compassionate policing and systematic investigation.

“The team’s compassionate approach, coupled with methodical investigations and swift action, brought hope and relief to many grieving families,” he said.

The Pioneer Classified

LOST & FOUND

I, have lost Original Builder Buyer Agreement dated 26.11.2008 and Possession Latter of Flat No. 805, Block B5, Jyoti Super Gardenia, Ahinsa Khand 2, Indrapuram, Ghaziabad 201014 U.P. Finder Please Contact Vibha Rastogi Mob No. 9582115456.

CHANGE OF NAME

It is informed that I, earlier known as Monika Rana (maidenname)/Monika Datta (marriedname) w/o Shri Rahul Datta r/o B-3, Press Enclave, Saket, Delhi have changed my name to Monika Rana Datta and henceforth shall be known by that name.

PD(021)C I, Nand Kishor Verma, Father of No. 15800774W Nk (OFC) Narendra Verma, R/o-Vill- Bafapur (Wafapur) Teh-Ashta Dist- Sehore M.P.- 466116, have changed my name from Nand Kishor Verma to Nand Kishore, vide affidavit dated 02/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(020)C I, Shila Bai, Mother of No.15800774W Nk (OFC) Narendra Verma, R/o- Vill- Bafapur (Wafapur) Teh-Ashta Dist- Sehore M.P.- 466116, have changed my name from Shila Bai to Sheela Bai, vide affidavit dated 02/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(021)C I, No.12964885F Nk Bilal Ahmad Reshi, R/o- Vill + Post- Poshker, Teh- Khag, Dist- Budgam, Jammu & Kashmir- 193411, have changed my daughter’s name from Madiha Bilal to Madiya Bilal, vide affidavit dated 02/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(022)C I, Rahul S/o- Babulal, R/o-VIII + Post- Borkheda Puriya, Teh- Hatpipliya, Dist- Dewas, M.P.- 455223, have changed my son’s name from Vivek to Vivek Prajapati, vide affidavit dated 02/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(023)C

I, No.15449650X Sep Hasmuddin, R/o- Vill- Tajpur Eqpbalpur Urf Kamelpur, PO- Dhanaura, Dist- Amroha, U.P.- 244231, declare that my Father’s name is wrongly written as Jahir Ahamad in my service record, whereas his correct name is Zaheer Ahmad which may be amended accordingly.

PD(024)C

I, No.15449650X Sep Hasmuddin, R/o- Vill- Tajpur Eqpbalpur Urf Kamelpur, PO- Dhanaura, Dist- Amroha, U.P.- 244231, declare that my Mother’s name is wrongly written as Naseem Jhan in my service record, whereas her correct name is Nasimajahan which may be amended accordingly.

PD(025)C I, Santosh Devi, Mother of- No. 15727104K Hav Deepak, R/o- VPO- Kheri Asra, Teh- Jhajjar, Dist- Jhajjar, Haryana- 124104, have changed my name from Santosh Devi to Santosh, vide affidavit dated 02/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(026)C I, Chaudhary Bherabhai Bhimaji, Father of No.15748208Y S/M Chaudhary Maheshkumar Bherabhai, R/o- Vill- Dera, PO- Jalodha, TA- Lakhni, Dist- Banaskantha, Gujarat- 385330, have changed my name from Chaudhary Bherabhai Bhimaji to Chaudhary Bheraji Bhimaji, vide affidavit dated 02/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(027)C I, Chaudhary Vaduben Bherabhai, Mother of No.15748208Y S/M Chaudhary Maheshkumar Bherabhai, R/o- Vill- Dera, PO- Jalodha, TA- Lakhni, Dist- Banaskantha, Gujarat- 385330, have changed my name from Chaudhary Vaduben Bherabhai to Vaduben Bheraji Chaudhary, vide affidavit dated 02/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(028)C

I, No.15417272W Hav (AMB ASST) Sambhu Singh, R/o-Vill: Jamodhi, Post: Jamodhi, Teh: Sasaram, Dist: Rohtas, Bihar- 802212 have changed my Mother’s name in my service record from Ful Kumari Davi to Ful Kumari Devi vide affidavit dated 02/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(029)C

I, Prasadu, Father of No.17015013N Nk Vallapaneni Aneelkumar, R/o- 4-47C, Mundlamuru Mandalam, Boppudivaripalem, PO- Idara, Prakasam, A.P.- 523265, have changed my name from Prasadu to Vallapaneni Prasad, vide affidavit dated 30/06/2026 before SDM Delhi Cantt.

PD(030)C I, Venkata Lakshmi, Mother of No.17015013N Nk Vallapaneni Aneelkumar, R/o- 4-47C, Mundlamuru Mandalam, Boppudivaripalem, PO- Idara, Prakasam, A.P.- 523265, have changed my name from Venkata Lakshmi to Vallapaneni Venkata Lakshmi, vide affidavit dated 30/06/2026 before SDM Delhi Cantt.

PD(031)C I, Partima Davi, W/o No. 15417272W Hav (AMB ASST) Sambhu Singh, R/o-Vill: Jamodhi, Post: Jamodhi, Teh: Sasaram, Dist: Rohtas, Bihar- 802212, have changed my name from Partima Davi to Partima Devi, vide affidavit dated 02/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.13 Classified for Pioneer English Delhi only

PD(032)C I, Sanjay Kumar Sharma S/o Late Sh. Dayanand Sharma R/o 4/1410, Gali No-1, Shalimar Park Bhola Nath Nagar Shahdara Delhi- 110032. Hereby declare that I have changed my name from Sanjay Kumar Sharma to Sanjay Kumar for all purposes. Henceforth Sanjay Kumar Sharma and Sanjay Kumar one and the same person.

PD(033

PUBLIC NOTICE
This is to inform general public that Mr. Anil Kumar Lohia has acquired Property bearing No. B-103 land area measuring 209.03 Sq. Mtrs. comprised in Kharsa No. 1683 & 1684, Situated at Phase-1, in Block-B5, Aaya Nagar Extended (abadi of Aya Nagar Village, New Delhi-47 (Regn. No. 23(ELD); by way of Conveyance Deed dated 14.09.2025, Document No. 2025/11/11529. Now, we are given to understand that above said owner is availing loan on above said property from Axis Finance Ltd. & in case anyone has any objection, the same may be raised within 7 days of this publication to Advocate Atul Sharma or Advocate Pramod Kumar Singh partner of Acculaw Solutions LLP, Office No. 361, Second Floor, Sector-1, Vajshahi, Ghaziabad-201010 or contact:- +91 9603909809 (M)

SOUTH INDIAN Bank
Regional Office-Delhi, 3rd Floor, Plot No.21, 21/1, Pusa Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi -110005, Phone-011 4233 1664/011 4512 8661 email-r/o1008@siib.co.in.

E- AUCTION SALE NOTICE
E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) and 9(1) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.
1. **Mrs. Shri Gangadas Textile Industries Limited**, 7098 Shop no. 1, Jain Market, Guru Nanak Gali, Gandhi Nagar, Delhi- 110 031. Also at: F 224, Focal Point, Phase VIII, Chandigarh Road, Ludhiana, Punjab 141 010. Also at: Ground & First Floor, Property no. 465, Near Sabzi Mandi, Jheel Khurana, Delhi 110 051
2. **M/S GG Fabrics under proprietorship of Mr. Nitin Dawar** at F 224, Focal Point, Phase VIII, Chandigarh Road, Ludhiana Punjab-141 010
3. **Mr. Pankaj Ahuja** 4181, 04 Duragupri Haibowal, Kalan, Ludhiana, Punjab- 141 001
4. **Mrs. Hema Ahuja** 4181, 04 Duragupri Haibowal, Kalan, Ludhiana, Punjab 141 001
5. **Mr. Rakesh Kumar** 7412, Ram Nagar Extension, Krishna Nagar, Delhi 110 051
6. **Mr. Suresh Kumar** 7412, Ram Nagar Extension, Krishna Nagar, Delhi 110 051
7. **Mr. Vinay Dawar** House No. 267, Block A, Rajguru Nagar, Ludhiana, Punjab 141 012
8. **Mr. Nitin Dawar**, House No. 267, Block A, Rajguru Nagar, Ludhiana, Punjab 141 012 (Personal guarantor and legal heir of late Ramesh Kumar).
9. **Mrs. Shivani Kochar**, 742, Ram Nagar Extension, Krishna Nagar, Delhi 110 051, also at: House No.267, Block A, Rajguru Nagar, Ludhiana, Punjab 141012. (Legal heir of late Ramesh Kumar)
10. **Mrs. Savita Dawar**, House No. 267, Block A, Rajguru Nagar, Ludhiana, Punjab 141012, also at: House 504, Block GX, BRS Nagar Extension, Opposite Verka Milk Plant, Ferozpur Road, Ludhiana-141012, also at 742, Ram Nagar Extension, Krishna Nagar, Delhi-110051
Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the borrower/guarantor/ Legal heirs that the below described immovable properties mortgaged to The South Indian Bank Ltd, Branch Vasundhara (Secured Creditor), the Physical Possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of The South Indian Bank Limited (Secured Creditor), will be sold on “as is where is” basis, “as is what is” and “whatever there is” condition on 21-07-2026 for recovery of an amount of Rs.16,92,38,143.26/- (Rupees Sixteen Crore Ninety Two Lakh Thirty Eight Thousand One Hundred Forty Three and Twenty Six Paise Only) as on 18-02-2026, with future interest, costs and expenses etc. thereon, due to The South Indian Bank Limited, Branch Vasundhara (Secured Creditor), from the above mentioned Borrower(s) and guarantor(s).

Item No. 1	
Name of Property Owner	Late Mr. Ramesh Kumar (Now represented by legal heirs Mrs. Savita Dawar, Mr. Vinay Dawar, Mr. Nitin Dawar and Mrs. Shivani Kochar), Mr. Rakesh Kumar and Mr. Suresh Kumar
Description of property	All that Part and Parcel of Freehold Residential Property comprising 50 square yards out of area measuring 100 sq. yds. out of total area measuring 218 sq. yds. out of Kharsa No. 464/362 along with Residential Buildings constructed upon it bearing No. MPL 783/18-A/5 (old), New No. IX/7172 along with all other constructions, improvements, Easementary Rights existing and appurtenant thereon situated at Gaur Nanak Gali, Gandhi Nagar, Village Seelampur, Ilaga Shahdara, Delhi 110 031 owned by Late Ramesh Kumar Dawar (since expired and represented by his legal heirs: Mrs. Savita Dawar, Mr. Vinay Dawar, Mr. Nitin Dawar and Mrs. Shivani Kochar), Mr. Rakesh Kumar and Mr. Suresh Kumar more particularly described under Sale Deed No. 1287 dated 09-05-1989 at SRO - IV, New Delhi/Delhi and Will dated 02-06-1997 bounded on North by Common Passage, South by Other’s property, East by Common wall & Shop No. 7 and West by common wall and shop No. 5
Reserve Price (Net No.1)	Rs. 1,44,50,000/- (Rupees One Crore Forty Four Lakh Fifty Thousand Only)
Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) (Net No.1)	Rs. 14,45,000/- (Rupees Fourteen Lakhs Forty Five Thousand Only) EMD shall be deposited on or before 20.07.2026 till 02.00 PM
Bid Increment amount (Net No.1)	Rs. 10,000/- (Rupees Ten Thousand Only)
Date and time of E-auction (Net No.1)	21.07.2026 from 11:00 AM to 11:30 AM (with 5 minute unlimited auto extensions till sale is concluded)
Encumbrances known to the Bank (Net No.1)	Nil/ Encumbrances from 01.01.2018 to 22.11.2022

For detailed terms and conditions of the sale, please refer to the link provided in web portal of South Indian Bank Ltd. (Secured Creditor) website i.e. www.southindianbank.com. Details also available at https://bankauctions.in. For any further clarification with regards to inspection of property, terms and conditions of the e-auction or submission of bids, kindly contact South Indian Bank Ltd on 9818-772-322 / 7309-655-552 / 9007-046-006 (contact number).

Sd/- AUTHORISED OFFICER

NOTICE
I, Colonel GS Bhandari, ret'd, R/O of J/86, Rajouri Garden, New Delhi - 110027 would like to inform the general public that the original property Sale Deed chain documents, specifically Sale Deed No. 907, Vol 122, Pgs 201-206, dated 06 Apr 1960 and Sale Deed No. 4318, Vol 261, Pgs 29-32, dated 02 May 1955, both registered at the Sub Registrar Office, Janakpuri, New Delhi, pertaining to property J/86 Rajouri Garden, New Delhi, have been lost/misplaced/stolen. FIR No. 39101/12/2026 dated 22 June 2026 and FIR No. 404680/2026 dated 29 June 2026 have been lodged in PS Rajouri Garden. The use of these documents by any person will be illegal. Anyone find it kindly contact me at 8016494111 within 14 days of date of issue of this Notice.

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given on behalf of Smt. Sunita Devi W/o Member Singh Rawat who is purchasing Built-up Property area measuring 25 sq. yds, with terrace/roof rights, out of Kharsa No. 8/18, Situated in the area of Village Kamalpur, Majra Suraj, Present colony known as Shiv Enclave, Vikas Nagar, Hastal, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi-110059, from Mr. Suresh Kumar who had owned the subject property vide Notarized GPA, ATS dated 14.02.2025 executed by Mr. Ashok Pal now Smt. Sunita Devi W/o Member Singh Rawat is intend to purchase the subject property and same to be mortgaged with ADITYA BIRLA HOUSING FINANCE LIMITED So, to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 15 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances. Iencl:- Lucum Legal LLP N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre, New Delhi-110049 Contact # 011-40046316 & 41667327

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given on behalf of Mr. Saraj Verma who is purchasing Second Floor without roof/Terrace Rights of Built-up of Property bearing No. 202, Plot No. 19, Left Side Portion on Front Side, area measuring 73 sq. yds. out of Kharsa No. 117/1, Situated in the revenue estate of Village Palam, Delhi/State Delhi area abadi known as Colony Mahesh Enclave, Part-II, Gali No. 39, New Delhi-110059, from Mrs. Meera who has owned the subject property vide Notarized GPA, ATS dated 25.03.2021 executed by Mr. Bansi Singh and Mr. Saraj Verma is intend to purchase the subject property and same to be mortgaged with ADITYA BIRLA HOUSING FINANCE LIMITED So, to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 15 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances. Iencl:- Lucum Legal LLP N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre, New Delhi-110049 Contact # 011-40046316 & 41667327

KONKAN RAILWAY CORPORATION LIMITED
(A Government of India Undertaking)
E-TENDER NOTICE
Principal Chief Signal & Telecom Engineer invites E-Tender bids from Eligible bidders for **E-Tender Notice No: KR-CO-SG-ET-2026-01, dated: 03.07.2026. Name of work:** Leasing of Dark fibers of Konkan Railway between Kolad To Thokur station along Konkan Railway route for Three years. **Last date & time for submission of bids:** 27/07/2026 up to 16:00 hrs. **Minimum reserve price for single pair of dark fiber:** Rs.87,91,200/- (Excl. GST). For further details please visit: www.ireps.gov.in

BABA FARID UNIVERSITY OF HEALTH SCIENCES
SADIO ROAD, FARIDKOT (PUNJAB) -151203 Ph-01639-256232,256236
COMPETENCY BASED ULTRASONOGRAPHY TEST-2026
Fresh online applications are invited for Competency based Ultrasonography Test through University website upto 30/7/2026 from the doctors who have completed six month ultra-sonography training from recognized medical colleges of Punjab under PC PNDD (Prohibition of sex selection) (Six months Training) Amendment Rules 2020. The date for conduct of test and practical exam will be notified later through university website i.e. www.bfuhs.ac.in
REGISTRAR
31/08/12/2026-27/12/873 Dated CHD 11- 02/07/2026
Dr. Girish Chandra Sharma

Delhi Police bust alleged ISI terror module, 4 arrested

KHUSHI MEHROTRA
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police's Special Cell foiled a suspected Pakistan-backed terror plot in the national Capital by arresting four alleged operatives linked to an inter-state arms and terror network. Investigators said the accused, three arrested in Punjab and one in Delhi, were allegedly working at the behest of Pakistan-based ISI handler Shahzad Bhatti and had procured weapons and used foreign phone numbers to evade detection.

Police alleged that one of the accused had conducted reconnaissance of police establishments and religious places in Delhi and had been tasked with carrying out a firing incident in the city. The accused have been identified as Shubdeep Singh alias Vishal (23) and Gurjant Singh alias Rishi (22), both residents

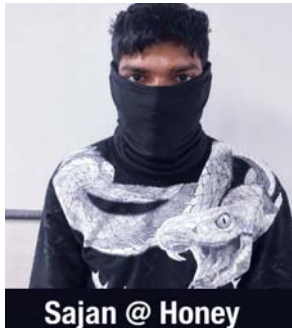


of Tarn Taran district; Sajjan Singh alias Honey (28) of Amritsar district; and Gaganpreet (24) of Fatehgarh Sahib district in Punjab.

According to the Special Cell, the operation was carried out by a team led by Inspectors Satish Rana and Ashok under the supervision of ACP Vivek Kumar Tyagi, following specific intelligence inputs that Pakistan's Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI), through handler Shahzad

Bhatti and his associates, was recruiting youth from Punjab to execute a terror strike in Delhi-NCR.

Police said sustained technical surveillance and multiple raids in Delhi and Punjab led to the arrests. The first breakthrough came with Shubdeep Singh's arrest from Majitha Road in Amritsar, from whose possession police recovered a semi-automatic pistol, five live cartridges and two mobile



Sajjan @ Honey



Gaganpreet



Rishi



Shubdeep

phones. During interrogation, Shubdeep allegedly disclosed that he was in direct contact with Pakistan-based handlers of the Shahzad Bhatti network and had been receiving consignments of firearms and narcotics dropped by drones from across the international border. Investigators said he used foreign phone numbers supplied by his Pakistani handlers to avoid detection. Police added that

he had previously been arrested by Punjab Police in a case under the NDPS Act.

Acting on his disclosures, police arrested Gurjant Singh and his cousin Sajjan Singh from Punjab. A Zigana pistol, four live cartridges and two mobile phones were allegedly recovered from their possession. According to investigators, the duo was also in touch with Pakistani handlers through foreign numbers and received arms

and narcotics consignments sent through drones.

The investigation subsequently led to Gaganpreet's arrest in Delhi. Police said a mobile phone containing incriminating material was recovered from him. He was allegedly instructed by Pakistani handlers through social media to conduct reconnaissance of religious places, police stations and police pickets in Delhi. He was assigned the task of car-

rying out a firing incident in the capital.

In all, police recovered two foreign-made pistols, a Zigana pistol and a .30 bore pistol, nine live cartridges and five mobile phones from the accused. A case has been registered under the relevant provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and the Arms Act.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (Special Cell) Praveen Kumar Tripathi said the

arrests exposed an ISI-sponsored inter-state terror and arms network that was allegedly attempting to recruit youth and infiltrate weapons into India through drones for terror-related activities.

The latest arrests come just over a month after Delhi Police claimed to have busted an alleged Pakistan ISI-underworld terror module and arrested eight people, including a Nepali national, who were allegedly planning attacks on vital installations, security establishments and police personnel in Delhi, Mumbai, Chandigarh and Punjab. Police said the eight accused were apprehended in a coordinated multi-state operation that uncovered a conspiracy allegedly orchestrated by Pakistan's ISI in collaboration with underworld operatives and the network of Shahzad Bhatti.

DU begins Phase II UG admission process; deadline July 11

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi University will commence Phase II of its undergraduate admission through the Common Seat Allocation System (CSAS) portal on Friday, allowing candidates to fill their college and programme preferences ahead of the first seat allocation list on July 16.

According to the admission schedule released by the university, candidates who have completed Phase I registration will be able to participate in Phase II from July 3 until 11.59 pm on July 11.

The first CSAS allocation list will be announced at 5 pm on July 16. Candidates allotted seats must accept them between July 16 and July 18, while colleges will verify and approve applications by July 20. The last date for payment of admission fees under the first round is July 21.

DU dean of admissions Haneet Gandhi clarified that during this period, students will be able to fill in their college and programme preferences. A correction window will remain open from 10 am on July 10 to 11.59 pm on July 11, during which



candidates can make changes in their registration details, if required.

The university will declare simulated ranks at 5 pm on July 12, following which candidates can modify their programme and college preferences until 4.59 pm on July 13. The second allocation list will be released at noon on July 25. Candidates can accept their allotted seats until July 26, while colleges will complete verification by July 27. The fee payment deadline for the second round is July 28.

The university said it is offering admissions to 73 bachelor's programmes and 150 BA programme combinations for the 2026-27 academic session.

Under Phase II, candidates will be required to map the subjects studied in Class XII

with the corresponding CUET (UG)-2026 test papers. The university said appearing in CUET (UG)-2026 in subjects similar or closely related to those studied in Class XII is mandatory for admission.

"For admission to University of Delhi, it is mandatory for the candidate to appear in CUET(UG)-2026 in those subjects in which(she) has passed class XII," the DU notification mentioned.

Candidates will also be required to submit their programme and college preferences in order of priority. They may choose as many programme-college combinations as they are eligible for and can revise their preferences during the preference-filling correction window before the deadline.

"Upon reaching the dead-

line of Phase II, the saved preferences will automatically get locked and will be used for allocations," the notice said.

The university said candidates who submit admission fees within the stipulated period of a round will have the option to "upgrade" or "freeze" their allotted seat. Those opting for an upgrade will be allowed to reorder their higher preferences until the prescribed deadline for that admission round.

"The last saved preferences will get auto-locked at 11.59 pm Tuesday, July 21, 2026. Similarly, for Round 2, the reorder option will close at 11.59 pm, Tuesday, July 28, 2026," it mentioned.

Delhi University has advised candidates to regularly check the admission portal for updates regarding admission status, schedules and announcements.

This comes after a DU notification informed that the new academic session 2026-27 is set to begin on July 28. According to a university notification issued on July 1, the calendar will apply to all UG and PG programmes and is to be followed by all concerned.

Capital to get first underground CBRN command centre for disasters

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi is set to get its first underground Chemical, Biological, Radiological and Nuclear (CBRN) command centre at the new headquarters of the Delhi Fire Services, a first-of-its-kind facility aimed at significantly strengthening the capital's preparedness for nuclear emergencies, chemical disasters and large-scale crises.

A tender has been floated for the project, inviting bids for the construction of the new Delhi Fire Services (DFS) headquarters and the creation of specialised emergency-response infrastructure. The proposed headquarters will house a plug-and-play underground CBRN command centre designed to remain operational during nuclear warfare, radiological leaks or chemical disasters.

Chief Fire Officer Abhilash Malik said that the facility would be specially engineered to shield personnel from nuclear radiation and ensure uninterrupted coordination among multiple agen-



cies during emergencies.

"This will be the first such CBRN command centre in the national capital. It is being designed in a way that radiation will not affect personnel inside, enabling effective command and coordination during critical situations," Malik said.

He added that during disasters, the command centre would coordinate operations at the city's three existing disaster centres at Nehru Place, Laxmi Nagar and Rohini, besides guiding the DFS Search and Rescue battalion.

The facility will be built at the site of the existing DFS headquarters and is expected to be completed within five years. A senior police

officer said, "The fire department is always at the forefront during any major disaster, whether it is extinguishing fires, carrying out rescue operations or supporting multiple agencies in managing large-scale emergencies."

He added that the creation of a dedicated CBRN command centre is a significant step towards strengthening Delhi's preparedness for chemical, biological, radiological and nuclear incidents. "Such a facility will enhance coordination, improve response time and ensure that the fire services can provide critical operational support to all stakeholder agencies during high-risk situations," the officer said.

Delhi Discoms BRPL, BYPL, TPDDL operate as 51:49 joint ventures between private players and Govt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi discoms — BSES Rajdhani Power Limited (BRPL), BSES Yamuna Power Limited (BYPL) and Tata Power Delhi Distribution Limited (TPDDL) — are joint venture companies, held on a 51:49 basis between the private promoters and the Government of Delhi (GoNCTD). The Delhi Government is a 49 per cent owner all these three companies.

The three discoms power around 7.5 million consumers across the national capital. Over close to 25 years, the discoms have emerged among India's best-performing distribution utilities — delivering a record reduction in AT&C losses, alongside sustained improvements in reliability, consumer service and operational efficiency.

The Government of Delhi over the years has maintained direct representation on the Boards of these companies through its senior functionaries, including the Chief Secretary, the Finance Secretary and the Power Secretary. Every material decision of the companies is taken by the respective Boards comprising nominees of Delhi Government.

The accounts of these discoms have been audited by CAG-empowered auditors for close to 25 years. These auditors are appointed by the respective Boards and the DERC is informed of these appointments. The companies' finances are under full regulatory scrutiny.

Power distribution is a highly regulated business with robust checks and balances. All financial and operational aspects of the discoms are subject to the continuous oversight of DERC and other statutory authorities. As responsible



organisations, Delhi discoms adhere to the highest standards of corporate governance, accountability, integrity and transparency.

The CAG will undertake a "strict and intensive" audit of the circumstances under which discoms — BSES Rajdhani Power Ltd (BRPL), BSES Yamuna Power Limited (BYPL) and Tata Power Delhi Distribution (TPDDL) — have continued without recovery of regulatory assets, according to an order issued by the Power Department of the Delhi Government on Wednesday. This is the first time that the power discoms will go through a CAG audit in Delhi since the privatisation of electricity distribution in 2002, if they do not take legal recourse. An earlier attempt at a CAG audit of discoms by the then AAP Government was thwarted by the High Court in 2015.

RAs refer to deferred expenses borne by the discoms out of changes in fuel costs. These are determined as the gap between the average cost of supply by the discoms and the revenue collected by them through tariffs and subsidies.

The Delhi Cabinet, in its meeting chaired by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on June 29, recommended, in public interest, "a strict and intensive" CAG audit of the circumstances in which the discoms have continued without recovery of the regulatory assets, said the order.

MCD plans citywide dog survey through microchipping under rabies-free roadmap

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) is mulling a citywide survey of dogs through microchipping and expansion of its sterilisation infrastructure under a four-year roadmap aimed at making the capital rabies-free.

The proposed microchipping exercise, scheduled to begin in a few weeks, is intended to establish the actual population of dogs in Delhi, which officials said is crucial for planned sterilisation, anti-rabies vaccination, and effective monitoring of programmes.

Senior MCD officials said the civic body is in advanced discussions with a non-Governmental organisation (NGO) to carry out the large-scale microchipping exercise, adding that the selected NGO will use CSR funds to conduct the drive. Estimates of expenses and methodology for the survey have also been sought from the said NGO.

"If the task is taken up by the NGO, it will save funds of the corporation, which will be further used to strengthen veterinary services across the city," a senior official said.

The number of specialised agencies which can undertake such a broad exercise is low, which has resulted in stalling of the process, officials said, adding that the civic body is preparing a tender for the exercise, which may be floated in a month.

According to officials, the last time MCD conducted a dog survey was in 2016, when the exercise was carried out in four administrative zones (South, West, Central and West) under the erstwhile South Delhi Corporation and roughly 1,90,000 dogs were enumerated.

Senior officials from the veterinary department said the current dog population in the capital is likely to be around 10 lakh or more.

The civic body also plans to significantly expand its Animal Birth Control (ABC) infrastructure by increasing kennel capacity and setting up new centres across the city to step up sterilisation and immunisation of stray dogs, officials said.

According to official data, the MCD has sterilised and immunised 1,31,137 dogs during 2024-25. The number stood at 1,01,394 in 2025-26.

In the current financial year,



16,124 dogs have been sterilised and immunised till May, with 7,972 procedures carried out in April, and 8,152 in May.

Officials said new kennels are under construction at the Bijwasan, Bela Road, Rohini and Usmanpur ABC centres. The expansion at Bijwasan will double the capacity of the facility.

At Bela Road, 35 new kennels are being built over the existing capacity of around 850 dogs, while 45 new kennels are under construc-

tion at Rohini, which currently has a capacity of around 1,700 dogs. Another 35 kennels are being added at Usmanpur, where the existing capacity is around 1,200-1,300 dogs, officials said, adding that the expansion is expected to double the capacity.

According to officials, the ABC centre at Prahladpur, with a capacity of 600-750 dogs, has received in-principle approval from the Delhi Government and is expected to be taken over by the Government.

Ghaziabad man held for sending hoax bomb threat emails to NIA, ISRO, DRDO

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police have apprehended a Ghaziabad man in connection with a series of hoax bomb threat emails sent to several organisations, including the NIA, ISRO, DRDO and an Air India flight, officials said on Thursday.

The 36-year-old has been undergoing treatment for mental illness since 2008, they said.

The emails, sent on June 29, claimed the presence of bombs at multiple high-security establishments, including the headquarters of the National Investigation



Agency (NIA), Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO), Nuclear Power Corporation of India Limited (NPCIL), Defence Research and Development

Organisation (DRDO) and the Ministry of Civil Aviation (MoCA), the officials said.

A threat email was also sent for an Air India flight operating from New Delhi to

New York, triggering immediate security checks and alerting multiple agencies.

The police said all organisations concerned and security agencies were informed and standard safety protocols were followed, and the threats were found to be a hoax.

Following the incident, an inquiry was initiated by the police, which tracked the digital trail of the emails.

During the technical investigation, the police analysed two mail accounts suspected to have been used to send the emails.

A detailed examination of the email trail led investigators to a mobile number

linked to the accounts, officials said.

Using technical surveillance, the police team traced the suspect to Sanyog Nagar in Uttar Pradesh's Ghaziabad on June 30.

The police reached the location and examined the suspect, identified as Nishant Tyagi, at his residence, they said.

According to the police, Tyagi had pursued his education through open schooling and had enrolled in a bachelor's degree programme in 2010 but did not complete it.

During preliminary inquiry, it emerged that he had allegedly been suffering

from a mental illness since 2008 and had been undergoing treatment at various medical institutions over the years.

His family members also informed the police about his prolonged medical history, officials said.

The police said no explosives or suspicious materials were recovered during the inquiry.

The investigation is underway to ascertain the motive behind the emails and the circumstances under which they were sent.

Further legal action will be taken based on the outcome of the probe, the police added.

IN FOCUS



Rainbow stretches across the sky over the mountains following rain in Kullu

PTI

After WhatsApp, MeitY notice to Telegram, Signal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

After sending a notice to Meta-owned WhatsApp, the IT Ministry has now shot off notices to Telegram and Signal, raising questions on their existing username feature and asking how the platforms are addressing concerns related to fraud and impersonation risks, according to a source.

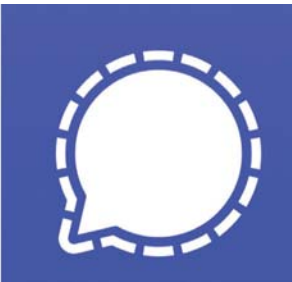
The source said that in the notice to Telegram, the government has asked the platform why it should be allowed to have the username feature.

The feature allows users to create unique usernames that can be used for connecting on the platform without sharing phone numbers.



On Wednesday, the Centre issued a notice to Meta over the username feature announced for WhatsApp, citing concerns that it could materially increase online fraud, phishing, digital arrest scams, and impersonation attacks.

It had also directed WhatsApp to pause the feature until consultations on the issue are completed 'to



the satisfaction of the Government'.

The government has now widened its scrutiny to other messaging platforms as well.

The source told PTI that the IT ministry has also written to Telegram and Signal - which already have the username feature - and asked how concerns around fraud and impersonation are being addressed by them.

"Government has asked Telegram why the feature should be there," the source said. Telegram and Signal could not be reached for their comments.

Meanwhile, Zoho-backed homegrown messaging platform Arattai will be disabling the username-based account feature "to comply with the regulatory change", according to a X post by prominent Indian founder Sridhar Vembu.

The government source added that the two cases are similar, but not identical. Telegram already has the feature in place, while WhatsApp has only announced it. The user bases also differ significantly, with India being WhatsApp's largest market.

Power tariffs to remain unchanged in UP: Govt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

The electricity tariffs will remain unchanged across all consumer categories for the seventh consecutive year in 2026-27, Uttar Pradesh Energy Minister A K Sharma said on Thursday.

In a statement, Sharma said the tariff order for 2026-27 issued by the Uttar Pradesh Electricity Regulatory Commission reflected the state government's pro-consumer approach and would benefit domestic consumers, farmers and other electricity users. He said the state government has increased the electricity tariff subsidy to Rs 20,400 crore for 2026-27 from Rs 17,100 crore in the previous financial year. The subsidy will benefit lifeline consumers, rural and urban poor families, private tube



UP Energy Minister AK Sharma

well operators and rural metered consumers, he said. The minister said the tariff order also retained the existing green energy additional tariff and introduced provisions for battery swapping stations and Battery as a Service (BAAS) providers. Electricity supplied to EV charging stations during solar hours between 9 am and 4 pm will attract a 20 per cent lower tariff to encourage electric mobility and cleaner energy adoption, he added.

Delhi BJP condemns demolition of historic Gurudwara in Pakistan



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi BJP leaders and state president Harsh Mahotra on Thursday condemned the "demolition" of a historic Gurudwara in Pakistan and criticised the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) for remaining silent on the issue.

Mahotra said in a statement that the demolition of the Gurdwara in Pakistan is "highly condemnable" and charged that the "silence" of the AAP government in Punjab on the issue is another "proof of its disregard" for Sikh values and traditions. He said the Gurudwara Shri Guru Singh Sabha in Farukhabad, Pakistan, was "demolished" during the night of June 24-25. The BJP leader said this is not an isolated incident, as attacks on Sikhs, Hindus, Christians, and their places of worship have unfortunately become a recurring occurrence in Pakistan. Delhi government minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa

condemned the attack on the religious place, stating that the 125-year-old Gurudwara in Pakistan was "demolished" overnight. "Occupation of Gurdwaras in Pakistan, encroachments on their properties, thereby damaging their heritage, is a grave sin. The world must take notice of this, and the Pakistan government must restore the Gurdwara Sahib," Sirsa said.

Arvinder Singh Lovely, a Sikh leader of the BJP and chairman of the Trans Yamuna Area Development Board, said while Pakistan pretends to be a saviour of minorities worldwide, it has failed to safeguard minorities and their religious places.

"What has happened in Pakistan is also a violation of UNESCO norms," he said.

Lovely said the Narendra Modi government took prompt cognisance of the matter and conveyed a "strong message" to the Pakistan government and called for its reconstruction.

Lawyers seek FIR against Ram Temple Trust functionaries, hold protests

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ayodhya

On Thursday, lawyers from the Faizabad Bar Association held a protest march and filed a police complaint. They asked for an FIR against Ram Mandir Trust general secretary Champat Rai, trust member Anil Mishra, and temple official Gopal Rao, accusing them of misusing donation funds.

According to Faizabad Bar Association president Kalika Prasad Mishra, Krishna Mohan, the trustee who filed the first FIR, has now also been named as an accused in the lawyers' new complaint.

The lawyers walked from the court to the Ram Janambhoomi police station to submit their complaint. They demanded that a case be registered and called for a fair and impartial investigation into the



allegations. A large number of lawyers raised slogans demanding an FIR and an investigation into the Trust's senior functionaries.

Earlier, the bar association said it would not defend the accused in this case. They also warned that any lawyer who chose to represent them would have to pay a penalty of ₹5 lakh for each accused person.

During the march, police strug-

gled to control the crowd. Some lawyers said they suffered minor injuries in the pushing and shoving.

At the police station, several lawyers gathered in the Station House Officer's office with media personnel, insisting that a case be registered immediately, while police officials tried to pacify them by assuring that the complaint would be examined and appropriate action taken in accordance with the law. Mishra told reporters that the association had requested an FIR against the three people named in the complaint for allegedly misusing donations to the Ram Temple. He also called for an impartial investigation. Rao is involved in building the temple and works with the trust. "A written complaint has been submitted. Five people have gone to collect the hard copy. If they do

not provide it, the protest will continue. The police have said that action will be taken and have given full assurance. The FIR includes Champat Rai, Anil Mishra, Gopal Rao, and Krishna Dev (the complainant in the first FIR)."

He said the association would start a protest, but the police did not file a case against the accused. Superintendent of Police (City) Chakrapani Tripathi said the police have received the complaint and are looking into it. Later, police said the case was entered in the General Diary (GD) at the Ram Janambhoomi police station, and an acknowledgement was given. A police officer said the complaint is being reviewed in accordance with the law and that appropriate action will be taken. If it is found to be warranted but is not registered, action

would also be taken against the officials concerned at the police station. A GD is the police station's official record for proceedings. Activist Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav alleged embezzlement of donations at the Ram temple. The Special Investigation Team (SIT) set up in Uttar Pradesh gave its initial report on June 23.

After that, people involved in counting temple donations said he was taking "moral responsibility." Security has been increased at important places, including Rai. A security official said deployment had been strengthened at the Teerth Kshetra office, Karsavakpuram, and other important places linked to the Trust. Four sub-inspectors have been posted in Karsavakpuram and other important places linked to the Trust.

Meghalaya recorded 32 crore digital transactions in 2025-26: Official

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Shillong

Meghalaya recorded 32.76 crore digital transactions and nearly 10 lakh Jan Dhan accounts during 2025-26, officials said on Thursday.

RBI Shillong General Manager Olden Nongpluh said the Jan Dhan-Aadhaar-Mobile (JAM) Trinity, Direct Benefit Transfer and Digital Public Infrastructure have significantly expanded banking access, improved transparency and accelerated digital adoption across the country.

Participating in a panel discussion, he said 98 per



cent of bank account holders in Meghalaya have adopted at least one digital mode of transaction, while efforts are underway to achieve universal and meaningful digital adoption.

SBI Deputy General Manager Ejaz Ahmad said the state had 9.99 lakh

Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana accounts as on March 31, 2026, with SBI accounting for 3.55 lakh, or 36 per cent, of the total.

He said enrolment under the Centre's social security schemes has also grown, with 5.08 lakh beneficiaries under the Pradhan Mantri Jeevan Jyoti Bima Yojana, 9.36 lakh under the Pradhan Mantri Suraksha Bima Yojana and 1.02 lakh under the Atal Pension Yojana.

India recorded 21,860 crore digital transactions during 2025-26, while Meghalaya accounted for 32.76 crore transactions, Ahmad said.

Haryana chief electoral officer asks political parties to support SIR exercise

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

Haryana Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) A Sreenivas on Thursday urged all recognised national and state political parties to hold meetings between their booth level agents (BLAs) and booth level officers (BLOs) to ensure the smooth conduct of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in the state.

Chairing a meeting with the representatives of political parties here, Sreenivas said the parties should inform election authorities in advance about the date and time of such meetings and ensure proper videography and photography of the proceedings.

He said the SIR will continue till July 14 while the final electoral rolls will be published on September 22.

Sreenivas said the BLOs have been instructed to visit every household where enumeration forms have not been received at least three times. If the forms are still not available, the BLOs will verify the status through neighbours and record the reason as "absent", "shifted", "deceased" or "duplicate", as applicable. To ensure transparency, booth-wise lists of voters whose names are not included in the draft electoral rolls, along with the reasons for their exclusion,



will be displayed at Panchayat Bhawans, urban local body offices and block development and panchayat officer (BDPO) offices. The lists will also be uploaded on the websites of the CEO and the concerned district election officers (DEOs).

The CEO said the BLOs have also been directed to carry 30 to 40 blank Form-6 applications and declaration forms during door-to-door visits to facilitate the enrolment of eligible new voters. Referring to the Representation of the People Act, 1950, Sreenivas said no person can be registered as an elector in more than one constituency.

He said BLAs may also collect enumeration forms from voters and submit them to the concerned BLOs.

He said if a voter has permanently shifted due to employment, marriage or any other reason, a family member may return the enumeration form to the concerned BLO.

If the voter is not available

during the house-to-house survey, any adult member of the family may sign the form and hand it over to the BLO.

Sreenivas said electors who have permanently shifted, are deceased or fall under other prescribed categories will not be included in the draft electoral roll prepared during the revision.

He said Haryana conducted an SIR of electoral rolls the last time in 2002.

The enumeration forms can be downloaded from the official website and a dedicated 1950 helpline has been set up at all district headquarters and assembly constituencies.

The helpline will function from 7 am to 9 pm in two shifts. Giving an update on the exercise, the CEO said Haryana has 2,06,55,929 registered electors, of whom 75,63,762 enumeration forms have already been digitised.

He said 20,629 BLOs are engaged in the exercise, with each BLO covering an average of 1,028 electors.

Government brings stem cell, gene therapies under CLAA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The government has amended the Drugs Rules, 1945, to bring cell or stem cell-derived products, gene therapeutic products and xenografts under the Centrally Licensed Approving Authority (CLAA) framework, a move aimed at strengthening regulatory oversight of advanced and emerging medical technologies.

Under the Drugs and Cosmetics Act, certain categories of critical drugs and biological products are



subject to the joint regulatory supervision of the central and state regulators. These include vaccines, large volume parenterals and r-DNA-based medicines.

This set is being expanded with this amendment to cover additional emerging technologies, according to a statement by the health ministry. Cell or stem cell-derived products, including stem cell-based regenerative treatments and CAR-T cell therapies, are increasingly being used to treat blood cancers such as leukaemia and lymphoma.

Gene therapeutic products, such as gene replacement and gene editing products, are used in the treatment of genetic disorders and various types of cancers.

Xenografts are animal tissue-derived products, such as heart valves, which can be transplanted into humans and are used in cardiology and orthopaedics. As these technologies are highly complex, specialised and rapidly evolving, they need enhanced regulatory scrutiny to ensure patient safety, the statement said.

The inclusion of these products under the CLAA framework will facilitate a system of joint oversight by the central and state licensing authorities, thereby ensuring uniformity in regu-

latory standards across the country, it said. The amendment will increase regulatory rigour for emerging technologies and reinforce India's regulatory framework in line with scientific advancements and global best practices, the ministry said.

This initiative reflects the government's continued commitment towards safeguarding public health while promoting innovation and quicker adoption of the latest technologies in healthcare and life sciences sectors, it said.

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Takaichi, who is on a three-day visit to India, said Japan was committed to strengthening economic growth through investment and innovation.

"I am committed to realising a strong economy and enhancing Japan's supply chain and technological capabilities through investment in 17 strategic areas," she said.

Referring to Modi's vision of Viksit Bharat 2047, Takaichi said India and Japan shared the goal of building strong and prosperous nations through investments in the future.

"Prime Minister Modi launched Viksit Bharat, a national goal to make India a developed nation by 2047 and is strongly driving India's growth. In this way, we share the goal of making our countries strong and prosperous through investments in the future," she said.

India-Japan ties have witnessed significant expansion over the past decade. The relationship was elevated to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014 and now spans trade, investment, economic security, defence, science and technology, culture and people-to-people exchanges. As the two countries prepare to celebrate the 75th anniversary of diplomatic relations in 2027, the bilateral framework has expanded to include more than 70 dialogue mechanisms.

Modi last visited Japan for the 15th India-Japan Annual Summit in Tokyo in August last year. The annual summit continues to serve as the flagship platform for advancing the strategic partnership between the two countries.

Shah, Nabin discuss BJP reset ahead of Cabinet...

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman who is travelling abroad will be back on the same day. Sources in the BJP said there is growing view within the Government's top brass that key ministries require fresh blood.

Party sources further said more representatives from Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand and Punjab are likely to be inducted into the ministry, with Assembly elections due in these states next year.

Following the BJP's landslide victory in West Bengal, some of the party's MPs from the State could also be accommodated in the Union Council of Ministers. According to the sources, representatives from the rebel AAP, TMC and Shinde led Shiv Sena group are also likely to figure in the Union Council of Ministers.

Monsoon finally arrives in Delhi, ending weeks...

The first spell of rain, accompanied by strong winds on Tuesday night, brought significant relief from the intense heat. Cooler conditions persisted through Wednesday and into Thursday, raising expectations that the monsoon could arrive in Delhi soon.

The weather department expects monsoon activity to stay active over Delhi and much of northwest India for the next several days. A favourable monsoon trough, the elongated low-pressure zone that draws moisture-laden winds inland, is in place, and a fresh low-pressure area is likely to form over the northwest Bay of Bengal around July 3. Together, these are expected to support widespread rainfall across northern India in the days ahead.

The IMD said the monsoon has now advanced across the national capital along with large parts of northwestern India, while extremely heavy rainfall is expected to continue over Maharashtra, Goa, Konkan, south Gujarat and parts of central India over the next several days.



ED attaches ₹58 crore assets in Bhushan Steel case

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate's (ED) Delhi office has provisionally attached movable and immovable properties worth about ₹58.34 crore in the name of Ritu Singal, who is the wife of Neeraj Singal, the former promoter and Managing Director (MD) of Bhushan Steel Ltd.

The attachment, ordered under the Prevention of Money Laundering (PMLA) Act, 2002, covers land and part of a residential property in Indore, Madhya Pradesh, as well as equity shares and bank balances. With this step, the total value of attached assets in the case has reached about ₹481.72 crore.

This action is part of an ongoing investigation into an alleged bank fraud involving loans of ₹46,000 to ₹56,000 crore given to Bhushan Steel by public sector banks, mainly State Bank of India and Punjab National Bank.

The ED alleges that the promoters diverted funds



through fraudulent means, resulting in significant losses to the lenders. Investigations found that Neeraj Singal and his associates allegedly set up about 150 shell companies to move funds through complicated chains. The money was then used to inject artificial capital into Bhushan Steel, buy properties, and divert funds for personal use.

The ED has pointed to cases of forged documents and fake letters of credit that banks discounted, with the money then sent back to group companies or moved through family members and proxies. Ritu Singal's name has come up before in the investigation. The ED claims

that large sums, including money taken from Bhushan Steel, were sent to her through associates such as Archana Ajay Mittal and her husband, Ajay S Mittal, who were arrested in January 2024 for allegedly handling about ₹80 crore in proceeds of crime. Properties held under false names or through dummy directors were also previously attached to prevent their concealment.

In March 2024, the ED attached assets worth about ₹367 crore linked to Bhushan Steel and related companies in Delhi, Mumbai, Kolkata, and Odisha. Earlier, ₹61 crore was seized in 2021. The latest order focuses on

assets held directly by Ritu Singal in Indore. Neeraj Singal was arrested by the ED in June 2023 and remained in custody until the Supreme Court granted him bail in September 2024, citing prolonged detention and trial delays. His mother, Uma Singal, and other family members have also been investigated.

Under the PMLA provisions, provisional attachments must be confirmed by an adjudicating authority and may result in confiscation upon conviction. The ED says these steps are intended to prevent accused individuals from benefiting from alleged crimes.

"The case began with complaints from the Serious Fraud Investigation Office (SFIO) and related CBI FIRs, and is still under investigation.

The total attachments of over ₹481 crore underscore the magnitude of the alleged diversion of public funds and highlight the agency's ongoing efforts to recover the money through legal means", an ED official said

BJP accuses Priyanka Gandhi, Robert Vadra of attempting to grab land in Uttarakhand

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Thursday claimed that Congress leader Priyanka Gandhi Vadra and her husband Robert Vadra were involved in an alleged attempt to grab a four-acre land parcel in Uttarakhand, where a 90-year-old woman was being threatened to vacate the property.

Addressing a press conference here, BJP national spokesperson Pradeep Bhandari alleged that the Gandhi-Vadra family's real business was not politics



Pradeep Bhandari

but "grabbing people's land".

He said Robert Vadra's sister-in-law Saira Vadra is trying to take possession of the four-acre land at Kichha in Udhham Singh Nagar district of Uttarakhand. The original land

lease is in the name of late Kulsum Khan, and the property is currently occupied by her 90-year-old sister, Nasreen.

Bhandari said Congress MLA from Kichha, Tilak Raj Behar, arrived at the property with around 100 supporters late on Wednesday night and threatened Nasreen Khan with dire consequences if she did not vacate the land. Congress leaders intimidate the occupant when legal routes fail, he alleged. "When they realised that Saira Vadra could not get possession of the land through the legal route, they

intimidated the occupant. She (Saira Vadra) is the front, while Priyanka Vadra and Robert Vadra are behind her," the BJP leader claimed.

Bhandari said the elderly woman has accused Congress workers of trying to get the property handed over to the Vadra family.

"This is not my allegation. Nasreen Khan herself said that Congress workers came to her farm to get possession of her property and hand it over to the Vadra family. She has named the Vadra family, not just Saira Vadra," he said.

Every country is paying more attention to India: Argentine envoy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Argentine Ambassador to India Mariano Caucino has said that every diplomatic conversation today starts by mentioning the unpredictability and changing times we are living in, but at the same time to certain extent some certainties arise on the global stage and one of them is the rising importance of Asia and the Indo-Pacific.

Speaking at the India-Latin American & Caribbean Business & Diplomatic Conference at the FIEO Auditorium, Ambassador Caucino affirmed that "It is in this scenario in which India is growing so much that it has become one of the most important countries in the world today" and remarked that "every country



is paying more and more attention to India, the world's largest country in terms of population".

Praising links between Argentina and India, the envoy reminded that "in 1950 we established a sitting embassy here, we were among the first Latin American countries to do it.

"In 2009 we opened a General Consulate in Mumbai, India's main economic and financial hub, and in 2019 we elevated the relationship to the rank of Strategic Partnership and Argentina opened an Agriculture Office in Delhi under the leadership of Agriculture Attache Mariano

Beheran," he stated.

Ambassador Caucino stated that we are convinced that Argentina in particular and South America in general can contribute even more to India's development ambitions. "The Indian government has established the goal of becoming a fully developed economy by 2047 and in order to achieve that objective it has been doing a tremendous effort of opening and diversifying," the Ambassador said.

Ambassador Caucino noted that India has emerged as Argentina's sixth-largest trading partner, reflecting the rapid growth of bilateral commerce and cooperation. "Although we are very far away countries, we are destined to continue collaborating for our mutual benefit," he remarked.

Wish had antidote for insecurities of individuals, institutions: Manish Tewari

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Ignored in the Punjab Congress reshuffle for the upcoming assembly polls, Congress leader Manish Tewari on Thursday put out a cryptic post on social media and wished he had an antidote for the "insecurities of individuals" and "institutions".

The Chandigarh MP, however, asserted that the Congress has given him enough over the past 45 years and he has also devoted his entire adult life in the service of the party.

Tewari shared in a post a media report which stated that he was "left in the cold" as Congress appointed new working presidents and set up poll panels for Punjab.

"Hai bada koi avgun usme jise koi hunar aave" (If a person is talented, then society and people usually pick a fault in him). Wish I had an antidote for the insecurities of individuals and institutions! Tewari posted, without elaborating. "Having said that @INCIndia has given me enough over



the past 45 years and I have also devoted my entire adult life in the service of the Indian National Congress over the decades," the former Union minister said.

"Que sera, sera, Whatever will be, will be," he added.

The Congress on Wednesday appointed former Punjab chief minister Charanjit Singh Channi as chairman of the party's Campaign Committee ahead of 2027 assembly elections in the state and said there will be no change in the state unit president or CLP leader.

The party also appointed former deputy chief minister Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa as chairperson of the party's Core Committee and former state minister Vijay Inder

Singla as chairman of the Election Management and Coordination Committee. Party MP Amar Singh will head the manifesto committee.

"Congress president has appointed chairpersons of election-related committees for the upcoming assembly elections in Punjab, with immediate effect—Campaign Committee chairperson Charanjit Singh Channi, Election Management and Coordination Committee chairperson Vijay Inder Singla, Core Committee chairperson Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa and Manifesto committee chairperson Dr Amar Singh," AICC general secretary, Organisation, K C Venugopal said in a statement.

BJP LINKS TEWARI'S POST TO CONGRESS INFIGHTING

New Delhi: The Congress is in "tukde tukde" mode again and has no value for those who do not put "parivar" first, the BJP claimed on Thursday, seizing on senior leader Manish Tewari's post on "insecurities of individuals and institutions" after he was sidelined in the Punjab Congress reshuffle.

According to BJP national spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla, the Congress is witnessing factional rivalries in several states. "It has split into pieces in Karnataka with D K Shivakumar versus Siddaramaiah. We have seen fighting in Rajasthan between Pilot and Gehlot, in Chhattisgarh, and now in Punjab it has reached a climax where Manish Tewari has openly attacked the Congress party for leaving him out in the lurch," he said in a video statement.

"The Congress is once again in 'tukde tukde' mode," he said.

Oil companies suffered ₹74,781 cr loss on fuel sales amid West Asia crisis: Puri



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The West Asia conflict, which disrupted supply chains, led to Indian oil companies suffering ₹74,781-crore losses for selling petrol, diesel and LPG below cost, Union Petroleum Minister Hardeep Singh Puri said on Thursday. He also said a reduction in prices at home hinges on oil prices staying low for the next few weeks.

Puri further said international crude oil prices have come down but companies are still processing crude they bought at the height of the West Asia crisis.

Oil companies typically buy crude oil — the raw material for producing fuel — at least two months in advance. So, crude oil that is being processed now is essentially what was bought in April or early May when international prices were very high.

Asked if there would be a cut in prices of petrol and diesel, Puri said this would be a legitimate question if oil prices stayed low for the next few weeks.

"We are using the crude petroleum stock today that we had bought two months ago (at a price that existed two months ago).

If this (decline) continues for 2-3 months, we will see. But it is a hypothetical situa-

tion," he said. The Minister highlighted that the petrol price increase in developed world was around 20% and around 35% in India's neighboring countries, but in India, the increase in petrol price was just 5.58 per cent during the crisis.

"We did well without any dryout or closure at any of the 1,07,000 retail outlets during last four months (February 28th till the end of June)," Puri said.

Private fuel retailer Nayara Energy has cut petrol prices by ₹5 per litre and diesel prices by ₹3 per litre across its retail network from July 1, making it the first major cut in retail fuel prices since crude prices began falling.

The decision may put pressure on rival private retailers to review their own prices if international oil markets remain stable.

Crude oil prices started coming down only in the second half of June after the US and Iran reached an agreement to end the conflict. The closure of the Strait of Hormuz during the US-Iran war triggered one of the most severe global energy disruptions in recent decades, sending oil prices soaring and raising concerns over supply shortages across major importing nations.

States Focus



JAYA BACHCHAN MEETS MAMATA IN KOLKATA

Samajwadi Party Rajya Sabha MP Jaya Bachchan on Thursday called on former West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee at her Kalighat residence here, amid continuing political chatter over opposition realignments after the TMC's defeat in the assembly polls. Bachchan arrived at Banerjee's residence in the afternoon along with TMC MP Derek O'Brien. The details of the meeting were not immediately known. The visit assumes significance as it comes days after senior Samajwadi Party leader Kiranmay Nanda, during a visit to Kolkata, held the former CM responsible for the Trinamool Congress' defeat in the polls, and remarked that "people did not want Mamata". His comments had fuelled speculation about the growing distance between the two INDIA bloc partners in the aftermath of the emphatic victory in Bengal. (PTI)



CM SUVENDU INAUGURATES CYBER HELP DESKS

West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari on Thursday inaugurated cyber help desks in all police stations in the state to tackle cybercrimes. He said that cybercrime has become a pandemic, and to deal with these, help desks in all police stations have been created. Adhikari also inaugurated the Durga Suraksha squad for women's security in all districts and police commissionerates in West Bengal. Help desks for women in all police stations of the state were also inaugurated by Adhikari. (PTI)

NTA urges UGC-NET candidates to formally challenge alleged errors

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The National Testing Agency (NTA) has responded to concerns over alleged errors in the UGC-NET Sociology paper and reported repetition of questions in the English paper, urging candidates to formally challenge such issues through its grievance redressal mechanism.

Responding to the controversy, sources said students need to challenge the questions in the paper and submit formal queries to the NTA.

Sources said the agency would examine all genuine objections raised by candidates, citing the recent RE-NET examination as an example of its review



process. The NTA promises to look into the errors. We received 10,000 challenges from students regarding the Re-NET exam paper.

One question was retracted after the challenge was found to be valid. We will do the same for UGC-NET as well, but students need to submit their grievances formally through the grievance

ance redressal portal," sources said. Addressing concerns over repeated questions and typographical errors, they said such issues are not unusual and reiterated that candidates must follow the prescribed process to raise objections.

The clarification comes after a UGC-NET aspirant alleged on social media platform that the Sociology paper conducted on June 30 contained multiple spelling, grammar, and translation errors. In a post that went viral, the candidate claimed that nearly half the paper was affected by mistakes, including misspelled names of sociologists and incorrect translations in the Hindi version of the question paper.

TMC's Saugata Roy writes to LS Speaker over attack on Mahua Moitra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Senior Trinamool Congress (TMC) leader Saugata Roy on Thursday said he has written to Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla, seeking his intervention to ensure the safety of members of Parliament, after party MP Mahua Moitra was allegedly attacked during a visit to her constituency in West Bengal's Nadia district.

Addressing a press conference here, Roy alleged that Moitra came under attack when she visited her constituency, but refused to leave the area immediately and stayed on until the situation eased.

"She immediately reported the matter to the director general of police, but police remained silent spectators," Roy alleged.

He said he wrote to the speaker on Thursday, urging him to take steps to ensure the safety of MPs in their own constituencies. "I have written to the speaker to ensure the safety of MPs in their own constituencies. I hope the speaker takes



I have written to the Speaker to ensure the safety of MPs in their own constituencies. I hope the Speaker takes action

— SAUGATA ROY, TMC LEADER

action," he said. The veteran TMC leader said he tried to speak to Birla over the phone on Wednesday but could not get through. Instead, he said, he spoke to a Lok Sabha official attached to the speaker's office.

Roy further said he had recently written to Union Home Minister Amit Shah, expressing concern over alleged attacks on TMC workers in West Bengal. Moitra alleged on

Wednesday that Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) workers hurled eggs at her during a protest outside TMC MLA Alifa Ahmed's residence in Nadia district.

Moitra had gone to Palashi in Kaliganj to attend a TMC meeting at Ahmed's residence when a group of protesters allegedly gathered outside and shouted slogans of "go back" and "chor". The protesters also allegedly hurled eggs at her.

NHRC notice to UP Govt, DGP over assault on 12 labourers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The NHRC on Thursday said it has issued notice to the Uttar Pradesh government and the state's police chief in a case of alleged atrocities against 12 bonded labourers at a factory in Muzaffarnagar district. The human rights panel has sought a detailed report from the authorities in two weeks.

In a statement, the National Human Rights Commission said it has taken suo motu cognisance of a media report about "12 bonded labourers being assaulted in captivity and forced to work till midnight without sufficient food and wages for nearly one and a half years at a paper plate manufacturing factory in Mandi village in Muzaffarnagar district".

One of the labourers managed to escape from the factory and a complaint was filed with the Titawi police station, leading to the rescue of the other labourers, it said.

States Focus



TMC FEUD: REBEL FACTION MEETS ELECTION COMMISSION

The Ritabrata Banerjee-led rebel faction of the Trinamool Congress on Thursday said the full bench of the Election Commission gave it a "patient hearing" on its claim over the party, and expressed hope that the poll panel would respond shortly. Meanwhile, the Mamata Banerjee-led camp questioned the Election Commission's decision to grant an audience to the rebel faction, alleging that the meeting violated the poll body's own procedures. Speaking to reporters after meeting Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and the two Election Commissioners, Ritabrata Banerjee said the delegation had formally placed its case before the poll panel after informing it about the faction's special organisational session held in Kolkata on June 22. (PTI)



VB-G RAM G SCHEME TO CREATE DURABLE ASSETS: BHAJANLAL

Rajasthan Chief Minister Bhajanlal Sharma on Thursday said the newly launched Viksit Bharat -- Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) Scheme will provide 125 days of employment annually to eligible households in rural areas and help create durable assets while ensuring greater transparency and accountability. Speaking at the state-level launch of the scheme at an event in Beawar district, Sharma said the initiative reflects Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of developing villages as the foundation for a developed India by 2047. The event in Beawar was linked to the national launch of the scheme by Union Rural Development and Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan from Tirupati in Andhra Pradesh. (PTI)

7 workers killed in quarry collapse in Bengaluru

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

Seven migrant labourers, including five from Madhya Pradesh were killed instantaneously on Thursday when a massive granite rock slid from the top and fell on them in a quarry in Bengaluru urban district, a senior police official said and blamed "negligence" for the fatal incident.

Initially, police sources had said majority of the victims hailed from Bihar but it was later clarified they were from Madhya Pradesh.

Earlier, Yashwanthpur MLA and former Minister ST Somashekar had claimed that one more injured died in the hospital taking the toll to eight. However, Deputy Inspector General of Central Range S Girish clarified that only seven were killed, five were

wounded while four others working on the site escaped unhurt in the tragedy that took place at Madapattana in Bengaluru urban district just at the border with Bengaluru South district.

Besides the five victims from MP, one deceased hailed from Chhattisgarh and another was from Yadgir in Karnataka. "There are two crushers here — one is on the top and the second one is below. There was work going on at both the sites. There were about 16 labourers working there. A drilling machine was deployed on the top. A massive rock slid from the top and fell on the people working below. Seven people died on the spot," Girish told reporters here.

He added that the five injured are out of danger. "It is very obvious that



there was negligence due to which seven people lost their lives," he added.

An official from Mines and Geology Department, Rangappa said the quarry owner has agreed to provide compensation to the next of kin of the deceased and the injured. "I spoke to the quarry owner to get Rs 10 lakh compensation to the relatives of

the deceased and Rs five lakh to the injured. He has agreed to it," Rangappa told reporters.

Mourning the demise of the labourers, Karnataka Chief Minister D K Shivakumar said, "We will issue fresh guidelines for quarrying activities across the state. I will ensure that no such incident occurs again." He would examine whether quarrying

Assam CM, Union Minister discuss roadmap to boost fisheries, dairy sectors

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Thursday met Union Fisheries, Animal Husbandry and Dairying Minister Rajiv Ranjan (Lalan) Singh at the latter's official residence here and held extensive discussions on unlocking Assam's potential in the fisheries and dairy sectors.

Sharing details of the meeting on X, Sarma said, "Had a very good conversation with Hon'ble Union Minister Shri @LalanSingh_1 ji. His vast experience and deep understanding of the sector were reflected in the valuable insights he shared."

The Chief Minister said the discussions centred on harnessing Assam's immense potential in the fisheries sector by increasing fish production and promoting exports. "We had a



productive discussion on harnessing Assam's immense potential in the fisheries sector. Along with increasing fish production, we also explored promoting fish exports by strengthening the value chain, improving processing infrastructure and enhancing market access," Sarma said.

He added, "In the coming

Aushadhi Kendras, establishing Tetrapack (UHT) and Milk Powder Plants, and improving the existing cattle stock through artificial insemination."

In a separate post on X, Union Minister Singh described the meeting as 'warm and productive' and said the two leaders held a detailed discussion on unlocking Assam's immense fisheries potential by enhancing fish production, promoting exports, strengthening the value chain and expanding processing infrastructure.

The Union Minister said the meeting also deliberated on strengthening dairy cooperatives, expanding veterinary services, establishing veterinary medicine centres, setting up Tetra Pak (UHT) and milk powder plants, and improving livestock through artificial insemination.

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Show of unity fails to quell Congress infighting in MP

GIRISH SHARMA ■ Bhopal

The long-suspected factional divide within the Madhya Pradesh Congress has once again surfaced in public, exposing differences between senior leader Digvijaya Singh and Pradesh Congress Committee (PCC) president Jitu Patwari.

What began as a disagreement over allegations surrounding the Veer Bharat Nyas land allotment in Ujjain quickly snowballed into a political controversy, providing the BJP with fresh ammunition to attack the opposition while triggering criticism from within the Congress itself.

The controversy erupted after Jitu Patwari alleged that the Madhya Pradesh government had transferred land worth nearly Rs 500 crore in Ujjain to the Veer Bharat Nyas for a token amount of Re 1. Seeking to verify the claims, Digvijaya Singh visited Ujjain and pub-



Digvijaya Singh (left) and Jitu Patwari (right)

licly stated that there was nothing irregular in the transfer as the land had been allotted to a government trust. While defending the transaction, he remarked that "broker-like people" often level allegations for money. Though he did not name anyone, the statement was widely interpreted as a direct swipe at Patwari, whose allegations he had effectively contradicted.

The remarks immediately triggered political tremors

within the Congress. The BJP accused the party of exposing its own contradictions, while Congress leaders themselves began expressing discontent over the public disagreement.

State Congress General Secretary Nidhi Chaturvedi launched an unusually sharp attack on Digvijaya Singh through a social media post, questioning why a senior leader would publicly undermine the party's own state president. She wrote that if

Patwari was wrong, Singh should have corrected him privately rather than embarrassing the party before the public. Chaturvedi also alleged that Singh's continued protection of his son was indirectly providing "oxygen" to the BJP. Former Union Minister Arun Yadav reportedly urged Congress leader Rahul Gandhi to intervene and resolve the growing internal discord.

With the controversy threatening to spiral further, the party moved quickly to contain the damage. Digvijaya Singh and Jitu Patwari appeared together at a joint press conference in Bhopal in an apparent show of unity. Digvijaya dismissed reports of any rift, saying Patwari was "like a son" to him and clarifying that he had never intended to use the word "broker" for the PCC chief or any Congress leader. He stressed that the Congress remained united and that the misunderstanding

had been deliberately amplified. However, despite the public display of solidarity, political circles remain unconvinced that the differences have been fully resolved. Congress insiders indicated that the damage-control exercise followed intervention by the party's central leadership in New Delhi. According to party sources, Digvijaya Singh may have been pulled up by the high command after his remarks triggered a major embarrassment for the organisation. The subsequent joint press conference is being viewed as an attempt to publicly restore unity and prevent the issue from escalating further.

Political observers also noted that Digvijaya Singh's facial expressions during the joint appearance appeared restrained and unusually subdued, fuelling speculation that the veteran leader had been asked to defuse the controversy.

State lab tampered with viscera samples in RG Kar rape case: Victim's father

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

In a shocking claim, the father of the victim doctor of the RG Kar Medical College rape and murder case has told a trial court how the viscera samples of the victim were tampered with by three officials of the state-run Forensic Science Laboratory, seeking a proper inquiry into the matter.

Submitting two letters before the Sealдах Court, the father of the victim said that he had received those letters during the month of May from a retired employee of the state-run SFSL at Belgachia, north of Kolkata.

The letter alleged that three employees of the SFSL had tampered with the viscera sample before sending it to the Central Forensic Laboratory. "The names of the three employees have been mentioned in the letter



... I request the Court to enquire into the facts and bring the truth before the world," said the father of the victim, whose wife had earlier joined the BJP in quest of justice and successfully contested the April-May Assembly elections.

The mother of the rape victim said that her only goal was to seek justice for her daughter. The incident had shocked the entire country and even hit the inter-

national headlines.

According to strong allegations, some vested interests, including doctors linked to the then Mamata Banerjee Government had played an active role in the rape and murder of the lady doctor.

After coming to power, Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari had promptly suspended three top

IPS officers, including a former Commissioner of Kolkata Police.

Punjab decides to amend land pooling policy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

The Punjab Cabinet has given its nod to amend the state's land pooling policy whereby it would offer more benefits to landowners.

The cabinet, which met on Wednesday evening, also approved to waive facilitation charges for citizen-centric services which include birth and caste certificates in the wake of ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls. Addressing the media here on Thursday, Finance Minister Harpal Singh Cheema said it has been decided that landowners will get a commercial plot of 210 square yards as against 200 square yards now for giving every one acre of land under the land pooling policy.

Under the present policy, a land owner is entitled to get 1,000 square yards of a residential plot and 200



square yards of a commercial plot for an acre of land.

As per the amendment, if a land owner does not take 200 square yards of a commercial plot, then he will be entitled to a 1,630 square yards of a residential plot as against the present provision of a 1,600 square yards plot, said Cheema.

On another decision, Cheema said that citizens require different documents like birth certificates, caste certificates, and residential certificates for the ongoing SIR exercise.

West Bengal Govt likely to table Uniform Civil Code draft bill in Monsoon Session: Sources

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

The Bengal BJP Government inched closer towards implementing the much-talked-about Uniform Civil Code in the State with Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on Thursday taking the draft bill for a discussion in the Cabinet, sources said, adding the bill would "most likely" be tabled in the State Assembly in the coming Monsoon Session in the month of August.

An expert panel headed by former Supreme Court Judge Justice Ranjana Prakash Desai has been constituted to evaluate the Bill and submit its report in four weeks' time. The Bill that was likely to be shaped after similar UCC laws implemented earlier in the States of Gujarat, Assam and Uttarakhand would focus on a total of nine subjects, including marriage,



succession, divorce, adoption, inheritance, live-in relationships, custody of children, etc. The expert panel will conduct a study on the nine issues before submitting its report to the State Government.

Earlier, announcing the Government's plan to implement the UCC, the Chief Minister clarified that ancient tribal communities would be kept out of the purview of the Bill.

During a speech in the State Assembly the Chief

Minister earlier said that "the UCC will certainly be implemented in Bengal ... we are determined to implement it ... the (passing of the) Bill has a procedure ... this will be done after examining the examples of Gujarat, Assam and Uttarakhand."

Reacting to the comments from the Opposition Bench, the Chief Minister said, "The Bill will be tabled in August ... before that you keep your views before the (expert) Committee ... But let me make my point clear that we

are determined to implement this Bill and it will definitely be implemented."

The BJP had, during the election campaign, promised to bring UCC to Bengal, saying a time had come when "religion-based personal laws should end."

The State's Muslim community was, however, opposing the bill, saying, "It is an infringement in the private affairs of the minorities."

The Chief Minister also took stock of the welfare schemes and law and order situation in the State during the first two months of his rule, sources said.

The stock-taking situation comes close on the heels of a chief ministerial assurance to the bureaucrats that his Government would not interfere in their day-to-day business and that they would be free to take their own decisions as per law.

Indian Navy thwarts piracy bid in Gulf of Aden

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Swift and timely action by the Indian Navy foiled a piracy bid against a ship carrying vital cargo for India. The action took place off the Gulf of Aden on Wednesday, and the Indian warship INS Trikand deterred the piracy attack on the merchant vessel MV Golden Arsenal. The merchant ship had one Indian crew member, sources said here on Thursday.

Narrating the sequence of events, they said when the ship was attacked, the crew took refuge in a secure location and transmitted a distress signal on an emergency channel. The Indian Navy - which has a dedicated anti-piracy force in the area - was alerted and deployed rapidly.

As the warship approached the merchant ship, the pirates fled, sources confirmed. Marine Commandos (MARCOS) of the Navy then



boarded the MV Golden Arsenal to conduct a thorough sanitisation operation - to make sure there were no armed intruders on board the vessel. Once the vessel was sanitised and the crew were given medical check-ups, the Golden Arsenal continued on its way.

On June 19 the same warship responded to another distress call — this time from MV Fareeda 5 — about a likely piracy attempt in the Western Indian Ocean and undertook prompt action to investigate and deter pirates.

Downpour, debris hit traffic movement on Char Dham routes

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Dehradun

Amid moderate to heavy rain-fall in most parts of Uttarakhand, the weather office on Thursday issued an alert for several districts including Dehradun.

Due to unceasing down-pour, and falling debris and stones from hillsides, traffic movement has been affected on the Badrinath National Highway in Chamoli district and the Kedarnath Yatra route in Rudraprayag district. Officials said for safety of pilgrims, the movement of vehicles and pedestrians on the Sonprayag-Munkatiya road in Rudraprayag has been temporarily suspended as a precautionary measure.

The meteorological centre has issued an “orange alert” for



Personnel of the NDRF, Uttarakhand SDRF and Fire Services rescue participating during a flood rescue mock drill organised by the National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA) ahead of the monsoon in Dehradun

Dehradun, Tehri, Pauri, Nainital, and Bageshwar districts, cautioning of heavy to very heavy rainfall at isolated places. A “yellow alert” for heavy rainfall at isolated places

has been issued for Haridwar, Uttarkashi, Rudraprayag, and Chamoli districts.

Monsoon arrived in Uttarakhand on June 30 and by Wednesday, it became

active across the state. Since then, intermittent rains have been lashed many areas including Dehradun.

According to the Dehradun Meteorological Center, during

the past 24 hours, Narendranagar received 110 mm of rain, Dhanaulti 100 mm, Khatima 85.5 mm, Jolly Grant 80.4 mm, Dehradun 79.6 mm, Mussoorie 77.8 mm, Laksar 73.5 mm, Banbasa 72 mm, Pantnagar 70.6 mm, Barkot 65 mm, Rudraprayag 64.5 mm, Jakholi 63 mm and Yamkeshwar 60 mm. Moderate rainfall was recorded at several other places. Due to the rain, temperatures have dropped across the state. During the past 24 hours, the maximum temperatures in both plains and hills were significantly below normal.

According to the meteorological office, the maximum temperature in Dehradun on Thursday stood at 20.4 degrees Celsius, three degrees below normal. In comparison, a maximum of

25.8 degrees Celsius was recorded Wednesday, six degrees below normal.

In view of the heavy rain alerts, the State Emergency Operations Center (SEOC) has directed concerned district magistrates to exercise necessary vigilance and ensure precautionary measures.

Officials said falling stones from a hill in the Munkatiya area of Rudraprayag district blocked the Kedarnath Yatra route. In view of the safety of pilgrims, the administration has temporarily suspended movement of vehicles and pedestrians on this route.

Rudraprayag District Disaster Management Officer Nandan Singh Rajwar said work of removing debris and large boulders with the help of JCBs (excavators) is continuing at a war footing.

HEAVY RAIN SHUTS 46 ROADS IN HIMACHAL

Manali: Moderate to heavy rain lashed parts of Himachal Pradesh, disrupting normal life as 46 roads were closed to vehicular traffic across the state, officials said on Thursday. The Shimla Meteorological Centre issued an orange alert, warning of heavy to very heavy rainfall at isolated places from July 2 to July 5, except for July 3.

According to the State Emergency Operations Centre (SEOC), 18 roads were closed in Kullu, 15 in Mandi, nine in Sirmour and two each in Lahaul and Spiti and Una districts. A total of 181 electricity transformers and six water supply schemes were also affected due to torrential rain, the SEOC said. Poanta Sahib recorded 100.4 mm of rainfall since



Wednesday evening, followed by Kasauli (86 mm), Dharampur (83.4 mm), Jattan Barrage (77 mm), Dhaulakuan (69 mm), Pachhad (60 mm), Rampur (53 mm), Una (50.4 mm), Nahan (38.3 mm), Palampur (37.8 mm) and Dharamshala (34.1 mm). Kangra, Jubberhatti and Bhuntar also witnessed thunderstorms and lightning. (PNS)

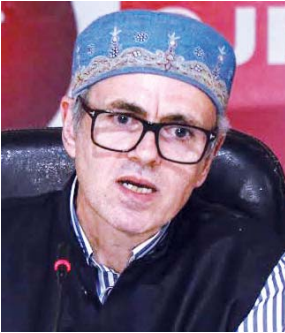
No one should object to India-Pak dialogue aimed at improving ties: Omar Abdullah

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Srinagar

Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah on Thursday said no one should object to dialogue between India and Pakistan aimed at improving bilateral relations.

Talking to reporters on the sidelines of a function here, Abdullah said the conflict between the two countries was not new and has persisted for the last three to four decades.

“This conflict is 30 to 40 years old, and last year, it intensified after the Pahalgam attack. Now, the PM is being requested, through a letter, that the relations between the two countries should be improved. No one should



have any objection to that,” Abdullah said.

A letter coordinated by OP Shah, chairman of the Centre for Peace and Progress, and signed by 61 Indians and 55 Pakistanis, has urged the two countries to engage in bilateral talks.

Questioning those criticising the initiative, Abdullah

said senior leaders of the RSS had also advocated improving ties between India and Pakistan. “Recently, a senior RSS leader said that India and Pakistan should talk to each other and become friends. When the RSS says this, no one objects, but when the leaders in J-K say the same thing, it becomes an issue.

“We are only saying what (former prime minister Atal Bihari) Vajpayee used to say that friends can be changed, but we cannot change neighbours. We want relations between neighbours to improve,” Abdullah said.

More than 100 prominent citizens, including former Jammu and Kashmir chief ministers Farooq Abdullah and Mehbooba Mufti, from

India and Pakistan, have urged Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi and his Pakistani counterpart Shehbaz Sharif to revive bilateral dialogue and restore normal ties.

Among the signatories are former RAW chief A S Dulat, Rajya Sabha MP Manoj Jha, former diplomat Ashraf Jehangir Qazi, former Union minister Mani Shankar Aiyar, former Pakistan foreign minister Khurshid Mahmud Kasuri, besides several retired diplomats and civil society members.

The letter urged both governments to take “meaningful and sustained steps towards restoring peace, normalcy, dialogue and cooperation in South Asia”.

Amarnath Yatra: LG flags off first batch of pilgrims

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

The annual Shri Amarnath Ji Yatra 2026 got underway on Thursday with Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha flagging off the first batch of more than 4,800 pilgrims from the Bhagwati Nagar Base Camp in Jammu.

The convoy, comprising 259 light and heavy vehicles, departed early morning under what officials described as unprecedented security arrangements. The road opening parties had sanitised the entire yatra route before the yatra convoy was flagged off from the base camp in Jammu. The quick reaction teams remained stationed along the Jammu-Srinagar National Highway at vantage locations to prevent any untoward incident.

Pilgrims received a traditional warm welcome along



LG Manoj Sinha flags off the first batch of pilgrims for the annual Amarnath Yatra from Bhagwati Nagar Yatri Niwas base camp in Jammu

the route to the Kashmir Valley, with locals and devotees chanting religious and patriotic slogans at various points

The Lt Governor wished all the devotees a safe and spiritually fulfilling journey and prayed for peace, prosperity, and happiness for all.

The pilgrims reached the valley through the Navyug tunnel in the Qazigund area

of south Kashmir's Kulgam district, where they were welcomed by the South Kashmir Range deputy inspector general of police and Kulgam deputy commissioner.

The officials welcomed the yatrins with garlands, flower bouquets, sweets, and tricolours. The convoys left separately for the Baltal and Pahalgam base camps, from

where they will leave for the 3,880-metre-high cave shrine early Friday. Elaborate security arrangements have been made in and around the base camps in the valley.

The yatra is being monitored 24x7 from the Integrated Command and Control Centre at Raj Bhawan and the Police Control Room, while an RFID-based tracking system has also been put in place.

Before embarking on the journey of faith, a group of pilgrims from Nasik told media persons that the atmosphere here in Jammu is very upbeat. “We are going to perform darshan inside the cave shrine without any fear in our minds. We also want to let the nation know that the UT administration has made extensive security arrangements and there is no need to be afraid.”

Retired police Sub-Inspector held in POCSO case in Kerala



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kannur

A retired Sub-Inspector was arrested for allegedly sexually harassing a minor girl at Pariyaram, police on Thursday said.

The arrested is Gopinathan (62), of Pariyaram. According to police, the incident took place on Wednesday when an 11-year-old girl living in the neighbourhood reached the house of the accused. Police said that the accused allegedly sexually harassed the child and threatened not to reveal it to anyone else.

However, after reaching the house, the child told the parents. When people assembled outside Gopinathan's house, he left the place and reached the police station.

Later, following a complaint filed by the parents, Pariyaram police registered a case under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act.

Mumbai manhole death amounts to culpable homicide: Speaker

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Maharashtra Assembly Speaker Rahul Narwekar on Thursday called the death of a man in a manhole in Mumbai a serious matter and said it amounted to “culpable homicide”.

Responding to the matter raised by a member, he asked the state government to place a detailed statement in the House on the incident before the day's proceedings concluded. A man died after being swept into an open manhole amid heavy rains in the city on Thursday afternoon, an official said. The incident occurred in the



Rahul Narwekar

Chandivali area in the eastern suburbs, where waterlogging had apparently concealed the uncovered manhole.

Fire brigade and civic disaster management teams conducted a search and operation and the man's body was recovered subsequently, he said. BJP MLA Ameet Satam raised the incident in the assembly and

demanding that criminal action be initiated immediately against those responsible.

Satam told the House that the incident occurred on Khairani Road in the area during drainage work being carried out by the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC). He identified the deceased as Aslam Ishaq Shaikh, a resident of Yadav Nagar in Sakinaka.

Satam demanded that an FIR be registered immediately and that the BMC official in charge of the work be suspended. He went on to add that suspension alone would not suffice and sought the registration of a case of culpable homicide.

Lt Gen VMB Krishnan reviews security, operational preparedness

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kohima

Lt Gen VMB Krishnan, PVSM, AVSM, YSM, General Officer Commanding-in-Chief, Eastern Command, accompanied by the GOC SPEAR CORPS, visited the Headquarters Inspector General Assam Rifles (North) to review the prevailing security situation, operational preparedness and ongoing operational initiatives in the region.

During the visit, the Army Commander was briefed on the operational environment, current security dynamics and the oper-

ational preparedness of the formation. He interacted with officers and troops, appreciating their professionalism, dedication and unwavering commitment towards maintaining peace, security and stability in the region. In recognition of exemplary devotion to duty, he presented Commendation Cards to deserving personnel.

Later, the Army Commander held a focused interaction with the Chairman, Ceasefire Monitoring Group (CFMG), to review the prevailing security situation and discuss key issues



MoS Nityanand Rai felicitates ITBP, BSF and NSG Everest expedition teams

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Minister of State for Home Affairs Nityanand Rai on Thursday felicitated the successful expedition teams of the Indo-Tibetan Border Police (ITBP), Border Security Force (BSF) and National Security Guard (NSG) during the Flag-In Ceremony for the Mount Everest Expedition-2026 and the BSF Mount Lhotse Expedition-2026 held in New Delhi. On the occasion, he also inaugurated newly constructed buildings of the ITBP and laid the foundation stone for new NSG infrastructure.

The ceremony was attended by Home Secretary Govind Mohan, Director



Intelligence Bureau, Mahesh Dixit, Director General ITBP Shatruijeet Kapur, Director General NSG B. Srinivasan, Director General BSF Praveen Kumar, senior officers of the three CAPFs, members of the expedition teams and other distinguished guests. The programme commenced

with presentations by ITBP, BSF and NSG on their respective mountaineering expeditions. Subsequently, the leaders of the three expedition teams presented their expedition flags to the MoS. The ceremony also featured the inauguration and foundation stone laying of ITBP and

NSG infrastructure projects, besides the presentation of commemorative mementoes to the Hon'ble Minister by the expedition teams.

Congratulating all mountaineers, expedition members and every officer and personnel associated with these remarkable achievements, Nityanand Rai said that unfurling the National Flag atop the world's highest peaks is not merely an extraordinary mountaineering feat but a powerful reflection of the discipline, professionalism, exceptional training and unwavering commitment of India's Central Armed Police Forces. He described mountaineering as the ultimate test of leadership, decision-

making, risk management and teamwork, emphasising that the true success of any expedition lies in the safe return of every team member.

The MoS observed that the same qualities required for safeguarding India's borders, combating terrorism and left-wing extremism, and undertaking disaster relief operations are equally reflected in mountaineering expeditions.

These accomplishments, he said, therefore represent not only sporting excellence but also the institutional capability, operational preparedness and professional competence of the Central Armed Police Forces. Rai described this year's expeditions as historic in many

respects. He particularly lauded ITBP's first all-women Mount Everest Expedition, BSF's first all-women Mount Everest and Mount Lhotse Expeditions, and NSG's first successful Mount Everest Expedition, stating that these achievements have elevated India's prestige on the global stage.

Recalling ITBP's rich mountaineering legacy, he said the Force began its mountaineering journey with the Mount Trishul Expedition in 1970 and has since conducted 232 successful mountaineering expeditions, including five successful Mount Everest expeditions, besides conquering several other challenging peaks across the world. Appreciating the achieve-

ments of BSF and NSG, he said that all three forces have demonstrated exemplary courage, professionalism and operational excellence under the most demanding conditions.

Highlighting the achievements of the women mountaineers, Nityanand Rai said they have once again demonstrated that given equal opportunities and training, Indian women are capable of excelling in every challenging sphere of national service.

He also described the collective rendition of 'Vande Mataram' by the expedition members atop Mount Everest as a deeply inspiring expression of India's culture, patriotism and national pride.

KERALA POLICE SEIZE DRUGS WORTH OVER ₹30 CRORE

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

The Kerala Police have registered 5,353 cases, arrested 5,736 people and seized drugs worth over Rs 30 crore during the first month of 'Operation Toofan: The Narco Hunt', a statewide anti-drug campaign launched by the state government to curb narcotics abuse and trafficking, officials said on Thursday.

According to a police statement, the campaign was launched by Chief Minister V D Sathesaran on June 2 and has since been carried out across the state, leading to the seizure of large quantities of narcotic substances and the arrest of hundreds of suspected drug peddlers.

Police said the initiative aims to dismantle drug trafficking networks, prevent the use and distribution of narcotic substances among school and college students, create public awareness about drug abuse and help addicts return to normal life through counselling and rehabilitation.

Between June 2 and July 1, intensive inspections were carried out across the state targeting suspected drug peddlers, users and supply networks, police said.

During the operation, police registered 5,353 cases and arrested 5,736 people.

The seizures included 3,706.743 grams of MDMA, 392.100 kg of ganja, 3,776.039 grams of hashish oil, 4.85 grams of hashish, 657.219 grams of brown sugar, 12,6709 grams of methamphetamine, 31.23 grams of heroin, 428 cannabis plants, 11 LSD stamps, 56 grams of nitrazepam, 25.23 grams of opium, 1.6 grams of charas and 3,294 ganja beedis, the statement said.

Police said the seized contraband was worth over Rs 30 crore.

One of the major seizures during the campaign was the recovery of 18 kg of hybrid ganja worth around Rs 18 crore in Ernakulam on June 24. The statement said the operation has received active support from various government departments and the public.



Editor's
TAKE

Can a pause on usernames stop online fraud?

The IT Ministry has ordered Meta to halt the rollout of WhatsApp's new usernames feature. But can it be a panacea for rising cyber fraud?

The sequence of events was swift. Meta announced on June 29 that WhatsApp users worldwide, including in India, could start reserving a username, a handle that lets people message without exchanging phone numbers. Within forty-eight hours, India's Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology had sent a notice to Meta's compliance office, ordering the company to halt the rollout, explain itself within three days, and justify why regulatory action should not follow under the IT Act and 2021 intermediary rules. WhatsApp's response was almost timid: only the reservation option is live; the ability to use a username instead of a number will not arrive until later this year.

The government's anxiety is not ill-placed. India has become a global hotspot for "digital arrest" scams, in which fraudsters impersonate police officers, tax officials or narcotics agents and browbeat victims into transferring their savings over video calls. A username system, unless tightly policed, hands such scammers a new prop: a handle styled to resemble a police officer or a tax official. Meta says it has reserved high-profile names for their legitimate owners and blocked obvious lookalikes, but automated filters have a well-documented habit of missing the clever fake while catching the innocent.

Yet the pause carries an irony the government's notice does not reckon with. Usernames were pitched, correctly, as a privacy feature: a way to talk to strangers on marketplaces or elsewhere without handing over a phone number that can be mined, sold or SIM-swapped. Signal has offered exactly this in India since 2024, and Telegram had it years earlier still, despite itself being banned here for a week. If the format were inherently dangerous, both apps would already have drawn the same scrutiny. What has changed is scale: WhatsApp counts more than 500 million Indian users, so any flaw in its architecture can have far reaching consequences.

However, scammers do not need usernames to run a digital-arrest racket; they already manage with spoofed caller IDs, cloned government letterheads and rented SIM cards. Stopping one product from launching buys time, not safety. What India actually lacks is the infrastructure that would make any messaging feature harder to weaponise: a verified-caller framework spanning telecom and app platforms, a fraud-reporting system fast enough to freeze stolen money before it clears through mule accounts, and public awareness that outlives one week's news cycle. Three days is not much time for Meta to produce a considered answer, and it is even less time for the ministry to design durable policy. The real test of this episode is not whether WhatsApp's usernames eventually launch; they almost certainly will, in India as everywhere else.

It is whether the government uses this pause to build defences that outlast any single product decision, or simply files the notice away once Meta tweaks its onboarding screen. A username can be paused. The fraudster will not wait for the government decision. He will have his way as he knows he is behind a smoke screen no one can penetrate.

Steering the future of Indian Ocean

Drawing upon both its civilisational legacy and contemporary strategic vision, India has the opportunity not merely to safeguard the Indian Ocean but to emerge as its foremost maritime power — anchoring regional stability, expanding global trade and leading through a model of cooperation, connectivity and Dharma-based diplomacy



SANTHOSH
MATHEW

The twenty-first century is increasingly being described as the Indian Ocean Century. As the global economic centre of gravity shifts from the Atlantic to Asia, the vast maritime region stretching from the eastern coast of Africa to the western Pacific has emerged as the world's busiest and most strategically important sea space. More than 80 per cent of the world's seaborne oil trade by volume and a significant share of global merchandise trade pass through the Indian Ocean. It is home to some of the fastest-growing economies and serves as the lifeline of international commerce. For India, the Indian Ocean is not merely a geographical expression. It is the foundation of the country's economic security, energy security and strategic influence. India's destiny has always been intertwined with the sea. From the days of the ancient Cholas, Cheras and the maritime traders of Kerala to the modern Indian Navy, the oceans have connected India to the wider world through commerce, culture and civilization.

India possesses enormous maritime advantages. With a coastline of more than 7,500 kilometres and an Exclusive Economic Zone of over two million square kilometres, the country is blessed with abundant marine resources.

The rapidly expanding Blue Economy—covering fisheries, aquaculture, marine biotechnology, offshore renewable energy and coastal tourism—is expected to contribute trillions of dollars to the global economy in the coming decades. India is well positioned to become one of its leading beneficiaries. Kerala occupies a unique place in this maritime vision. Situated at the heart of the Indian Ocean trade routes, the state has historically been India's gateway to the Arabian Sea.

Its strategic geography, natural harbours, shipbuilding potential and centuries-old seafaring traditions make Kerala a vital pillar of India's maritime ambitions. The state is among India's largest exporters of marine products and supports millions of livelihoods through fisheries, seafood processing, aquaculture and coastal tourism.

One of India's greatest maritime opportunities today is the development of world-class transshipment infrastructure. At present, nearly three-fourths of India's transshipment cargo is handled by foreign ports such as Colombo, Singapore and Dubai. This dependence increases logistics costs and leaves India reliant on foreign strategic infra-



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SECURING THESE
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STABILITY OF THE
GLOBAL ECONOMY

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its strategic centrality remains unchanged. No alternative terminology can erase India's indispensable role in securing one of the world's most important maritime regions.

India's greatest strength lies beyond military capabilities. It lies in what may be called Dharma Diplomacy—a civilizational approach rooted in mutual respect, peaceful coexistence, inclusiveness and humanitarian engagement.

Unlike many great powers that historically expanded through conquest and colonization, India spread its influence across the oceans through trade, culture, spirituality and knowledge.

Indian merchants, monks and scholars carried Buddhism, Hindu philosophy, Ayurveda, mathematics and art across Southeast Asia, East Africa and the Indian Ocean islands without the force of arms.

This civilisational legacy continues to shape India's global image. Whether through humanitarian assistance during natural disasters, vaccine diplomacy, development partnerships or initiatives such as "Security and Growth for All in the Region (SAGAR)", India projects itself as a trustworthy and responsible maritime partner. This soft power complements India's growing naval capabilities and reinforces its leadership in the Indian Ocean.

The future maritime order will not be determined solely by aircraft carriers and naval bases. It will also be shaped by trust, connectivity, sustainable development and cooperative security.

India's democratic values, technological capabilities and civilizational wisdom provide it with unique advantages that cannot be measured merely in military terms. As the Indian Ocean becomes the epicentre of global geopolitics and economic activity, India's maritime renaissance is gathering momentum.

With ports such as Vizhinjam, a vibrant Blue Economy, a professional navy and a rich civilizational heritage, India is well placed to emerge as one of the defining maritime powers of the twenty-first century. The tides of history are once again turning towards the Indian Ocean. And when history sails through these waters, India will not merely witness the journey—it will help steer it.

PIC TALK



Tourists visit the Bajrang Setu Glass Bridge after rainfall, in Rishikesh, Uttarakhand

PHOTO: PTI



BODDAPATI
CHANDRASHEKHAR

2ND OPINION

"Life is not meant for dying. It is meant for living and letting others live," a writer once said. Very thought-provoking words are these!

They contain a profound philosophy about the very purpose of human existence on this earth.

Life is not a burden imposed upon man; nor is it a meaningless journey moving helplessly toward death. It is a rare gift meant to be lived meaningfully, wholeheartedly, and with a sense of awareness. To live life "to its absolute fullness" naturally leads us to the understanding that life itself is a celebration.

Here, celebration does not merely mean pleasure, amusement, or uninterrupted happiness. It means accepting life in all its hues and rhythms. It means participating wholeheartedly in the flow of existence.

To live is to celebrate!

A person who lives meaningfully learns to cherish relationships. He values human bonds, understands emotions, and discovers beauty even in ordinary moments. He learns from suffering, delights in small joys, and gradually acquires emotional balance.

That is where a person's true courage, wisdom, and intellect lie.

Life is a blend of joys and sorrows. Light and darkness follow one another.

The dazzling light gradually fades into darkness, and even pitch darkness, in course of time, must yield to penetrating light. Neither of them is permanent. This is the eternal law of nature.

Human beings gladly welcome happiness and revel in it. But when sorrow strikes, many lose their peace of mind. Unable to bear pain and disappointment, they become emotionally unstable and begin to view death as an escape.

At such critical moments, the wisdom gained through experience, the values nurtured from childhood, the strength imparted by education, and even ordinary common sense seem to disappear. Man completely loses his sense of judgment.

"Man is a wonderful creation. In all of living creation, he is the most supreme, powerful, and resourceful," said Shakespeare. Indeed, among all living beings, man alone is blessed with an extraordinary power of thought.

From the days of the primitive caveman to the

modern technological age, humanity has undergone astonishing evolution and unimaginable transformation.

Through his ever-sharpening intellect, man has achieved remarkable progress in knowledge, science, civilization, and technology.

Yet, a disturbing question remains. When sorrows surround him, why does man fail to display the same maturity and mental strength?

Why does such a brilliant mind lose its resilience in moments of distress? Does he forget that troubles are temporary? Does he fail to realize that no night remains forever?

This beautiful life must be lived until its very end. We must protect our families, nurture our relationships, and keep our loved ones safe and flourishing. Only then can we truly taste the sweet nectar of life.

We must preserve our great civilization, artistic brilliance, and precious literature, passing them on to future generations. The humane qualities within man must multiply. He must grow into a person of wisdom, compassion, and discernment.

If such a transformation takes place, could there be any heaven greater than this very earth?

The writer is a columnist, lecturer, and radio presenter. He has delivered several talks on spirituality and literature, and has written numerous literary essays on various issues

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE



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PRIVACY AND PROTECTION MUST GO TOGETHER

Apropos the news report, 'Govt seeks pause on WhatsApp usernames' (July 2), WhatsApp's proposal to introduce usernames instead of exposing users' mobile numbers is a positive step towards strengthening online privacy. It can particularly benefit women, students and other vulnerable users by allowing them to communicate without revealing personal contact details. Concerns that the feature will automatically encourage cybercrime appear overstated, as every WhatsApp account will continue to remain linked to a verified mobile number. However, privacy must be accompanied by stronger safeguards. WhatsApp should prevent impersonation by restricting deceptive look-alike usernames, expanding

verified identity features and providing users with greater control over who can contact them or add them to groups and broadcast lists.

Equally important is improving digital literacy, especially among senior citizens, who are often the primary targets of online scams and fraud. Technological innovations that enhance privacy should be welcomed rather than resisted. Instead of delaying such features, policymakers should focus on strengthening cybercrime enforcement, promoting digital awareness and ensuring that robust security measures evolve alongside technological progress. The objective should be to make digital communication both safer and more privacy-friendly.

SANJAY CHOPRA | MOHALI

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Remembering Urumchi, demanding justice

July 5 marks 17 years since the Urumchi violence of 2009, a tragedy that remains deeply significant for the Uyghur community. The anniversary serves as a reminder of the need for truth, justice and accountability wherever allegations of serious human rights violations arise. The events in Urumchi followed protests over the killing of Uyghur workers in Guangdong Province. According to human rights organisations, the subsequent crackdown resulted in hundreds of deaths, widespread detentions and lasting trauma for countless families. Over the years, several governments, researchers and rights groups have expressed grave concern over the treatment of Uyghurs in Xinjiang, while the Chinese government has consistently rejected allegations of abuses. Commemorating such anniversaries is important not merely to remember those affected but also to reinforce the universal principles of human dignity, freedom and justice.

The international community should continue to support independent investigations, encourage constructive dialogue and uphold international human rights standards. Lasting peace can only be achieved when accountability, transparency and respect for fundamental freedoms prevail over repression and silence.

HENA ZUBERI | WASHINGTON DC

Put students before politics

The continuing protest at Jantar Mantar, led by activist Sonam Wangchuk, reflects growing concerns over issues affecting students, including examination irregularities and accountability in public institutions. Hunger strikes and prolonged demonstrations often draw attention to important grievances, but they also carry serious health risks for those participating. The allegations of paper leaks, the distress experienced by students and the reported rise in student suicides demand prompt and transparent action from the authorities. Public confidence in examinations can only be restored through impartial investigations, stronger safeguards against malpractice and timely reforms that ensure fairness and credibility.

At the same time, democratic protests should remain peaceful and constructive, while governments must engage sincerely with those raising legitimate concerns. Dialogue is always preferable to confrontation, especially when the future of millions of students is at stake. Education should never become a casualty of political differences. The priority must be to protect the integrity of examinations, restore trust in public institutions and provide students with an environment where merit, transparency and accountability prevail over uncertainty and controversy.

BHAGWAN THADANI | MUMBAI

Beyond sensationalism

The Lohagad murder case has become less a matter of justice and more a media spectacle. Television channels have devoted endless coverage to every development, often prioritising sensationalism over responsible reporting. Such excessive attention may attract viewers, but it also risks trivialising a tragic crime and causing further distress to those affected. What is even more disturbing is that countless similar crimes receive little or no attention because they lack public appeal or commercial value.

This selective outrage reflects an unhealthy media culture where headlines often determine public concern. Once the spotlight fades, many victims and their families are forgotten, while the demand for justice loses momentum. The incident also compels us to reflect on broader social issues. Strong family values, ethical education, empathy and respect for others remain the foundation of a healthy society. Cultural influences from across the world can be enriching, but they should be embraced thoughtfully rather than imitated blindly. Real progress lies not in televised debates or sensational coverage but in nurturing responsible citizens and ensuring that justice receives sustained attention, irrespective of media interest.

RS NARULA | PATIALA

Ancient Indian style: A heritage waiting to power the economy

India's ancient sculptures, paintings and literary traditions testify to a civilisation which had refined aesthetic sensibilities. Reimagining this rich legacy through innovation, design and entrepreneurship can transform India's cultural heritage into a dynamic driver of economic growth, global competitiveness and creative leadership



RAGHVENDRA SINGH

footwear, et al. What we see of these still imparts a superlative feel and continues to inspire the top echelons involved in the industry of contemporary couture.

The clothing and adornments of yore were not merely utilitarian. In Harappan culture, one of the world's oldest urban cultures, attire included meticulously crafted gold jewellery and garments made from fine cotton that were exquisitely embellished. The Rigveda, the oldest sacred text in India, provides insights into the importance of attire. Herodotus, a Greek historian, elucidates the quality of cotton produced in India.

As centuries passed, India became a reservoir of diverse influences, with dynasties and trade routes leaving indelible marks on the Indian 'stylescape'. The world-famous Sanchi, Bharhut, Gandhara, Mathura and Amravati masterpieces provide great insight into the apparel, hairstyle, jewellery and adornments of the Mauryan, Shunga, Kushan and later periods. Cave paintings from Ajanta showcases a diverse array of garments with intricate patterns and colours. These paintings are a rich repository of intricate hairstyles, headgear and ornaments from the period.

The sculptures of Sanchi, Bharhut, Gandhara, Mathura and Amravati are approximately 2000 years old and are India's exquisite world marvels. We all know that the Ajanta (a world heritage site) paintings are sublime. And Bharhut represents the peoples' movement in sculptural art (2nd to 1st Century BCE). Bharhut is an elegant example of the first usage of stone sculpture on such a large scale. It mirrors the society of its times with intricate carvings of beautiful garments and ornaments. Similarly, the Sanchi 'Toranas' echo the sophistry of the Indian society two millennia back. Ajanta, a great human experience, is the only remaining evidence of the style of painting that developed in India and traveled across Central Asia, China, Japan and Korea. The Ajanta caves of the earlier phase date from 2nd Century BCE. The remnants of paintings at Ajanta truly inspire a sense of awe and admiration. The hairstyles, the ornamentations and clothes worn by figures are quite similar to those sculpted at Sanchi and Bharhut.

The Gandhara and the Mathura styles are also a mirror image of the society that existed then. The best-known testimonials of the Gandhara style was the colossal rock hewn statues of Bamiyan, destroyed in 2001. They were perhaps one of the most impressive creations in the history of mankind. The Gandharan art had Hellenistic influence. The population of Gandhara was culturally Indian, not only because the region had become part of the Indian Mauryan empire, but also because the Vedic civilization had spread its influence in this region too.

Mathura had its golden days from the 1st Century AD till the 5th. The Mathura School of Art adopted its tradition from Bharhut and Sanchi, as also Gandharan. The earlier period of Amravati sculptures compare in style to Bharhut, while the later period compares to Mathura school. The Amravati sculptures were the glory of ancient Indian Buddhism, one of the most magnificent. Lost and forgotten, it lay buried until rediscovered in the 1790s. The Amravati sculptures are treasures of composition and compactness.

The inspiration for Indian stylescape and its classical and timeless elegance in terms of ornamentation, dress and style comes from these classics of sculptures and paintings. They are the realistic portrayal of polish that existed in the ancient Indian society.

In these sculptures and paintings one gets the glimpse of classical fashion practices through Keshha (hairstyle), Shirabhushan (headgear) and the accompanying jewellery) and Patta (garment). One can discern the brilliance of the textiles categorised into Uttariya (upper garment) and Antariya (lower garment) and the intricately designed waistbands, Paduka (footwear) and Alamkar (jewellery to ornament the body).

Examples of ancient art galleries are found in



ancient Indian literature. Mathura was a great center that boasts of some of the best portrait sculptures unearthed in India. They are of early vintage and by far the most famous. Many of the statues sculpted were housed in 'Devakula'.

Kalidas in "Raghuvansham" refers to a visit of Lord Ram to a Devakula, a Chitrashala (an art gallery of its times) to see the portrait of his father, Dasaratha, upon his return to Ayodhya from exile: "He [Ram] entered with tears in his eyes, the memorial palace of his father, of whom all that remained now was his portrait."

During the time of Panini, the term Salabhanjika connoted games in which girls gathered flowers from the branches of trees like 'Sala' and 'Ashoka'. The motif of the woman beside the tree continued through centuries, irrespective of the presence of the 'Sala' tree. "Damsel, holding on to the side of the window, with her body flexed beautifully like a bow and with her pearl necklace, looked like a carved decorative figure on the 'torana' gateway", are lines taken from Buddhacharita.

In the realm of Indian jewellery, gold reigned supreme. It was more than a precious metal. Gold stood synonymous with Lakshmi, the goddess of wealth. As one gazes upon the intricate designs and exquisite details of the Sirkap (Gandharan) artefacts, one cannot help being reminded of the enduring power of human creativity and the timeless allure of adornments that transcend the boundaries of time. Sirkap was situated in the Punjab region. It was on the opposite bank of Taxila. It emerged as a vibrant center of trade, connecting east to the west, attracting merchants from China, Greece and Rome. This historical enclave left behind a legacy of Indo-Greek jewellery that is mesmerising. In the early 20th century, the archaeologists excavated the captivating remnants of an impeccably well planned city, making an astonishing discovery of this brilliant gold jewellery collection that is currently with the National Museum in Delhi. The legacy of Sirkap jewellery lies not only in its visual splendour, but also in the skill and dedication of the artisans who created these masterpieces. They stand as a testament to beauty, creativity and self-expression.

The sculptures in India abound in elaborate dressing of hair with flowers, pearls and jewels. Kalidasa in Raghuvansham has so beautifully compared the hair dress to the dark stream of Yamuna: "There from his palace, he saw the Yamuna with golden flamingos and admired it as if it were the plaited hair of the

goddess of earth bedecked with golden strips." In Bharhut, there are exquisite representations of pearl-net decorations for the hair. This charming style of hair dress is also recorded in the early paintings of Ajanta.

What is remarkable is the praxis of style that constitutes the interplay of paintings, literature and sculpture in ancient India. Dynamics that involve the three elements are incredible. What is left unexplained by one is abundantly furnished by the other two, as in the case of 'saalbhanjikas' and many other such architectural motifs. The same applies to symbolisms in paintings and literature, whether it be Ajanta or Kalidas. The Sangam literature south of Vindhya and the 'Puyas' of India's north-east complete the pan-Indian narrative of yore.

The timeless elegance of Indian style is classical. It has not gone out of vogue. It continues to be appropriate, suitable and applicable even now. From the headgear to the torso, down to the leg-wear, the patterns and concepts have endured, as if ageless. With a touch of irony, it can unequivocally be said that the quintessentially iconic Indian themes have been artistically and commercially exploited by entrepreneurs all over the world. Somehow, it has escaped us to take advantage of our traditionally refined vintage assets - sculptures, paintings and literature, that seamlessly feed into each other creating perfect stories.

History is witness to the comparative world advantage India has enjoyed in the sector of traditional economy. Our conventional weavers and crafts persons, who should ordinarily revel in prominence, wealth and status, struggle for existence nowadays. It has been more than 75 years after India's independence. Their plight has not improved since. It is high time that Indian delved into its priceless resource to develop products that manifest its classic refinement with authentic accounts.

The creative economy sector in India is almost a clean slate with immense possibilities. The heritage crafts, doubtless, are the basis of any creative economy. Aligning them with innovation and product development will provide an edge to this artistry, enabling them to compete at national or world platforms.

Skilling, design intervention, mainstreaming capital investment, encouraging start-ups, incubation etc. will assuredly provide a strong fillip to our sector of creative traditional economy. This is the need of the hour.

The writer is former Culture Secretary, Govt of India and advisor Bharat Ki Soch

The Himalayas cannot carry unlimited development



UMESH RAJ | MOLOY BORA

of the figures. In the past two decades, glacial melting has nearly doubled in the Hindu Kush Himalaya region, with the area experiencing a 12 per cent decline in glacial cover between 1990 and 2020 (ICIMOD, 2026). There has been a 21 per cent decrease in glacial cover in the Ganga Basin, an icy shield that supports over 400 million lives. The Glacial Lakes Atlas of ISRO has reported 2,400 such glacial lakes, with 601 having doubled in size and are at risk of bursting into floods. Glacial retreat could cost the South Asian economy 6 per cent GDP growth till 2050 (ISRO, 2024). The Sikkim GLOF of 2023 provided an example of what such a path would be like. Permafrost erosion led to a landslide into South Lhonak Lake, producing a flood surge of 20 metres in height, which resulted in the destruction of Teesta-III dam, with at least 90 fatalities and flooding 276 square kilometres of agricultural lands (Sattar et al., 2025). The intensity of precipitation further aggravates the situation. According to reports, Himachal Pradesh witnessed 46 instances of cloudburst during 2025, 10 of which took place in a day, causing ₹4,800 crore loss to the economy, resulting in a death toll of 448 people. As per the World Meteorological Organisation (WMO), 2024 was recorded as the hottest year globally, resulting in a loss of 450 billion tonnes of glacier ice (WMO, 2024). Intensity of rainfall has increased by 15-20 per cent in the Indian Himalayan region since the 1950s. Climate change is not the only factor influencing this phenomenon. Human actions have stretched far beyond what the environment can support. The tourists who visited Uttarakhand grew 61.79 per cent in five years and were up to 5.96 crore by 2023. In Himachal Pradesh, the growth in the number of tourists increased thrice between 2021 and 2024.

The Char Dham Yatra clearly defines the paradox. During the year 2025, more than 51 lakh pilgrims performed their worship at these shrines; however, 72 percent of these devotees made the pilgrimage in the first 60 days, causing extreme strain on the trails due to early-season pressure. It was estimated that the shrine of Kedarnath had disposed of around 2,324 tonnes of trash for the season 2024-2025. The Eastern Himalaya and India's northeastern states harbour distinct and, in several respects, more acute pressures. This arc faces compounding stresses: hydropower proliferation, expanding road corridors, and the erosion of indigenous land-management systems that once stabilised fragile slopes. The state of Arunachal Pradesh alone has recognised hydroelectric projects amounting to over 10,000 MW on the Brahmaputra's tributaries whose combined hydrological impacts have been woefully insufficiently evaluated. Governance challenges specific to this area, including indigenous land claims, border issues, and limited capacities, make implementation of the policy difficult. The Sikkim GLOF that occurred in 2023 was not just a localised event. It was a wake-up call regarding development priorities.

The structural contradiction that lies at the core of such crises deserves to be addressed explicitly. The mountain states' economic development strategy is based increasingly on generating income from tourism, pilgrim circuits, hydropower projects, and infrastructure-led constructions, despite the fact that their ecological carrying capacity is increasingly under strain. This poses a problem in terms of governance: the activities which generate income are those that cause disruption to the fragile ecosystem. Scholarly evidence confirms that while tourism-induced urbanisation in Uttarakhand provided employment for 35per cent of the youth each year, it resulted in agricultural production dropping by 19-55 per cent, and food shortages increasing to 65 per cent-95 per cent. When fiscal incentives push states toward expanding precisely those activities straining ecological capacity, voluntary restraint becomes structurally improbable. What is required is not merely better environmental compliance but a reorientation of mountain state fiscal models - one that recognises intact watersheds, standing forests, and stable slopes as quantifiable economic assets rather than obstacles to development. Indian government's reaction to climate change is changing as well. Disaster Management (Amendment) Act, 2025 requires a National Disaster Database along with Urban Disaster Management Authorities (PIB, 2025). The state of Uttarakhand is changing its building regulations because of the newly assigned status of Seismic Zone VI. Finally, the "Right to be Free from Adverse Climate Effects" has been recognised, and carrying capacity assessments have been ordered in 12 Himalayan States and UTs.

However, signs will not be enough; carrying capacity evaluations need to be implemented as enforceable land use standards rather than merely as reports. The National Mission for Sustaining the Himalayan Ecosystem has been funding more than one hundred vulnerability assessments, but has been accused of institutional silos making such research unattainable by the people. That the NMSHE had to withhold certain findings under the pretext of strategic sensitivity at the start of 2026 (Economic Times, 2026) should worry anyone familiar with the fact that mountains don't care about classified reports. There are better solutions. The HUBS initiative brings natural solutions to water management and waste management in the hills such as Nainital and Gangtok (NMHS, 2026). The Parvatmala initiative's 1,200 km of cable car rides ensures that zero-footprint travel does not destabilise the slopes in any way. A 30-year-old effort to restore the hills in Uttarakhand has turned degraded lands into thriving biodiversity. The trouble with the Himalayan region does not lie in the fact that time is running out owing to only climate change. Time is running out owing to the way institutional responses to the changes have been reactionary, disorganised, and always lagging behind changes in the ecology.

These are living, geological formations, which are young, unstable, hydrological, and subject to extremes increasing at an even more rapid pace than was initially modeled. The dilemma that lies before India is one of civilisational adaptation, where economic aspiration is balanced with natural limits. The carrying capacity does not limit economic aspiration but, in fact, forms the cornerstone of any enduring process of development within such fragile mountain environments. It will not be a function of how fast roads, dams, and tourism belts are built, but rather of whether governance mechanisms have learned once again to live within ecological limits.

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Taking the university to the village: Lessons from Unnat Bharat Abhiyan



M AFSHAR ALAM

Ministry of Education, challenges that assumption. It asks universities to walk into villages, listen before they teach, and treat rural India not as a subject of study but as a partner in problem solving. Having steered this programme at Jamia Hamdard through much of my tenure as Vice Chancellor, I have come to see it as one of the more quietly transformative ideas in our higher education landscape.

The premise of Unnat Bharat Abhiyan is simple.

Every participating institution adopts a cluster of villages and commits its faculty and students to understanding local problems on the ground, whether these concern sanitation, livelihoods, health awareness or basic infrastructure. Solutions are then designed using the institution's own academic and technical strengths.

At Jamia Hamdard, this meant our engineering, pharmacy, medical and legal faculties working together in villages such as Saidul Azab on the outskirts of Delhi, addressing problems that ranged from waste management to public hygiene, often through small, replicable interventions rather than grand announcements.

One project that stays with me involved a village chaupal that had become a site of neglect. Our Computer Science and Engineering department, working with student volunteers, repainted the community space using bacteria resistant materials, installed smart waste bins and distributed hygiene kits to residents. It was not a large project by budgetary standards. But it demonstrated something important: that a university's technical expertise, however specialised, can be redirected toward the ordinary and urgent needs of the communities living in its shadow.

Similar efforts followed in the years after, including collaborations between our law students and rural residents through youth parlia-

ment initiatives that introduced constitutional literacy at the grassroots.

What makes this model valuable is not the scale of any single project but the discipline it imposes on institutions. Faculty members accustomed to laboratories and lecture halls are compelled to sit in a village chaupal and listen to concerns that rarely appear in a syllabus.

Students, many of them from urban backgrounds, encounter a version of India that their



around it. Jamia Hamdard's own founding ethos, rooted in Hakeem Abdul Hameed Sahab's vision of service alongside

scholarship, made this an easy fit. But I would argue that every institution, regardless of its founding history, stands to benefit from being asked this question regularly.

None of this is to suggest that Unnat Bharat Abhiyan is without its limitations. Faculty participation often depends on the enthusiasm of

coursework does not always prepare them for. This exposure has an educational value that is difficult to measure through conventional academic metrics, yet it is precisely the kind of grounding the National Education Policy 2020 envisions when it speaks of experiential learning and social responsibility as core components of a university education.

There is also a quieter institutional benefit. Programmes of this kind force universities to move beyond ranking exercises and accreditation cycles, important as those are, and ask a more basic question: what has this institution actually done for the community

a small number of coordinators rather than being embedded into institutional incentive structures. Funding for sustained, multi year village engagement remains modest compared to research grants.

And the danger of projects becoming one time events, a hygiene kit distributed here, a rally organised there, rather than sustained partnerships, is real and needs continuous correction. If the programme is to deepen rather than merely persist, universities will need to treat rural engagement with the same seriousness they bring to research output and placement statistics.

Still, five years of watching this programme grow at Jamia Hamdard has convinced me that its underlying idea deserves wider institutional commitment. As India's universities compete for global rankings and research visibility, it is worth remembering that a university's first and most immediate community is often the one just beyond its gates.

Unnat Bharat Abhiyan offers a modest but genuine correction to that oversight. It is a reminder that higher education institutions are not islands of expertise but participants in the life of the country they serve, and that some of the most meaningful learning happens not in the classroom but in the village chaupal.

(The author served as Vice Chancellor of Jamia Hamdard, New Delhi, from 2021 to 2026



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**Thane court acquits woman
in human trafficking case**



A Thane court has acquitted a 36-year-old woman accused in a human trafficking case, observing that the failure of the prosecution to examine the victims and the decoy customer reduced their claims to "hearsay". Holding that the prosecution failed to prove its case beyond reasonable doubt, Additional Sessions Judge RS Bhakare on Wednesday acquitted Karuna alias Gudiya Hemant Biswas, a resident of Shil Daighar in Maharashtra's Thane district. According to the prosecution, the Thane police's Anti-Human Trafficking Cell conducted a raid at Shiva Lodging and Boarding in Kalyan on August 26, 2019, after sending a decoy customer. The police claimed to have caught the accused along with two female victims in a room there and recovered marked currency notes of ₹4,500. However, the court noted that the victims and the decoy customer were not examined during the trial as the prosecution failed to secure their presence. "The witness summons had been sent to them, but the prosecution could not secure their presence. Several times the summons sent to the victims returned unserved. As the victims have not been examined, whatever they have disclosed before the prosecution witnesses is hearsay in nature. It is a weak piece of evidence," it said. Moreover, the decoy customer, who was the best witness, has also not been examined by the prosecution, the court noted. Under the Immoral Traffic (Prevention) Act, the prosecution must establish components of active inducement, control, or living off the earnings of prostitution, which could not be substantiated without the primary witnesses, it observed. A panch witness also turned hostile, admitting during cross-examination that he had signed the pre-raid and post-raid panchanamas directly at the police station rather than at the spot, making his testimony unreliable. (PTI)

**CBI to get granted sanction
to prosecute KSCDC officials**



The state Government on Thursday told the Kerala High Court that it has decided to grant sanction to the CBI to prosecute KSCDC officials in a 2015 corruption case. Justice A Badharudeen recorded the submission by Advocate General Jaju Babu that sanction for prosecution will be granted to the agency and directed that the same be produced on the next date of hearing on July 8. The court was hearing a contempt petition filed by Kollam native Kadakampally Manoj alleging non-compliance with its directions regarding the grant of sanction to the CBI to prosecute Kerala State Cashew Development Corporation (KSCDC) officials in the graft case. The corruption case dates back to 2015 when the CBI registered a case into alleged irregularities in the KSCDC following directions from the High Court. After completing its investigation, the agency sought sanction from the state Government to prosecute the accused, including former KSCDC chairman R Chandrasekharan. Subsequently, Manoj approached the court seeking implementation of its directions to grant prosecution sanction to the CBI. Following repeated delays in granting sanction, the single bench initiated contempt proceedings and directed the personal appearance of the Principal Secretary of the Industries Department. (PTI)

Karnataka HC stays State Cabinet decision to withdraw 52 criminal cases

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

The High Court of Karnataka on Thursday stayed the state cabinet's decision to withdraw prosecution in 52 criminal cases, including those linked to the 2022 Aland Ladle Mashak Dargah riots. The bench of Chief Justice Vibhu Bakhru and Justice KS Hemalekha prima facie found fault with the State's invocation of Section 321 CrPc violating the earlier order of the HC to seek withdrawal of prosecutions against the accused. The court issued notice to the state government and the Directorate of Prosecution, and directed them to file their responses



within two weeks. Advocate Girish Bharadwaj had petitioned the court to issue a writ of certiorari or any other appropriate writ to quash the Government order dated May 27 directing the Public Prosecutors under Section 321 of the Code of Criminal Procedure, 1973/ cor-



Who owns the mandate?

The TMC rebellion and the next test of India's anti-defection law



VIVEK NARAYAN
SHARMA

Nearly four decades after India enacted the anti-defection law to curb political horse-trading, the Constitution is once again confronting a question it has never fully answered, "When elected representatives abandon the political party on whose symbol they were elected, who truly owns the electoral mandate; the legislators or the political party?"

The ongoing controversy involving rebel Members of Parliament from the Trinamool Congress (TMC), coupled with recent developments within the Shiv Sena, has revived this constitutional debate in a manner that could significantly reshape India's anti-defection jurisprudence. What appears at first glance to be another episode of political realignment may ultimately become one of the most important constitutional tests since the Supreme Court's landmark Shiv Sena judgment.

Recent reports suggest that the rebel TMC MPs are no longer merely claiming protection under the merger exception contained in the Tenth Schedule; they are reportedly asserting a claim over the TMC itself. Simultaneously, several Members of Parliament belonging to Shiv Sena (UBT) have moved towards the Eknath Shinde-led Shiv Sena faction, which presently enjoys recognition from the Election Commission as the official Shiv Sena. These developments have transformed isolated political events into a larger constitutional contest concerning party identity, legislative loyalty and the ownership of the electoral mandate.

To appreciate the significance of the present controversy, one must revisit the origins of India's anti-defection law. The Tenth Schedule was introduced through the Fifty-Second Constitutional Amendment in 1985 in response to the infamous era of "Aaya Ram, Gaya Ram" politics.

Legislators frequently switched parties for office, influence and political advantage, leading to instability and erosion of public confidence in democratic institutions.

The anti-defection law sought to restore political stability by disqualifying legislators who voluntarily gave up membership of their political party or violated party discipline. Initially, the law contained two major exceptions — one relating to splits and another relating to mergers. The split provision soon became a convenient constitutional loophole, enabling legislators to engineer artificial factions to avoid disqualification. Parliament eventually abolished the split exception through the Ninety-First Constitutional Amendment in 2003. Today, the merger exception remains the sole constitutional shield available to legislators facing disqualification.

The current TMC controversy centres around Paragraph 4 of the Tenth Schedule, which protects legislators from disqualification if at least two-thirds members of a legislature party support a merger. On a plain reading, the provision appears straightforward. If the constitutional threshold is satisfied, why should disqualification follow?

Yet constitutional law is rarely that simple

The controversy raises a deeper question, "Can legislators carrying numerical strength within a legislature effectively transport an electoral mandate into another political formation even when the parent political party itself refuses to merge?" More importantly, "Can legislators claim ownership of the political party merely because they command a substantial majority within the legislature?"

The answers may lie in the shadow cast by the Supreme Court's Constitution Bench judgment in Subhash Desai v. Principal Secretary, Governor of Maharashtra(2023)arising from the Shiv Sena split.

The Shiv Sena dispute fundamentally altered the constitutional



conversation on defections. The rebel faction led by Eknath Shinde argued that numerical strength within the legislature entitled it to claim ownership of the political party itself. The Constitution Bench rejected that proposition.

The Court drew a critical distinction between a "political party" and a "legislature party." It held that elected representatives do not constitute an independent constitutional entity detached from the organisational structure of the political party. A legislature party remains connected to the parent political party and cannot automatically claim ownership merely because it commands superior numbers within the House.

This principle settled one constitutional controversy. The TMC dispute now presents the next. If the rebel TMC MPs are indeed claiming that they represent the "real" Trinamool Congress, the controversy begins to resemble the constitutional conflict witnessed in the Shiv Sena litigation. The Supreme Court's reasoning suggests that legislative strength alone may not be sufficient to establish ownership of a political party. Organisational legitimacy, party structure and recognition mechanisms under election law may become equally important considerations.

At the same time, the movement of Shiv Sena (UBT) MPs towards the

Shinde-led Shiv Sena presents a different legal question. Unlike the original Shiv Sena dispute, the Election Commission has already recognised the Shinde faction as the official Shiv Sena and allotted it the party name and symbol. This creates a fresh constitutional puzzle. Can legislators be accused of defection when they align themselves with the faction that presently enjoys legal recognition as the political party itself? The law remains unsettled, and future litigation may be required to clarify the position.

There are compelling arguments on both sides

There are compelling arguments on both sides. Supporters of the rebels contend that Paragraph 4 of the Tenth Schedule protects a merger supported by two-thirds members of the legislature party, irrespective of the parent party's wishes. Opponents argue that such an interpretation would undermine the anti-defection law by permitting defections through the back door.

At the centre of this constitutional drama stands the Speaker

Under Paragraph 6 of the Tenth Schedule, questions relating to disqualification are decided by the Speaker. Although the Constitution describes the Speaker's decision as final, the Supreme Court in

KihotoHollohan v. Zachillhu (1992) made it clear that such decisions remain subject to judicial review.

The Speaker, and eventually the constitutional courts, may therefore be required to answer a series of difficult questions:

- Is the alleged merger genuine?
- Can a legislature party invoke Paragraph 4 without the approval of the parent political party?
- Does the Shiv Sena judgment require primacy to be accorded to the organisational party?
- And most importantly, what exactly is the anti-defection law designed to protect — the political party, the legislative majority, or the electoral mandate itself?

Beyond the fortunes of any particular political party, these controversies expose a deeper weakness within India's anti-defection framework. The Constitution prescribes no mandatory timeline for deciding disqualification petitions. Consequently, legislators often continue functioning while constitutional questions remain unresolved. The very law intended to create political stability frequently generates prolonged uncertainty.

Ultimately, the TMC controversy and the continuing fallout of the Shiv Sena split raise a question that goes to the heart of representative democracy, "When citizens cast their vote, are they voting primarily for an individual candidate or for the political party represented by that candidate?"

The answer may determine the future direction of India's anti-defection law.

The Shiv Sena judgment answered one constitutional question. The TMC controversy may answer the next. And in doing so, it may well write the next chapter in India's evolving constitutional jurisprudence on defections, democracy and the ownership of the electoral mandate.

The author is an Advocate-On-Record at the Supreme Court of India, constitutional expert, accredited mediator and arbitrator, with over 26 years of experience in constitutional law, litigation, arbitration and public policy

SC dismisses plea against Manipur HC order extending panchayat polls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday refused to entertain a plea challenging the Manipur High Court order extending the deadline for conducting panchayat elections in the state to October 16 this year.

A partial working day bench comprising Justices N Kotiswar Singh and NV Anjaria dismissed the appeal filed by Pheiroijam Heramani and others against the May 19, 2026 judgement of the high court.

The bench took note of the submissions of Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Manipur government, that the state is bound by the directions of the high court and may be committing contempt if the polls of local bodies are not conducted.

It said there was no merit in the appeal to interfere with the high court order.



The high court had extended the deadline for conducting the sixth general panchayat elections to October 16. The high court bench comprising Chief Justice M Sundar and Justice A Guneshwar Sharma also cleared the path for the state to adopt a three-tier panchayati raj system in accordance with recent legislative amendments.

The matter before the high court arose from review petitions filed by the Manipur Government against a previous August 2025 order that had

mandated elections within six months.

The state argued before the high court that the prevailing law and order situation and the imposition of President's Rule in the state (effective February 2025) made holding immediate elections impracticable. Taking note of these "extraordinary circumstances," the high court modified its previous direction, allowing the state and the State Election Commission an extension until October 16, 2026, to complete the electoral process.

Honeymoon murder: Meghalaya Govt moves SC against bail order

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Meghalaya Government has moved the Supreme Court against the bail granted to Sonam Raghuvanshi, who is accused of murdering her husband during their honeymoon in the northeastern state in 2025.

A bench of justices MM Sundresh and Sheel Nagu was told by Solicitor General Tushar Mehta on Thursday that the high court has erred in granting bail to the prime accused in the case and sought urgent listing of the plea. Mehta submitted that bail was granted as the grounds of arrest were not fully supplied to her at the time of arrest.

"The concerned non-supply of documents relates to a provision that was wrongly cited due to a typographical error," he said, while emphasising that there was a chance of the accused absconding. The bench agreed to list the



matter for hearing on Friday. Sonam, a resident of Indore in Madhya Pradesh, was arrested in June last year in connection with the murder of her businessman husband Raja Raghuvanshi. The couple had gone missing while vacationing in Meghalaya's Sohra area on May 23 last year. Subsequently, Raja's body was found in a deep gorge on June 2 in 2025.

Police have alleged that Sonam conspired with hired assailants to kill her husband for financial gains. On June 29, the Meghalaya High Court had upheld a trial court order

granting bail to Sonam. The high court had dismissed the criminal petition filed by the state government, seeking cancellation of the bail granted by the trial court on April 27.

It held that the manner in which the grounds of arrest were prepared reflected a "total non-application of judicial mind". "It is evident that such preparation was made without any application of mind... and nowhere is found any specific allegation or information as to what are the actual charges against her," the high court had observed.

"If this is the manner in which the intimation of the grounds of arrest is made, the same reflects a total non-application of judicial mind on the part of the arresting agency," it had observed.

The high court had dismissed the state's petition, holding that there were no grounds to exercise its inherent powers to cancel the bail.

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NEW DELHI | FRIDAY | JULY 3, 2026

BUSINESS11

Suzuki Motorcycle India posts 21% sales growth in June

Japanese two-wheeler maker Suzuki Motorcycle on Thursday said its total vehicle sales in India witnessed a 21 per cent on-year growth in June to 1,15,030 units. The company had sold a total of 95,244 two-wheelers in May 2025, Suzuki Motorcycle India said. Domestic sales for June increased to 91,264 units, up 23 per cent from 73,934 units a year ago, it said, adding exports stood at 23,766 units for the reporting month, with a 12 per cent year-on-year growth, compared to 21,310 units exported in June 2025, it said. The company's sales performance in June reflects the sustained momentum, supported by strong demand, said Deepak Mutreja, Vice President for Sales and Marketing at Suzuki Motorcycle India Pvt Ltd. (PTI)

TVS Motor June sales jump 47% to 5.9 lakh units

TVS Motor Company on Thursday reported a 47 per cent year-on-year increase in total sales to 590,003 units in June 2026, compared with 402,001 units in the same month last year. Total two-wheelers sales, including moped, registered a growth of 47 per cent at 565,417 units in the previous month as against 385,698 units in June 2025, the company said in a statement. Domestic two-wheeler sales in June stood at 411,014 units, registering a 46 per cent growth from 281,012 units in the same month last year, the company said. Motorcycles registered a growth of 42 per cent during the reporting month with sales of 267,096 units as against 188,774 units in June 2025 while scooters sales jumped 53 per cent year-on-year at 247,950 in previous month as against 162,291 units in June 2025. (PTI)

J&K Bank hits ₹3L cr business mark on 16% deposit growth

The Jammu and Kashmir Bank on Thursday said its total business has crossed the ₹3 trillion mark in the first quarter of this fiscal, driven by over 16 per cent growth in deposits and more than 25 per cent growth in gross advances. The Bank has registered total business of ₹3.04 trillion, (₹1.73 trillion in deposits and ₹1.31 trillion in gross advances) with an year-on-year growth of over 20 per cent backed by healthy increase of over 16 per cent in deposits and over 25 per cent in gross advances, a spokesman of the bank said on Thursday. "Marking a defining milestone in its 88-year journey, J&K Bank has crossed the historic ₹3 trillion total business mark at the close of the June quarter (Q1 FY2026-27), reaffirming its position among the country's strongest and fastest-transforming financial institutions," the spokesman said. Managing Director & CEO Amitava Chatterjee congratulated all stakeholders and expressed gratitude to promoters, customers, shareholders and employees for shaping the bank's remarkable journey. (PTI)

Rupee falls 18 paise to close at 95.34 against US dollar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

The rupee pared initial gains and settled for the day on a negative note, lower by 18 paise at 95.34 (provisional) against the US dollar on Thursday, as the support from easing crude oil prices was negated by robust dollar demand from importers and corporate hedgers. Forex traders said the Indian rupee opened higher on an overnight decline in the US dollar following less hawkish comments from Fed Chair Kevin Warsh and a fall in crude oil prices. However, the rupee lost its initial gains on FI outflows and dollar demand from hedgers. At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 94.95 against the American cur-

rency and traded in a range of 94.90-95.40 during the session. The rupee finally closed at 95.34 (provisional), registering a decline of 18 paise from its previous close. On Wednesday, the rupee depreciated 60 paise to close at 95.16 against the US dollar. "We expect the rupee to trade with a negative bias on uncertainty over the US and Iran deal despite positive comments from US President Donald Trump. However, any softening of the US dollar on less hawkish comments from the Fed may support the rupee at lower levels." Declining crude oil prices may also support the rupee at lower levels. Traders may take cues from weekly employment claims and the non-farm payrolls report from the US. USD-INR spot price is

Date	Rate (₹ per US \$)	Change
June 24	94.45	
June 25	94.55	+21p
June 29	94.51	-06p
June 30	94.56	-05p
July 1	95.16	-60p
July 2	95.34*	-18p

*Provisional
(Inverted scale) KBK Infographics

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | FRIDAY | JULY 3, 2026

How India averted energy crisis during Hormuz war

TUSHAR GUPTA

Six years. Five external shocks. Covid in 2020. The Supply Chain Crisis in 2021. The Russia-Ukraine War in 2022. The Tariff War in 2025. And now, the Hormuz War in 2026. Each of these shocks was, on its own, capable of blowing a hole in the Centre's fiscal math. Covid did it literally, pushing the fiscal deficit past 9 per cent. The Supply Chain Crisis did it through imported inflation. 2022 did it through crude at \$120. The Tariff War did it by threatening \$48 billion of exports overnight. Hormuz did it by taking a fifth of the world's oil supply hostage for four months. What deserves more credit than it gets is this; despite absorbing the four shocks before Hormuz, one after another, without room to recover in between, India walked into the middle of 2026 with its fiscal house still in order. That was not an accident, and it was not luck. It was agile policymaking. Layer the fiscal deficit on top of that. The Centre had committed, back in 2021-22, to bring the fiscal deficit below 4.5 per cent of GDP by FY26. It delivered exactly that, at 4.4 per cent, before a war shut down a fifth of global oil supply. FY27 is budgeted lower still, at 4.3 per cent. This number will witness a revision, though not an alarming

one. Forex reserves sit north of \$680 billion, enough to cover eleven months of imports, even after the RBI sold tens of billions of dollars defending the rupee through March. The parallel to 2022 is instructive, and largely underappreciated. This is where Hardeep Singh Puri's Ministry scored a huge win. That year, India went from importing almost no Russian crude to importing close to 40 per cent of its daily requirement at peak, doing so while much of the West objected loudly. 2026 has been the same movie, except the stage was on fire this time. By February, sanctions on Rosneft and Lukoil, impacting market dynamics, had already forced Indian refiners to throttle Russian imports down to roughly a quarter of the basket. On the last day of February, the Hormuz was shut. No ships or tankers could go in or out. Middle Eastern supply, which had made up over half of India's crude imports, collapsed by more than 60 per cent. India went back to Russia. By June, Russian crude had hit a record 2.6-2.7 million barrels a day, over half of total imports. Factor in shadow-fleet volumes that don't register cleanly on AIS trackers, and the honest range through this period has been a steady 35-45 per cent. A trade deal struck with Washington in February had reportedly extracted a promise to wind these purchases down. New Delhi never confirmed any such promise, and within weeks the purchases had

not merely continued, they had hit an all-time high. Those who were bearish on the Ministry of Petroleum's capacity were humbled. Both administrations, Biden's and Trump's, tried the same play. Both got the same answer. The calculation in New Delhi has not changed across two very different American presidencies: energy security for 1.4 billion people is not a bargaining chip in Washington's Ukraine strategy or its Iran strategy. Call it bravado, call it pragmatism, but this is the new Indian mindset the West will have to acquaint itself with. Because the fiscal cushion existed, the Centre could afford to absorb the hit directly rather than pass it on. On March 27, excise duty was cut by ₹10 a litre on both petrol and diesel, bringing diesel duty effectively to zero. This was the Centre taking global crude volatility onto its own balance sheet. However, the states, who levy VAT on top and control roughly a quarter of the retail price, did precisely nothing. Not one matched the cut.

The burden-sharing that fiscal federalism is meant to deliver simply did not show up. Retail pump prices absorbed most of the public attention through this period, but commercial crude stability is the story that actually mattered, and it went almost entirely unremarked upon. Even with the excise cut in place, fuel prices rose again in May, because OMC losses had widened too far for the duty cut alone to absorb, and the war's endpoint remained unknowable at the time. That May increase was the last lever left, not the first one pulled. Commercial and logistics costs never entered double-digit inflation. There was no cascading cost-of-production shock and no MSME collapse, despite a fifth of the world's oil supply being taken off the board for months. Diplomacy played a quieter but equally important role. Tankers that had already been rerouted deep into Asian waters were turned back for Indian ports. The Petroleum Ministry was

working overtime to ensure an uninterrupted supply of crude at the Indian shores. In New Delhi, the Prime Minister's regime worked with Iran channel directly to keep India-bound cargo moving even while the Strait remained live with mines and gunfire. Hormuz cannot be read in isolation. The excise cut was possible only because of the fiscal discipline built across five consecutive shocks. And here is the number that should end most arguments on this subject: Nirmala Sitharaman presented four budgets: 2020, 2021, 2022, and 2026, that were each blindsided by a crisis within weeks of the speech. Despite that, the same government still delivered the income tax cut and the GST rationalisation in between. Much of the operational credit for this belongs to Hardeep Singh Puri. As Petroleum Minister, Puri was the one standing in Parliament through the worst of it, laying out numbers rather than reassurances. LPG procurement, historically 60 per cent dependent on the Gulf, was diversified within days to the United States, Norway, Canada, Algeria and Russia, with domestic LPG output pushed up 28 per cent through refinery directives under an Essential Commodities Act order. None of this made for dramatic television, which is presumably why it went largely uncelebrated. It was the unglamorous machinery of these ministries that had clearly rehearsed for this moment long before the Strait actually shut.

Free trade agreements to give major boost to toy exports: Industry experts

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The series of free trade agreements (FTAs) finalised by India, including the ones with the UK and the European Union, will give a major boost to toy exports, according to industry officials.

Under the free trade agreements with the EU and UK, Indian toys will get zero duty access, Toy Association of India Chairman Manu Giota said. At present, the products face about 5-6 per cent import duty in these two markets. "These FTAs will catapult us into the major league, he said, adding that these markets account for about 16 per cent of the country's total toy exports, which stood at USD 0.35 billion in 2024. India signed a trade pact with the UK last year, and it will come into force from July 15. The agreement with the 27-nation EU is likely to be signed by December this year and may be implemented next year. Gupta, who is also the CEO of Playgro Toys India, said that huge investments are coming into the sector due to the business-friendly policies of the Narendra Modi-led gov-

ernment.

Playgro has invested about ₹82 crore to set up a manufacturing capacity in Ujjain. The company, he said, has employed about 500 people and the number will be increased to 800 soon. He indicated that one more investment is in the pipeline. Talking about the free trade agreements, Amitabh Kharbanda, Promotor of Sunlord Group, said that the Indian industry should prepare itself to take advantage of these pacts as it will create massive export opportunities. He said that the UK and the EU have stringent quality standards and regulations which Indian toy makers have to meet to tap into these markets. "We need good testing facilities in India. The government is helping us. The UK and the

EU are focusing on sustainability issues," Kharbanda said, adding that his company is setting up a unit in Bihta in Bihar. To showcase Indian industry prowess in toy sector, Gupta said the association is organising a four-day international exhibition at Bharat Mandapam here from July 4. Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal will inaugurate the 17th Toy BIZ International Exhibition. Over 300 Indian companies are participating in the expo to showcase 400 brands in areas such as educational toys, plastic toys, soft toys, and electronic toys. "We are expecting 20,000 domestic visitors. Participants from regions like Europe, the Middle East, South East Asia, US and South America are expected to attend expo," Gupta added.

Credit market doubles to \$25 bn in 5 years: Moody's

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India's private credit market has doubled in size in the past five years to about \$25 billion in Assets Under Management (AUM) as of 2025 end, and will further expand amid strong financing demand, Moody's Ratings said on Thursday. However, the new RBI norms which allow banks to finance acquisitions will increase competition in a segment historically dominated by alternative capital. "While the new rules may benefit borrowers by lower-

ing costs for financing and increasing its availability, they could compress yields and reduce deal flows for private credit providers for acquisition financing,"

Moody's said.

As per the new RBI rules effective July 1, RBI, for the first time, has allowed banks to fund strategic acquisitions of equity shares and compul-

sorily convertible debentures, subject to certain conditions. Moody's said India's private credit market has expanded rapidly over the past five years, evolving from a source of financing primarily for distressed companies to a provider of credit for a wider mix of financially stable businesses. "India's private credit market has grown rapidly in the past five years - to more than \$11 billion in annual transaction value in 2025 and about \$25 billion in AUM as of the end of that year - it remains small by global standards", Moody's said.

RBI's concessional swap facility to boost overseas borrowing: S&P

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The concessional swap facility provided by the RBI would lower funding costs for many government-owned financial institutions that are now likely to increase their external borrowings, S&P Global Ratings said on Thursday.

To shore up foreign capital inflow, last month, the Reserve Bank had announced opening of a concessional forex swap facility to encourage PSUs to raise external commercial borrowings (ECBs) until September 30. Under this, RBI will offer a concessional 1.5 per cent per annum premium on fixed US dollar/Indian rupee swaps for 3-5 years for the ECBs raised by public sector companies. S&P said the swap agreement eliminates currency risk at a much lower cost than the market.

S&P said the new concessional swap agreement offered by the Reserve Bank of India eliminates currency risk at a much lower cost than the market. This should benefit funding costs for many government-owned financial institutions that are

now likely to increase their external borrowings.

In a report titled 'Indian Government-owned financial institutions: The RBI swap effect will increase offshore activity', S&P said government linkages provide financial flexibility, access to cheaper funding, and a mechanism for asset quality support for these entities. S&P Global Ratings analyst Geeta Chugh said incentivising overseas borrowings by government-owned financial institutions draws in foreign exchange to bolster reserves and support the rupee. "... channeling this international capital through institutional lenders creates a powerful credit multiplier effect across the Indian economy," said Chugh. Financial services is one of four strategic sectors in India. As such, government-related

RBI ANNOUNCED OPENING OF CONCESSIONAL FOREX SWAP FACILITY TO BOOST PSUS TO RAISE EXTERNAL COMMERCIAL BORROWINGS

entities (GREs) in the sector are more likely to benefit from government support. This is particularly so for those that play policy roles. GREs in the financial sector include PFC, REC, IRFC, NABARD, NHB, EXIM, HUDCO, SIDBI, IREDA and NaBFID. S&P said government linkages provide financial flexibility, access to cheaper funding, and a mechanism for asset quality support. GREs dominate the financial sector in India. Many nonbank GREs operate in segments that are of national interest. "We expect loan growth for financial GREs to stay at about 15 per cent per year over the next two years, aided by mandates to drive the development of strategic sectors," S&P Global Ratings credit analyst Deepali Seth-Chhabria said.

Sensex jumps 579 pts on easing crude oil prices

Index	Open	High	Low	Close	Change
NSE NIFTY	24,062.20	24,194.55	24,058.80	24,175.70	+169.85 (0.71%)
BSE SENSEX	77,083.14	77,578.93	77,063.95	77,502.12	+579.48 (0.75%)

KBK Infographics

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Stock market benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty ended nearly one per cent higher on Thursday amid softening crude oil prices, following positive developments on the geopolitical front and buying in blue-chip IT stocks. The 30-share BSE Sensex jumped 579.48 points, or 0.75 per cent, to end at 77,502.12. During the day, it surged 656.29 points, or 0.85 per cent, to 77,578.93. The 50-share NSE Nifty rallied 169.85 points, or 0.71 per cent, to settle at 24,175.70. From the Sensex pack, Infosys jumped 5.64 per cent, followed by Tech Mahindra (4.32 per cent), Tata Consultancy Services (4.28 per cent) and HCL Tech (4.12 per cent). Bajaj Finserv, Adani

Ports, Titan and ICICI Bank were also among the major gainers. Larsen & Toubro, Maruti Suzuki India, Axis Bank and Reliance Industries were among the laggards. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, dropped 1.45 per cent to \$70.53 per barrel. India and Japan on Thursday unveiled a raft of landmark initiatives, including an economic partnership framework and defence pact to co-develop military hardware, following summit talks between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and his Japanese counterpart Sanae Takaichi. The major outcomes from the meeting included a declaration on economic security, a joint statement for cooperation in the field of artificial intelligence and a document to bolster engagement in the energy supply chain.

services." (PTI)

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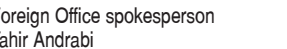
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Pakistan a day after last

Let this be very clear: the real issue is not terrorism.



communities across the
commonwealth.”
The California attorney



Under the IWT, brokered

ation of water." (PTI)

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followed by China at 9,995, convenient and affordable holiday destination. (PTI)

REPORT ON AUDIT OF THE FINANCIAL STATEMENTS OF JAMIA CO-OPERATIVE BANK LIMITED									
To The Members, Jamia Co-operative Bank Limited Opinion We have audited the accompanying Financial Statements of Jamia Co-operative Bank Limited (the "Bank") as at 31 March 2026, which comprise the Balance Sheet as at 31 March 2026, and the Profit and Loss Account, for the year then ended, and a summary of significant accounting policies and other explanatory information. The returns of eight branches audited by us are incorporated in these financial statements. In our opinion, and to the best of our information and according to the explanations given to us, the aforesaid financial statements give the information required by the Banking Regulation Act, 1949, the Delhi Cooperative Societies Act, 2003 and the Rules made thereunder, and the guidelines issued by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) and the generally accepted accounting principles and, in the manner so required and give a true and fair view in conformity with the accounting principles generally accepted in India of the state of affairs of the Bank as at March 31, 2026 and its profit and loss for the financial year ended on that date. Basis for Opinion We conducted our audit in accordance with the Standards on Auditing (SAs) issued by the Institute of Chartered Accountants of India (ICAI). Our responsibilities under those Standards are further described in the Auditor's Responsibilities for the Audit of the Financial Statements section of our report. We are independent of the Bank in accordance with the Code of Ethics issued by the ICAI and we have fulfilled our other ethical responsibilities in accordance with the Code of Ethics. We believe that the audit evidence we have obtained is sufficient and appropriate to provide a basis for our opinion on the financial statements. 1. It was observed that the balances under Current & Contingency Reserve and Technology Upgradation Reserve have remained unchanged for the past few years and no fresh appropriations have been made to these reserves during this period. As the bank has enough free reserves and other reserves to cover the future losses so The balances lying in Current & Contingency Reserve and Technology Upgradation Reserve should be transferred to Free Reserves after obtaining the necessary approvals and complying with applicable regulatory requirements. 2. It was observed that the Bank does not maintain a separate Memorandum Account for tracking expenses/charges recoverable from NPA accounts. In the absence of such a mechanism, it is not clear how the Bank identifies and appropriates amounts recovered from NPA accounts towards recoverable charges before adjusting the balance recovery against principal and interest. Further, no system-generated report is available for tracking such recoverable charges. Consequently, the bifurcation and calculation, if carried out manually, would be time-consuming and may increase the risk of errors and incorrect appropriation of recoveries. 3. It was observed that the Bank continues to carry a balance of ₹11.86 crore under the GL "Bad and Doubtful Debts Reserve" classified as per the reserve. As per the guidelines dated 02.08.2024, NPA provisions are now being maintained through the GL "Contingent Provision for Bad & Doubtful Debts," which carries a balance of ₹17.46 crore and adequately covers the provision requirement for accounts classified under the NPA category. In view of the revised regulatory framework and the fact that the NPA provisioning requirement is being met through the new provision account, the rationale for continuing the old "Bad and Doubtful Debts Reserve" in the books could not be ascertained. Information Other than the Financial Statements and Auditor's Report Thereon The Bank's Board of Directors is responsible for the preparation of the other information. The other information comprises the information included in the Report of Board of Directors including other explanatory information but does not include the financial statements and our auditor's report thereon. The report of the Board of Directors is expected to be made available to us after the date of this auditor's report. Our opinion on the financial statements does not cover the other information and we do not express any form of assurance conclusion thereon. In connection with our audit of the financial statements, our responsibility is to read the other information and, in doing so, consider whether the other information is materially inconsistent with the standalone financial statements or our knowledge obtained in the audit or otherwise appears to be materially misstated. If, based on the work we have performed, we conclude that there is a material misstatement of this other information, we are required to report that fact. We have nothing to report in this regard. When we read the Annual Report, if we conclude that there is a material misstatement therein, we are required to communicate the matter to those Charged with Governance. Responsibility of Management for the financial statements The Bank's Board of Directors is responsible for preparation of these financial statements that give a true and fair view of the financial position and the financial performance of the Bank in accordance with the accounting principles generally accepted in India, including the Accounting Standards issued by ICAI, provisions of Banking Regulation Act, 1949 and the Rules made thereunder, provisions of Delhi Cooperative Societies Act, 2003 and the Rules made thereunder and circulars and guidelines issued by RBI from time to time. This responsibility also includes maintenance of adequate accounting records in accordance with the provisions of the aforementioned Acts for safeguarding the assets of the Bank and for preventing and detecting frauds and other irregularities; selection and application of appropriate accounting policies; making judgments and estimates that are reasonable and prudent; and design, implementation and maintenance of adequate internal financial controls, that were operating effectively for ensuring the accuracy and completeness of the accounting records, relevant to the preparation and presentation of the financial statements that give a true and fair view and are free from material misstatement, whether due to fraud or error. In preparing the financial statements, management is responsible for assessing the Bank's ability to continue as a going concern, disclosing, as applicable, matters related to going concern and using the going concern basis of accounting unless management either intends to liquidate the Bank or to cease operations, or has no realistic alternative but to do so. The Board of Directors is also responsible for overseeing Bank's Financial Reporting process. Auditor's responsibility for the Audit of the Financial Statements Our objectives are to obtain reasonable assurance about whether the financial statements as a whole are free from material misstatement, whether due to fraud or error, and to issue an auditor's report that includes our opinion. Reasonable assurance is a high level of assurance, but is not a guarantee that an audit conducted in accordance with SAs will always detect a material misstatement when it exists. Misstatements can arise from fraud or error and are considered material if, individually or in the aggregate, they could reasonably be expected to influence the economic decisions of users taken on the basis of these financial statements.	As part of an audit in accordance with SAs, we exercise professional judgment and maintain professional skepticism throughout the audit. We also: - Identify and assess the risks of material misstatement of the financial statements, whether due to fraud or error, design and perform audit procedures responsive to those risks, and obtain audit evidence that is sufficient and appropriate to provide a basis for our opinion. The risk of not detecting a material misstatement resulting from fraud is higher than for one resulting from error, as fraud may involve collusion, forgery, intentional omissions, misrepresentations, or the override of internal control. - Obtain an understanding of internal control relevant to the audit in order to design audit procedures that are appropriate in the circumstances, but not for the purpose of expressing an opinion on the effectiveness of the Bank's internal control. - Evaluate the appropriateness of accounting policies used and the reasonableness of accounting estimates and related disclosures made by management. - Conclude on the appropriateness of management's use of going concern basis of accounting and, based on the audit evidence obtained, whether a material uncertainty exists related to events or conditions that may cast significant doubt on the Bank's ability to continue as a going concern. If we conclude that a material uncertainty exists, we are required to draw attention in our auditor's report to the related disclosures in the financial statements or, if such disclosures are inadequate, to modify our opinion. Our conclusions are based on the audit evidence obtained up to the date of our auditor's report. However, future events or conditions may cause the Bank to cease to continue as a going concern. - Evaluate the overall presentation, structure and content of the financial statements, including the disclosures, and whether the financial statements represent the underlying transactions and events in a manner that achieves fair presentation. We communicate with those charged with governance regarding, among other matters, the planned scope and timing of the audit and significant audit findings, including any significant deficiencies in internal control that we identify during our audit. We also provide those charged with governance with a statement that we have complied with relevant ethical requirements regarding independence, and to communicate with them all relationships and other matters that may reasonably be thought to bear on our independence, and where applicable, related safeguards. Report on Other Legal & Regulatory Requirements 1. The Balance Sheet and the Profit and Loss Account have been drawn up in accordance with the provisions of Section 29 of the Banking Regulation Act, 1949 and The Delhi State Co-operative Societies Act, 2003 and the rules made there-under. 2. As required by rule 80(6) of Delhi Cooperative Societies Rules, 2007, we report that: a) We have obtained all the information and explanations, which to the best of our knowledge and belief were necessary for the purpose of our audit and have found to be satisfactory; b) In our opinion, proper books of account as required by law have been kept by the Bank so far as it appears from our examination of those books and proper returns adequate for the purposes of our audit have been received from the branches/offices; c) The transactions of the Bank which came to our notice have been within the powers of the Bank; d) The Balance Sheet and the Profit and Loss Account dealt with by this report, are in agreement with the books of account and the returns; e) The accounting standards adopted by the Bank are consistent with those laid down by accounting principles generally accepted in India so far as applicable to Banks; f) In our opinion and according to information and explanations given to us, we have not noticed any material impropriety or irregularity in the expenditure or in the realization of money due to the bank. g) The members have been enrolled as per the provisions of the Act and the rules made thereunder. 3. As per the information and explanations given to us and based on our examination of the books of account and other record, we report as under on certain matters specified in sub-rule (7) of rule 80 of the Delhi Co-operative Societies Rules, 2007:- a. We have not come across any transactions which appear to be contrary to the provisions of the Delhi Cooperative Societies Act, 2003, the rules or the bye-laws of the Bank. b. We have not come across any material or significant transactions which appear to be contrary to the guidelines issued by the Reserve Bank of India. c. Based on our examination of the books of account and other records and as per the information and explanations given to us, the money belonging to the Bank which appears to be bad or doubtful or recovery are detailed below: <table border="1"><thead><tr><th>Category</th><th>Principal outstanding as on March 31, 2026 (Rs. In Lakhs)</th></tr></thead><tbody><tr><td>Doubtful Advances</td><td>1732.72</td></tr><tr><td>Loss Advances</td><td>NIL</td></tr><tr><td>Other Assets</td><td>NIL</td></tr></tbody></table> d. The Bank has not given any loans to the members of the Board of Directors. e. We have not observed any violation of guidelines, conditions etc., issued by the Reserve Bank of India. f. The Registrar of Cooperative Societies in this regard has not specified any matters to the Bank. We further report that: i. The Balance Sheet and the Profit and Loss Account dealt with by this report, are in agreement with the books of account and the returns. ii. In our opinion, proper books of account as required by law have been kept by the Bank so far as appears from our examination of those books. iii. The reports on the accounts of the branches audited by us / branch auditors have been dealt with in preparing our report in the manner considered necessary by us. For VGHSR & Associates LLP Chartered Accountants FRN : 007915N/500393 Sd/ CA. Vinod Kumar Kalra (Designated Partner) DPIN: 00288415, M. NO. 0866990	Category	Principal outstanding as on March 31, 2026 (Rs. In Lakhs)	Doubtful Advances	1732.72	Loss Advances	NIL	Other Assets	NIL
Category	Principal outstanding as on March 31, 2026 (Rs. In Lakhs)								
Doubtful Advances	1732.72								
Loss Advances	NIL								
Other Assets	NIL								

Major Russian attack kills 20 civilians in Kyiv

HANNA ARHIROVA/ILLIA NOVIKOV ■ Kyiv

Russia hammered Kyiv in an 11-hour drone and missile attack overnight into Thursday morning, killing at least 20 civilians in the city and injuring scores more in what Moscow said was retaliation for Ukrainian strikes on Russian oil facilities. Loud explosions shook the Ukrainian capital for hours during the night, with many people sheltering in subway stations after authorities issued air raid warnings. Emergency crews were still digging through

the rubble of collapsed and charred apartment buildings in search of victims as dawn broke. Russia's Defence Ministry said in a statement that the deadly bombardment was in response to Ukraine's long-range strikes that have caused severe fuel shortages and put pressure on President Vladimir Putin. Ukraine's increasingly frequent and large-scale attacks — described by Zelenskyy as a 40-day blitz — have especially targeted oil refineries, causing a fuel crisis that has frustrated Russians, more than four



Emergency services personnel work to extinguish a fire after a Russian strike on Kyiv, Ukraine on Thursday

AP

years after Moscow's full-scale invasion of its neighbour. Ukrainian officials say they are trying to force Putin to the negotiating table, but so far Moscow's response has been to hit back. Diplomatic efforts to end the war, most recently by the Trump administration, haven't produced results. Putin thinks that time is on his side, that Western support will peter out and that Ukraine's resistance will eventually collapse under pressure from strategic bombing, Western analysts say.

The attack killed 20 people in Kyiv, according to Kyiv city administration head Tymur Tkachenko. More than 90 others were injured, according to Kyiv Mayor Vitali Klitschko. Foreign Minister Andrii Sybiha said it was a "night of horror" in the capital. Damage was recorded in 30 locations across the city, mainly residential buildings and civilian infrastructure, according to Tymur Tkachenko, head of the Kyiv City Military Administration. Some 20 residential buildings were damaged, Interior Minister Ihor Klymenko said. (AP)

Andy Burnham, likely next UK PM, wants grooming gang leader deported to Pakistan

ADITI KHANNA ■ London

Andy Burnham, widely expected to succeed Keir Starmer as Britain's new prime minister later this month, is leading calls for the deportation of a grooming gang ringleader to Pakistan after he was released from prison on Thursday. Burnham, the MP for Makerfield likely to be elected unopposed later this month after Starmer's recent resignation, said he will "review all options" to remove Shabir Ahmed — convicted in 2012 of multiple charges of rape and sexual offences against young girls. The scandal, which rocked Rochdale in Greater Manchester, falls within



Burnham's patch as the region's former mayor and has hit the headlines again after it emerged that Ahmed is protected under a 1970s law that blocks his deportation.

"Like everyone, I want this vile criminal out of the country. Victims must come first," said Burnham. "I will ask the Home and Foreign Secretaries to review all possible options

— and they should consider nothing is off the table," he said. Ahmed, a 73-year-old dual national, was stripped of his British citizenship when he was sentenced to 22 years imprisonment by a UK court. However, a Probation Service letter informing victims of his early release under a prison scheme this week revealed that as per the UK's Immigration Act 1971, any Commonwealth citizen who arrived in the UK before 1973 and had been here for at least five years, cannot be deported. The issue is said to have been further complicated by the fact that there is reluctance on the part of the receiving country, Pakistan, to accept the criminal. (PTI)

UN asks Pakistan to reverse reconstructions at Taxila sites

SAJJAD HUSSAIN ■ Islamabad

The UN has asked Pakistan to reverse the "reconstructions" that "undermined the integrity" of two historical sites in Taxila, a UNESCO World Heritage site, or these would be placed on the agency's "danger list", a media report said on Thursday. UNESCO, the cultural arm

of the UN, in a recent meeting told senior government officials that it would not hesitate to "delist" the historical sites at Mohra Moradu and Sirkap, just like it had "delisted" a World Heritage Site in Germany, due to the recent "unnecessary interventions", the Dawn newspaper reported, quoting sources. The UN agency warned that it would "delist" Taxila from its World



Heritage List if the actions were not reversed. Taxila, located in the Rawalpindi district of Pakistan's Punjab province, is a vast serial site that includes a Mesolithic cave and the archaeological remains of four early settlement sites, Buddhist monasteries, and a mosque and madrasa. The ruins of the four settle-

ment sites at Taxila reveal the pattern of urban evolution on the Indian subcontinent through more than five centuries, according to the UNESCO website. In March, a visitor shared information and pictures with Pakistan's Permanent Delegate to UNESCO in Paris, highlighting reconstruction works by the Punjab archaeology department. (PTI)

Seek balanced ties with neighbours, says Nepalese foreign minister

SHIRISH B PRADHAN ■ Kathmandu

Nepal wants to maintain a balanced relationship with all friendly countries, including neighbours India and China, stress on economic diplomacy and pursue a new style based on national interest, Minister for Foreign Affairs Shisir Khanal said Thursday. Talking about his recent visit to India, which was the first high-level contact between the two countries after the formation of the new government in Nepal in March, Khanal said the visit may be termed as a "special one." During his visit to India from June 5-7, Khanal held wide-ranging talks with External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar and also met National Security Advisor Ajit Dval. "We have placed eco-

nomie collaboration as the focal point during the discussions. As bilateral mechanisms have become active and operational as a result of my recent official visit to India. The visit may be termed as a special one," Khanal told the National News Agency of Nepal. (PTI)





कार्यालय नगर निगम, भोपाल

विद्युत शाखा

निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना

क्रमांक 44 / वि.शा. / 2026

दिनांक 02/07/2026

निम्नलिखित कार्य हेतु दो लिफाफा पद्धति के अनुसार परसेन्टेज मोहरबंद निविदायें निर्धारित प्रपत्र पर आनलाईन आमंत्रित की जाती हैं।

क्र.	आन लाईन टेंडर नं.	कार्य स्थल का नाम	अनुमानित राशि	घरोर राशि	निविदा प्रपत्र की कीमत	टेकेदार की श्रेणी	कार्य हेतु निर्धारित एस ओ आर	निविदा की अवधि	कार्य की अवधि
1.	2026_UAD_518955_1	Crematorium construction with Civil Internal External Electrification and Supplying and Fixing of Crematorium Machine for Laharpur Govindpura Bhopal.	1,02,43,012/-	51,215/-	12,500/-	Registered Electrical contractor in centralized registration system in MPPWD having valid electrical license	MPUADD Electric Works SOR 2021, MPUADD Building Works, SOR 2021, and MPPWD SOR- 2024	1 माह	12 माह

नियम व शर्तें :-
निविदा प्रपत्र की निर्धारित राशि, घरोर राशि एवं अन्य आवश्यक दस्तावेज आनलाईन प्रस्तुत करने होंगे। समस्त विस्तृत जानकारी www.mptenders.gov.in पर देखी जा सकती है। यदि किसी प्रकार का संशोधन होता है तो वह website पर प्रदर्शित होगा। वह पृथक से सामाचार पत्र में प्रकाशित नहीं किया जायेगा।

कार्यालयन यंत्री (वि.) नगर निगम भोपाल

नि. क्र. 387/026/027



भवन रचना विभाग

निविदा प्रक्रिया कक्ष

निविदाजाहिरात - फ़ेर निविदा कामे पुणे महानगरपालिका

1) ई-निविदा विक्री कालावधि :- 03/07/2026 दुपारी 2.30 वा. वाजेन्तर ते 13/07/2026 दुपारी 2.30 वाजेपर्यन्त..

2) निविदा स्वीकृती व अंतिम दिनांक व वेळ :- 03/07/2026 दुपारी 2.30 वा. वाजेन्तर ते 13/07/2026 दुपारी 2.30 वाजेपर्यन्त..

3) तांत्रिक बाबींचा लिफाफा उघडणे दिनांक :- 14/07/2026 दुपारी 3.00 वा. वाजेन्तर

अ. क्र	निविदा क्र.	खात्याचे नाव	कामाचे नाव	एकूण निविदा रक्कम	बयाणा रक्कम	कामाची मुदत	निविदा संच रूपये	निविदाविषयक जबाबदार व्यक्तीचे नाव
1.	सी.एम.सी./भवन / 271/ 2025-26	भवनरचना विभाग	पुणे पेठ कोथरुड सन. 69,70 या ठिकाणी एक्झिव्हेशन सेंटरचे उर्वरीत कामे करणे (फेज-3)	76286279	381431	9 महिने (पावसाळ्या कालावधीसह)	17879	श्रीमती गौरी पोतदार

टिप - जाहिरात क्र. 3/1858 दि. 27.03.2026 रोजीच्या यापूर्वी मजकूर हा वर्तमान पत्रात प्रसिध्द केलेला आहे.

Advt. No.- 03/308
Date- 03/07/2026

स्वाक्षरी.
कार्यकारी अभियंता
भवन रचना कार्यालय
पुणे महानगरपालिका

NORTHERN RAILWAY

TENDER NOTICE

Tender Notice No. DSL-TKD-AMC-EOT-OT-26 Dated **01.07.2026**

The Sr. DME/Diesel, Northern Railway, Diesel Loco Shed, Tughlakabad for and on behalf of President of India invites e-tenders for the following work. The tender will be accepted online only in the prescribed tender document.

Name/ Annual Maintenance Contract of EOT Cranes (Including consumables, labour, of materials, tools and all other accessories) and Inspection/Testing & Certification of lifting tackles, Deflection & Load testing of EOT cranes and Jib cranes installed in Diesel Shed Tughlakabad for three years

Place of work	Diesel Shed, Tughlakabad, New Delhi-110044.
Completion period	03 years
Approximate cost of work	Rs. 31,26,126.42/- Including GST (Rs. Thirty One Lakh Twenty Six Thousand One Hundred Twenty Six and Forty Two Paise only including GST)
Amount of Bid Security	Rs. 62,500/- (Rs. Sixty Two Thousand Five Hundred only)
Technical Eligibility Criteria	As per clause 10 of tender form (second sheet) of Tender Document.
Financial Eligibility Criteria	As per clause 10 of tender form (second sheet) of Tender Document.

Website to download and upload e-tender document www.ireps.gov.in

Due date & time of uploading of Tender by tenderer 23.07.2026 upto 12:00 Hrs.

Date & Time of Tender opening 23.07.2026 after 12:00 Hrs.

Validity of offer 60 days from opening of tender.

Tender Document can be downloaded from Indian Railway website www.ireps.gov.in. For details of work experience, scope of work and terms & conditions please see Tender document. 2267/26

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is to inform to the public at large Smt. Savinder Malika has acquired Entire Third Floor with right built-up Property No.49, measuring 300 sq. yds, in Block-A (A-49), The Janta CHBS Ltd. known as Meera Bagh, Paschim Vihar Delhi vide Sale Deed dt. 11.09.2024 executed by Smt. Krishna Devi, Original Perpetual Sub-Lease Deed dt. 06.11.1978 and Conveyance Deed dt. 22.01.1996 executed in favour of Mr. Gian Prakash Sharma w.r.t entire property are Lost. Now Smt. Savinder Malika is the undisputed owner of said properties and willing to mortgage the said property with IndusInd Bank Ltd.

OR

Any person / firm / institution / company having any claim or right in respect of the said Property in form of inheritance, share, sale, agreement, lease, license, gift, possession, legal heirs, partners or encumbrance however or otherwise is hereby required to intimate in writing to the undersigned within 07 days from the date of publication of this notice of his/her/their share or claim, if any, with all supporting documents at below mentioned address. After expiration of notice period, the claims, if any, of such person shall be treated null and void and also treated as waived and not binding on our client.

Ajay Kumar Giri (Advocate) H No. 26/161, Basement, Vikram Vihar, Lajpat Nagar 4, New Delhi - 110024

PUBLIC NOTICE

Re: Entire Second floor without its Roof terrace rights, Said floor Built-up Property Bearing Municipal No. VZ-610, area measuring 150 Sq. Yds. i.e. 125.415 Sq. Mtrs., Part of Mustali No. 19 Kila No. 5/2, Khewat No. 46, Khata No. 79, situated in the area of Village Shakur Pur, Delhi State Delhi, Abadi Known as Sri Nagar Extn., Shakur Pur, Delhi-110034. : hereinafter referred to as "said property".

NOTICE is hereby given to general public that our client, Mrs. Adarsh (hereinafter called the "owner") is the absolute owner of the said floor by virtue of Sale Deed dated 01.04.2024 executed by Mrs. Saroj Garg, Mrs. Alka Saini & Mrs. Isha Garg registered as document no. 2024/151/4078. It has been further informed that initially Mrs. Priyam Kaur was the owner of the said property vide a sale deed dated 25.07.1960 and thereafter, Mr. Krishan Chander Goel purchased the said property vide a sale deed, dated 21.04.1969. Further, Mr. Krishan Chander Goel died on 02.12.2009, Leaving behind his legal heirs Mrs. Savita Goel, Mrs. Sushma Garg, Mr. Naresh Kumar Goel & Mr. Rajesh Kumar Goel. Out of these legal heirs Mrs. Savita Goel & Mrs. Sushma Garg Relinquished their share to Mr. Naresh Kumar Goel & Mr. Rajesh Kumar Goel vide a relinquishment deed dated 13.08.2021. Thereafter, Mr. Naresh Kumar Goel & Mr. Rajesh Kumar Goel sold the said property to Mrs. Saroj Garg, Mrs. Alka Saini & Mrs. Isha Garg vide a sale deed dated 10.03.2022 and finally, the said floor has been sold to the owner as per above mentioned details. The said owner has also informed that the said floor is mortgaged with Suryoday Small Finance Bank and there is no dispute or any litigation pending upon the said floor.

Any person including Bank/s, Financial Institution/s, relative/s having any claim, right or interest in the said property or any nature whatsoever except of Suryoday Small Finance Bank into or upon the said floor is hereby called upon to make the same known, in writing, with documentary evidence, by Registered A.D. Post, to the undersigned at the address mentioned herein below within 07 days of publication of this notice and in the event of no response having been received to the notice, the title of the owner in respect of the said floor shall be deemed to be clear of any charge or encumbrance of any nature whatsoever and any subsequent claim shall not bind our client/owner, in any manner whatsoever.

Shivkant Arora, Advocate
For M/s Intelective Law Offices
A-74, LGF, Defence Colony,
New Delhi-110024

PM Sharif to visit Iran to attend Khamenei's funeral

SAJJAD HUSSAIN ■ Islamabad

Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif and his top ministers will visit Iran on Friday to participate in the funeral of late supreme leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, who was assassinated in US-Israeli strikes in February, the Foreign Office announced on Thursday. "The prime minister will convey condolences on behalf of the people and government of Pakistan to the Iranian leadership and the bereaved families while reaffirming solidarity with the

brotherly nation in their hour of profound grief," Foreign Office spokesperson Tahir Andrabi said. Deputy PM and Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar, cabinet members and senior officials will accompany the premier on his visit. From Tehran, PM Sharif would travel to Turkiye at the invitation of President Recep Tayyip Erdogan, Andrabi said. He would "hold discussions on the entire gamut of bilateral relations with a special focus on giving impetus to bilateral trade and investment cooperation between the two brotherly countries," Andrabi said. (PTI)

Germany charges Ukraine for Nord Stream blasts

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Berlin

German federal prosecutors on Thursday filed charges against a former Ukrainian army officer over undersea explosions that damaged the Nord Stream gas pipelines between Russia and Germany four years ago. The suspect, identified only as Serhii K in line with local privacy rules, faces charges of

causing an explosion, damaging property, disrupting public service and being an "accomplice to war crimes" by attacking civilian objects, prosecutors said in a statement. The undersea explosions on September 26, 2022 damaged pipelines that were built to carry Russian natural gas to Germany under the Baltic Sea.

NORTHERN RAILWAY

TENDER NOTICE

Tender Notice No. DSL-TKD-WLU-Misc-26 Dated **01.07.2026**

The Sr. DME/Diesel, Northern Railway, Diesel Loco Shed, Tughlakabad for and on behalf of President of India invites e-tenders for the following work. The tender will be accepted online only in the prescribed tender document.

Name/ "Provision for Cleaning & washing of waterless urinals; Cleaning and washing of driver seat cover Set; Removal and reinstall/refit of fire extinguisher, wooden wedges and spare BP-FP pipes/hoses; and Sand filling in Sanders of Electric Locomotive at Diesel Shed, Tughlakabad for 02 year."

Place of work	Diesel Shed, Tughlakabad, New Delhi-110044.
Completion period	02 years
Approximate cost of work	Rs. 24,55,370.51/- Including GST (Rs. Twenty Four Lakh Fifty Five Thousand Three Hundred Seventy and Fifty one paise only including GST)
Amount of Bid Security	Rs. 49,100/- (Rs. Forty Nine Thousand One Hundred only)
Technical Eligibility Criteria	As per clause 10 of tender form (second sheet) of Tender Document.
Financial Eligibility Criteria	As per clause 10 of tender form (second sheet) of Tender Document.

Website to download and upload e-tender document www.ireps.gov.in

Due date & time of uploading of Tender by tenderer 23.07.2026 upto 12:00 Hrs.

Date & Time of Tender opening 23.07.2026 after 12:00 Hrs.

Validity of offer 60 days from opening of tender.

Tender Document can be downloaded from Indian Railway website www.ireps.gov.in. For details of work experience, scope of work and terms & conditions please see Tender document. 2266/26

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

NOTICE INVITING BID

Odisha State Medical Corporation Limited (OSMCL)

In front of Ram Mandir, Convent Square, Unit - III, Bhubaneswar -751 001

Tel. : (0674) 2380950, Website : <https://osmcl.odisha.gov.in> , Email : drugs-osmcl@od.gov.in

Bid Ref. No.: OSMCL/2026-27/ BLOOD BANK-SBTC/04 Date:02/07/2026

Online Bids through e-Tender portal (<https://tendersodisha.gov.in>) are invited from eligible bidders for supply of SBTC Items as per the particulars mentioned below:

Sl. No.	Particulars	Date and time
1.	Date & time of release of bid	02/07/2026, 3 PM
2.	Date & time for submission of queries by E-Mail id - drugs-osmcl@od.gov.in	06/07/2026, up to 5:00 PM
3.	Date & time of Online bid submission	Start/Date & Time 07/07/2026, 3 PM End/Date & Time 28/07/2026, 6:00 PM
4.	Date & time for submission of Tender Documents, Tender Document Fee and EMD amount as per section-IV of tender document	Start/Date & Time 29/07/2026, 10 AM End/Date & Time 06/08/2026, 11:00 AM
5.	Date & time of online Technical bid opening	06/08/2026, 11:30 AM
6.	Date/opening of Price Bid	To be informed to the qualified bidders

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5.	Date & time of online Technical bid opening	06/08/2026, 11:30 AM
6.	Date/opening of Price Bid	To be informed to the qualified bidders

The bid document with all information relating to the bidding process including cost of bid document, EMDs, Prequalification criteria and terms & conditions are available in the websites: <https://osmcl.odisha.gov.in> and <https://tendersodisha.gov.in>. The Authority reserves the right to accept / reject any part thereof or all the bids without assigning any reason thereof. All notice will be published in the OSMCL website <https://osmcl.odisha.gov.in>. Hence the bidders are requested to visit OSMCL website <https://osmcl.odisha.gov.in> time to time for any published notice against the tender.

OIPR-10001/01121/2627/0005

SD/-
Managing Director
OSMC Ltd., Odisha

NBCC to build new AP Bhavan, signs MoU with Andhra Govt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

NBCC (India) Limited, a Navratna Central Public Sector Enterprise, has signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with the Government of Andhra Pradesh for the planning, design and construction of the new Andhra Pradesh Bhavan in New Delhi at an estimated project cost of Rs 105.5 crore, excluding GST and Project Management Consultancy (PMC) charges. The project will be executed on a turnkey deposit work basis. The MoU was signed by Pravin Kumar, IAS, Resident Commissioner, Andhra Pradesh Bhavan, Government of Andhra Pradesh, and Anil Kumar, Chief General Manager (Engineering), NBCC (India) Ltd., in the presence of Dr KP Mahadevaswamy, Chairman and Managing Director of NBCC, Arja Srikanth, Special Commissioner, Andhra Pradesh Bhavan, and Dr. Suman Kumar, Director (Commercial), NBCC.



According to the agreement, the proposed Andhra Pradesh Bhavan will have a built-up area of approximately 2.49 lakh square feet. As the designated executing agency, NBCC will be responsible for the complete execution of the project, including preparation of architectural concept plans, detailed structural drawings, contract management, open tendering and construction. The two sides have also agreed to sign a separate MoU in the future for handing over comprehensive annual maintenance of the building to NBCC

or one of its subsidiaries for a minimum period of five years. The new Andhra Pradesh Bhavan is expected to serve as a modern administrative complex for the state Government in the national capital. The project is also intended to showcase contemporary architecture while strengthening the state's institutional presence in New Delhi. NBCC said it will leverage its expertise in project management and infrastructure development to deliver the facility in line with the project's objectives.

Assam pushes aviation expansion as CM seeks faster approval for Silchar Greenfield Airport

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Assam has stepped up efforts to expand its aviation infrastructure, with Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma urging the Centre to expedite approval for the proposed greenfield airport at Silchar during a meeting with Union Civil Aviation Minister Ram Mohan Naidu Kinjarapu on Thursday. The meeting, held at the Union Minister's office in Rajiv Gandhi Bhavan, focused on accelerating key aviation projects aimed at strengthening air connectivity and positioning Assam as a major aviation and logistics hub in the Northeast. According to the Chief Minister, discussions covered the status of six proposed greenfield airports in the state at Silchar, Manas, Umrangso, Majuli, Diphu, and Charaideo, along with a proposed heliport at Haflong.



Sarma said the state Government has completed most of the preparatory work for the Silchar airport project and requested the Ministry of Civil Aviation to fast-track the approval process so that construction can move forward without delay. For the remaining proposed airports, both sides agreed to expedite pre-feasibility studies to enable the projects to progress to the next stage at the earliest. The meeting also reviewed the ongoing expansion of Rupsi Airport, which has become an important regional aviation facility serving western Assam.

Speaking after the meeting, Sarma said the state Government views aviation infrastructure as a key driver of economic growth, adding that improved air connectivity would not only enhance passenger movement but also strengthen logistics, boost tourism, improve access to remote regions and create new investment opportunities. The proposed greenfield airports are expected to significantly improve regional connectivity and support Assam's broader strategy of emerging as a transportation and logistics gateway for Northeast India.

QBE acquires full ownership of Indian insurance venture after IRDAI approval

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Australian-headquartered insurer QBE Insurance Group Limited has acquired full ownership of Raheja QBE General Insurance Company Limited, marking the end of its 18-year joint venture with Prism Johnson Limited and strengthening its presence in the Indian insurance market. The acquisition, which received approval from the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI), makes QBE the sole shareholder of the company. Following the transaction, Raheja QBE will be rebranded and operate under the QBE name. The company said the move represents a significant milestone in its expansion strategy in Asia and reflects its long-term commitment to India, which it considers a key growth market. With complete ownership,



QBE plans to introduce greater product and operational innovation while leveraging its global expertise to develop customer-centric insurance solutions tailored to the Indian market. The consolidation is also expected to facilitate the adoption of global best practices and advanced technology across its Indian operations. Commenting on the development, Rob Kosova, Chief Executive Officer of QBE Asia, described India as one of the world's most dynamic markets with significant long-term growth potential.

PROSPECT

Justice Prakash Srivastava inaugurates cafeteria at NGT premises

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

National Green Tribunal (NGT) Chairperson Justice Prakash Srivastava on Thursday inaugurated a newly established cafeteria at the Tribunal's premises, aimed at providing a comfortable, hygienic and convenient space for litigants, advocates and visitors. The facility has been developed as part of efforts to improve amenities within the Tribunal and enhance the overall experience of those visiting the NGT for judicial proceedings and related work. Speaking on the occasion, Justice Srivastava said the new cafeteria would contribute to a better workplace environment by promoting greater efficiency, convenience and the overall well-being of all stakeholders associated with the Tribunal. The inauguration ceremony was attended by Judicial Member Justice



Arun Kumar Tyagi, Expert Members Dr A Senthil Vel and Dr Afroz Ahmed, Registrar General Vineeta Warsi, Deputy Registrar Neetu Nagar, Assistant Registrar Fatima Ali, and Narendra Pal Singh, President of the NGT Bar Association. Members of the Executive Committee of the NGT Bar Association, along with senior officers and staff of the Tribunal, were also present at the event.

ZIVAME STRENGTHENS ITS PAN-INDIA RETAIL NETWORK

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Zivame, India's leading intimate apparel brand, has expanded its retail footprint with the launch of a new franchise store in Jabalpur, Madhya Pradesh. The store marks another step in the brand's mission to make intimate apparel shopping more accessible and inclusive for women across India. The new outlet brings Zivame's extensive range of lingerie, sleepwear, shapewear, and activewear closer to customers in the region, along with expert fit assistance and a personalized shopping experience. Founded in 2011, Zivame has become one of India's most trusted intimate apparel brands, offering over 50,000 styles across lingerie, sleepwear, shapewear, and activewear in 100+ sizes, catering to women across age groups and geographies.

Foresta Origins showcases premium forest-based foods at Udyami Madhya Pradesh 2026

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Panna/Bhopal

Foresta Origins, the premium brand of Panna-based Nainas Kitchen Pvt. Ltd., participated in Udyami Madhya Pradesh 2026, a state-level entrepreneurship event organised by the Department of Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSME), Government of Madhya Pradesh, where it showcased its range of innovative value-added food products. The event was held on June 27 at Ravindra Bhavan in Bhopal to mark International MSME Day and was attended by the Chief Minister of Madhya Pradesh and the state's MSME Minister. The programme featured a grand exhibition, buyer-seller meet, vendor development programme, export promotion session, and finance session, providing a platform for MSMEs to connect with industry leaders, institutional buyers, investors, and exporters.



During the exhibition, Foresta Origins displayed a selection of premium products, including Amla Honey Spread Chocolate, Garlic Honey, Mahua Infused Honey, and Chironji Saffron Honey Spread. The products highlighted the company's focus on developing value-added offerings using ingredients inspired by the natural and forest resources of the Panna region. Speaking at the event, Rajkamal Sharma, Founder and Director of Nainas Kitchen Pvt. Ltd., said participation in Udyami Madhya Pradesh 2026 was a significant milestone for the company and a matter of pride for Panna district.

ASU launches Japanese Language Teacher Development Programme for Northeast

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Assam Skill University (ASU), in collaboration with The Japan Foundation (JF) and the Indo Japan Business Council (IJBC), on Wednesday launched the Japanese Language Teacher Development Programme - Northeast India, an initiative aimed at strengthening Japanese language education and creating a skilled pool of language teachers across the region. The programme was inaugurated at the university's City Campus in Birubari, Guwahati, by Assam's Skill, Employment and Entrepreneurship Minister, Biswajit Daimary, in the presence of senior officials from the university, The Japan Foundation and the Indo Japan Business Council. Addressing the gathering, Daimary said language should never be a barrier to education or learning and noted that proficiency in Japanese could open new avenues in education, cultural exchange and global employment.



He described the initiative as a significant step towards enhancing India-Japan cooperation while creating opportunities for skill development and employment in the Northeast. The minister said participants completing the programme would be equipped to teach Japanese, helping expand the network of Japanese language education across the region. He added that the initiative would contribute to building a skilled workforce and support economic growth through stronger international collaboration. The Japanese Language Teacher Development Programme has been intro-

duced to address the growing demand for qualified Japanese language educators while creating greater opportunities for young people in education, skill development, employment and cultural exchange with Japan. Speaking on the occasion, Hanif Noorani, Registrar of Assam Skill University, said the programme had been designed to develop a strong pool of trained Japanese language teachers across Assam and the Northeast. He said the initiative would not only strengthen language education but also open pathways to global career opportunities for the region's youth.

DAILY SUDOKU

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DIFFICULTY RATING: ★☆☆☆☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

SOLUTION (2.7.26)

9 5 2 1 4 8 3 6 7

4 6 1 3 5 7 9 2 8

7 3 8 6 2 9 1 4 5

5 4 9 7 8 2 6 1 3

3 2 6 5 9 1 8 7 4

8 1 7 4 3 6 5 9 2

1 9 5 8 7 4 2 3 6

6 8 4 2 1 3 7 5 9

2 7 3 9 6 5 4 8 1

DOUBLE CROSSWORD

FRIDAY | JULY 3, 2026

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ACROSS

3 For a change, slip into slacks! (5)

8 Nick isn't at church (5)

10 I'm a long time getting the picture (5)

11 At the end of one's tether, there's always a woman (3)

12 The boards used for making gags? (5)

13 He's Tony, formulating an advisable policy (7)

15 Hold the last of the seamen in port (5)

18 Wherein half the army is at the Western Front (3)

19 Walked from Dorset (6)

21 Properly both a member and a friend

22 Like the Cyclops, singularly (4)

23 Posted some presents (4)

24 They may fly with shrill cries from the ship's cat! (7)

26 Handily protected - but not immune to cold feet? (6)

29 Every brazen hussy has one (3)

31 Not a single tango necessitates nine performers (5)

32 Such a driver needs to have the right angle (7)

34 A drover could make it go the right way

35 Apt to be bent over the sink (3)

36 A Britten piece in a hackneyed arrangement (5)

37 How chuck would chat up the shrinking Violet? (5)

38 A couple of characters from Arsenal, possibly at Wembley (5)

DOWN

1 Sound knowhow, but substandard English (5)

2 Fixed things with the driver (7)

4 A job to do when it's dusty out? (4)

5 Old, perhaps, but still capable of making scores (6)

6 Denigrate wild mares? (5)

7 Not quite golden, maybe, but visually admired (5)

9 Figure in the late news (3)

12 Possibly Ted Ray's description of a lost dog (7)

14 Not all press agents look tired (3)

16 Opt to wrap a torn vest round one's head (5)

17 Place in an inferior position? (5)

18 Be unconscious of a slur about honour (7)

20 We leave the weeding in order to show condescension (5)

21 The fruit of sterile monasticism? (5)

23 Dark-complexioned, but self-conscious about a wart (7)

24 Being Irish, is popularly called Red (6)

25 Less than average time (3)

27 In France, water blended with oil with some care (5)

28 She lights up strikingly (5)

30 Answer concerning laminated wood (4)

32 Having an inclination to be angular? (5)

33 No beginning and end, naturally (3)

SOLUTION (2.7.26)

ACROSS

3. Tori

8. Glance

10. Mad Max

11. Meter

12. Cried-d

13. S-Ch-clar

15. Sabot

16. Easel

18. Cried-d

19. Ego-ato

21. L-e-g-at

22. Malay-a

23. Do-CIL-e

24. S-late

25. S-late

26. S-late

27. S-late

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35. S-late

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37. S-late

38. S-late

DOWN

1. Tori

2. Glance

4. Mad Max

5. Meter

6. Cried-d

7. S-Ch-clar

8. Sabot

9. Ego-ato

10. L-e-g-at

11. Malay-a

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Several trains diverted, regulated in July due to track maintenance

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Rail traffic on the Moradabad-Bareilly section will be affected during July due to traffic blocks for track tamping work, with several trains being diverted and others regulated, railway authorities announced. According to the notification, three long-distance trains will be diverted on specified dates via the Moradabad-Chandauli Junction-Bareilly Cantonment route instead of the usual Moradabad-Rampur-Bareilly Cantonment route. The 15910 Lalgarh Junction-Dibrugarh Express will be diverted on July 3, 5, 7, 10, 12, 14, 16, 19, 21, 23 and 29. During the diversion, the train will skip its scheduled halt at Rampur and instead stop at Bareilly Cantonment in place of Bareilly station. The 13152 Jammu Tawi-Kolkata Terminal Express will be diverted on July 3 and 29. The train will bypass Rampur, Milak and Clutterbuckganj, while an additional halt has been provided at Bareilly Cantonment instead of Bareilly.

Similarly, the 13042 Jammu Tawi-Howrah Junction Express will be diverted on July 6 via the alternate route. Although no scheduled stoppages will be skipped, the train will halt at Bareilly Cantonment instead of Bareilly. In addition to the diversions, several trains will experience en-route delays due to traffic regulation during the maintenance period.

IndianOil launches Swachhata Pakhwada 2026, honours sanitation workers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

IndianOil's Director (Refineries), Arvind Kumar, on Wednesday inaugurated Swachhata Pakhwada 2026 at the company's Refineries Headquarters, reaffirming the organisation's commitment to promoting cleanliness, hygiene and community participation. As part of the inaugural programme, Kumar felicitated members of the house-keeping team, recognised as "Swachhata Mitras", for their contribution to maintaining clean and hygienic workplaces. He also distributed Swachhata Kits to the sanitation workers, adminis-



tered the Swachhata Pledge and unveiled a thematic poster carrying this year's message, "Swachhata is Everyone's Responsibility." Swachhata Pakhwada is observed twice a year across ministries and departments of the Government of India under the broader Swachh

Bharat Mission. The fortnight-long campaign seeks to institutionalise cleanliness through sanitation drives, hygiene awareness and public participation, encouraging organisations to make cleanliness a sustained practice rather than a one-time activity.

VP urges ICAI to keep exam standards high on 78th CA Day

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Vice President CP Radhakrishnan on Wednesday called upon the Institute of Chartered Accountants of India (ICAI) to uphold stringent and robust examination standards while highlighting the profession's role in strengthening transparency, accountability and economic governance in the country. The remarks were made during the celebration of the 78th Chartered Accountants Day at Vigyan Bhawan in New Delhi. The event was attended by ICAI President CA. Prasanna Kumar D, Vice-President CA. Mangesh Kinare, Central and

He said Chartered Accountants have played a significant role in the implementation of the Goods and Services Tax (GST), the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC), Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) initiatives and tax reforms, adding that their expertise has strengthened transparency, improved compliance and enhanced investor confidence.

Guru Nanak Dev University, Amritsar Tender Notice				
The Department of G.N.D.U. Amritsar invites online bids for the following:				
Sr. No.	Reference No.	Item	Quantity	Closing date & time
1.	GNDU/Gen/11/2026	Supply / Printing of 32 Pages, 16 Pages Answer Book and 08 Pages Practical Answer Book	09 Lakh	23-07-2026 at 5:00 PM
For details log onto www.eproc.punjab.gov.in Note:- Any corrigendum(s) to the Tender Notice shall be published on the above website only. 24/26/12/2026-27/12/2692 Dated CHD - 02/07/2026				

BRIEFLY

Paqueta suffers thigh injury ahead of Norway match



Brazil midfielder Lucas Paqueta, who limped off the field at halftime during his team's last World Cup match, has a thigh injury. Paqueta was replaced for the start of the second half in Monday's 2-1 win over Japan. Brazil advanced to a round of 16 match against Norway on Sunday at East Rutherford, New Jersey.

The Brazilian soccer confederation said Tuesday the 28-year-old Paqueta had a scan that revealed a muscle injury at the back of a thigh. Paqueta has 13 goals in 67 international appearances. (AP)

Moriyasu expected to stay on as Japan men's team coach



Hajime Moriyasu is expected to continue as head coach of Japan's men's team, with the national soccer federation set to announce a move later on Thursday, according to reports in the domestic media. Moriyasu guided the team to the round of 32 at the World Cup before falling 2-1 earlier in the week to five-time champion Brazil.

Japan has consistently progressed on the world stage in the last two decades but has yet to win a match in the knockout stages at the World Cup.

Moriyasu took over the national team after the 2018 World Cup in Russia. He guided Japan to the knockout stage in the 2022 World Cup in Qatar, losing to Croatia on penalties. Kyodo, the national news agency, reports that the Japan Football Association wants Moriyasu to remain on the job. (AP)

3 people stop play during match between Belgium, Senegal



Three people ran onto the field during Wednesday's World Cup match between Belgium and Senegal in the round of 32, causing a stoppage of play. The people disrupted the game in the 32nd minute. Roughly a dozen security guards were deployed to get them off the field. Belgium defender Maxim De Cuyper held onto the ball amid the incident.

At the time of the interruption, Senegal was leading Belgium 1-0 on a goal by Habib Diarra in the 25th minute. Diarra also scored in the 5-0 rout of Iraq.

Senegal advanced to the knockout round as one of the best third-place finishers. The African team navigated one of the toughest groups in the tournament, facing France and the Erling Haaland-led Norway. (AP)

Yamal is healthy enough to play for Spain in knockout rounds: Fuente



GREG BEACHAM ■ Inglewood (US)

Lamine Yamal is now healthy enough to play a full World Cup match for Spain if needed, coach Luis De La Fuente said Wednesday.

The 18-year-old Barcelona winger scored just one goal while playing only 141 minutes across Spain's three group matches, making him arguably the only world superstar who hasn't excelled in this star-dominated World Cup. Yamal's minutes have been limited by Spain to optimize his recovery from his hamstring tear on April 22.

When De La Fuente spoke to reporters at SoFi Stadium before the start of knockout play, he indicated that Yamal's recovery is all but complete as La Roja prepares to face Austria in a round of 32 match on Thursday.

"Lamine can play whatever we ask him to play," De La Fuente said through an interpreter. (AP)

Technology attracts controversy at World Cup



KUSHAN MITRA

I genuinely believe that technology has made sport better and most sports fans would tend to agree. In games such as cricket, football, tennis and now even baseball which are often decided by a literal hairs breadth, technology, particularly 'Hawk-Eye' has taken any and all subjectivity out of decisions. Indian cricket fans in the era before Hawk-Eye know how certain cricket umpires almost always ruled against India on LBW decisions.

While some amount of ambiguity is allowed to remain in cricket through 'Umpires Call' and rightly so, there is no doubt that the adoption of technology has removed the most egregiously bad calls. In sports like tennis, Hawk-Eye has removed all ambiguity whatsoever on line calls. Similarly in football, line calls and offsides can be decided in seconds and more accurately.



However, as the ongoing World Cup in North America is proving, technology can also be controversial. And on the night between 1st and 2nd July we saw three extremely questionable decisions made thanks to the Video Assistant Referee or VAR. The first was the denial of a penalty to England for a clearly obvious foul on Harry Kane. The second was the awarding of an

extremely dubious penalty to Belgium that knocked out Senegal. The third, a debatable red card for the United States' Balogun.

What is interesting as well, is that while the first decision was confirming the on-field referee's decision, the second and third were decisions made on the advice of the VAR. Now, according to the rule-book, the on-field referee is still the



boss and VAR is only supposed to intervene in the case of high egregious bad calls. Yes, the on-field referee and linesmen are humans and miss something. But there was clearly nothing in those second and third decisions that I feel VAR needed to intervene in.

And I do not believe that I am alone here. VAR can see things frame by frame, and thanks to broadcasters using high frame-rate technology of at least 60 frames per second, this is faster than the human eye can resolve. But we still play the game at the speed of a human eye.

On another front, should teams have the right to appeal? In a knock-out tournament if a decision

has gone against you, particularly a questionable decision such as one Senegal endured, you are on a flight home. But at least a red card can be reversed. If a player can be punished for an on-field action after the fact, then he should also be exonerated after the fact.

Poor VAR decisions have the ability to change the conversation completely and FIFA should be worried. In addition to the decisions above, there was also the decision against Germany a few days earlier that was debatable and could have gone either way. However, the on-field referee in that case had ruled in Germany's favour.

So what should have happened? I believe football should have some sort of equivalent of cricket's umpire's call system. In a free-flowing game like football, challenging an on-field decision by the team's manager for example, like DRS in cricket might not be feasible. But there has to be some method to appeal cards and other decisions.

There is a risk in adopting technology as this World Cup has displayed first-hand, it needs to be fixed.

Harry Kane sends England into round of 16 after 2-1 win against Congo

JAMES ROBSON ■ Atlanta

England handled the pressure and is now headed to Mexico City. Harry Kane ensured England avoided an early exit from the inaugural 48-team World Cup by scoring two second-half goals in a come-from-behind 2-1 win over Congo in the round of 32 on Wednesday.

The late victory, England's second ever at the World Cup after conceding the first goal, earned the 1966 champions a spot in the round of 16 and a match against co-host Mexico. "It was just about pounding the rock, keep pounding the rock and our moment would come," Kane said after scoring his fourth and fifth goals of the tournament. "We spoke about people having hero moments. It can be anyone in the team. Whoever it is, we have hero moments, and for me it was the day."

That team's next match will be played at the Azteca Stadium, the site of Argentina great Diego Maradona's infamous "Hand of God"



goal that eliminated England from the 1986 World Cup quarterfinals. Getting there didn't come easy against a Congo team that nearly pulled off one of the biggest upsets in World Cup history.

England's only other World Cup victory after trailing 1-0 came in the 1966 final against

West Germany at Wembley Stadium.

Kane made sure it happened again at Mercedes-Benz Stadium by extending his record as his country's leading scorer in tournament history to 13. He has record 84 goals for the national team in total. His first goal on Wednesday came in the 75th minute. Substitute Anthony Gordon lifted a cross from the left and despite Congo goalkeeper Lionel Mpsasi getting a hand to Kane's header, he didn't stop it from nestling into the bottom corner. (AP)

Balogun gets US's go-ahead goal against Bosnia and then a red card

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Santa Clara (US)

Folarin Balogun put United States ahead of Bosnia-Herzegovina in the World Cup's round of 32 match on Wednesday night with his third goal of the tournament, then got a red card early in the second half that forced the Americans to play a man short for the remainder of a 2-0 win.

Balogun celebrated a goal with The Silencer move used by the NBA's LeBron James — twice — but the first time he put ball in net the goal was disallowed for offside.



He received a red card from Brazilian referee Raphael Claus for stepping on Tarik Muharemovic's right ankle. Claus didn't initially signal a card but showed Balogun red after a video review.

Balogun became the third player to score and be sent off in a World Cup knockout game after Brazil's Ronaldinho in a 2002 quarterfinal against England and France's Zinedine Zidane in the 2006 final against Italy.

"It never was intentional," US coach Mauricio Pochettino said. "It's never a red card. Never." Balogun has to serve an automat-

ic one-game suspension for Monday's round of 16 game against Belgium.

"We told him we've got his back. We're a team of 26, not just one," defender Chris Richards said. "One man's down, the next guy steps up."

After Balogun's goal was disallowed for offside in the 31st minute, he put the U.S. ahead in the 45th minute as Malik Tillman's pass was deflected into his path by Bosnia's Stjepan Radeljic with a sliding clearance attempt.



Algeria coach will go up against his former team Switzerland in the World Cup knockout round

ANNE M PETERSON ■ New York

Swiss forward Breel Embolo credits Algeria coach Vladimir Petkovic with raising up Switzerland's national team during his seven years at the helm.

Embolo and the Swiss will play against Algeria and their former coach on Thursday in Vancouver, British Columbia, when the two teams meet in the round of 32 at the World Cup.

Petkovic coached Switzerland from July 2014 to 2021. He led the team to the round of 16 at the 2018 World Cup in Russia, then took Switzerland to the quarterfinals of the European Championships for the first time in 2020.

Embolo, who earned his first senior national team call-up in 2015, was named to the 2018 World Cup squad by Petkovic.

"Yeah, he's a coach that knows me very well," Embolo said "I'm not the only one. I think he knows a lot of players. But personally speaking, no, nothing's going to change on my front. I'm going to play the football I'm used to playing, taking into consideration not only the qualities of the Algerian squad, but also their



weak spots. We're going to work together as a group, and we're going to try and get in there 100 percent because we believe that if we play to our strengths, we've got what it takes to get through to the next round.

"And then obviously I'll go and say hi to him after the match."

The feeling was mutual.

"The world of football has become universal. Everyone knows each other. There are no real secrets left in the game," Petkovic said. "I don't think it's a huge advantage to know someone or someone else, just as I know the

players, the players know me, and it's a huge pleasure to come up against them. It'll be lovely to meet and greet them, but after that, the players will go out there on the pitch, and I'm certainly expecting a tough game, and in order to win a match we need to give 120% against a very decent Swiss inside."

Algeria, back at the World Cup for the first time since 2014, was looking for a first knockout round victory. At the Brazil World Cup, Algeria advanced out of the group stage, but fell in the first match against eventual champions Germany. (AP)

Fans embrace lucha libre fever

NAYARA BATSKCHE ■ Mexico City

He's everywhere: around the stadiums, in the streets, having a beer at bars. The anonymous masked wrestler has become one of the defining images of the World Cup in Mexico, often found in throngs of fellow lucha libre aficionados.

Travelers from all over the world have succumbed to the magic of the sport, which, alongside soccer, is a national passion. Inside the fortress of wrestling, they forget about soccer fever for a few hours to experience a unique night. As Spain faced Uruguay in an agonizing match in Guadalajara, tens of thousands of fans tuned in to another spectacular showdown: Místico and Mascara Dorada against The Beast Mortos and Sammy Guevara at the iconic Arena Mexico, also known as the cathedral of lucha libre.

"It was simply fantastic, we enjoyed it immensely," said Andy Winston, a Manchester native who has traveled with his family to



all three World Cup host countries — Canada, the United States and, now, Mexico — while supporting England. "You can't come to Mexico and not come to watch lucha libre. It's a great tradition, a classic."

In the stands, fans cheered and supported their favorites, sporting jerseys from various national teams: England, Japan, South Korea, Brazil, Colombia, Spain and, of course, Mexico. "It was a wonderful night, much better than I imagined," said Henrique Nunes dos Santos,

from Brazil. "You connect with the spectacle in a way that makes it all seem real. There's a gigantic energy." **Wrestling, with Mexican DNA:** The origins of Mexican lucha libre date back to the beginning of 20th century. Its style fuses techniques from American wrestling and Greco-Roman wrestling with aerial acrobatics and performance elements. Soon, this unique combination forged its own identity and become part of country's DNA. It was declared part of Mexico City's cultural heritage. (AP)

Rain abandons India vs England T20I after Iyer, Abhishek half-centuries

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chester-le-Street (UK)

Abhishek Sharma's dynamic 59 and skipper Shreyas Iyer's composed 68 helped India gain a slice of positivity despite their first T20I against England getting abandoned because of incessant rains on Wednesday.

Their fifties helped India post a competitive 189 for seven, a noticeable change in their batting fortunes after churning out two underwhelming efforts against Ireland in the recent 0-2 series defeat.

England's chase of 190 remained a non-starter after the heavens opened up during the innings break.

The second contest of the five-match series will be played at Manchester on July 4. But the beginning of the tourists' innings was anything but rosy after they elected to bat.

The T20I world champions lost Sanju Samson, who drove Saqib Mahmood (3/33) to Tom Banton at point, and Ishan Kishan with just six runs on the board.

Kishan was run out after a mix-up with Abhishek, a mirror image of his dismissal in the second T20I against Ireland at Belfast recently.

At that time, the Indian camp might have briefly revisited their recent batting travails against Ireland in a 0-2 series



defeat. But those fleeting worries were soon eased once Abhishek slipped into his groove, and a bedlam ensued.

Pacers Luke Wood and Mahmood were taken apart spectacularly. Mahmood were carted around for 4, 6, 6 and Shreyas also found a four as India eked 21 runs off the fourth over.

Mahmood tried to unsettle Abhishek

with a couple of short-pitched balls, but the left-hander was equal to the task while bringing out two well-timed pulls.

The timing was a big part of the third wicket alliance that produced 82 runs in a little over seven overs, and it was evident in the way Abhishek handled Wood. The 25-year-old smashed England quick for a hat-trick of fours as

India piled up an impressive 61 for two in the powerplay.

Abhishek did not take his feet off the pedal even after the powerplay, and fetched his fifty off just 20 balls.

Will not give Olympic team status to Greenland, Faroe Islands, says IOC



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Lausanne (Switzerland)

Greenland and the Faroe Islands will not be recognised as separate and independent Olympic teams despite a request from Denmark's parliament, the IOC said Wednesday.

The Olympic Charter has for 30 years defined a country that can have an official team as "an independent state recognised by the international community."

Greenland and the Faroe Islands — which are semi-autonomous territories in the kingdom of Denmark — do not meet that standard, the International Olympic Committee said in a statement. "This position has been explained and communicated very clearly to the concerned parties on numerous



occasions over the past years," the IOC said.

The formal request by the Danish parliament was made two weeks ago and published Tuesday.

It came weeks after Danish Prime Minister Mette Frederiksen formed a new coalition Government.

Serena wins praise from fellow pros at Wimbledon

ANDREW DAMPFAP ■ London

There were still serves beyond 120 mph. Plenty of heavy groundstrokes landing within inches of the baseline, too.

Serena Williams won plenty of praise about her game from her fellow players at Wimbledon a day after her first singles match in nearly four years.

The 44-year-old Williams was beaten 6-3, 6-7 (6), 6-3 by 20-year-old Maya Joint of Australia in the first round on Tuesday but showed she could be competitive after being away for so long.

Coco Gauff ended her dinner early to find somewhere to watch Williams.

"I think Serena's level was insane," Gauff said Wednesday. "It proves even more how she's the GOAT despite age and all that. I don't know how she can play that level not playing for four years. I was already



nervous not playing two weeks before this tournament. I couldn't imagine four years.

"I just love her. I love her fight. And the serve is unbelievable," Gauff added after her second-round win. "You just look at her and you think, 'This is like 10 years ago.' It's really insane. I think it was cool for the sport."

The 87th-ranked Joint

was in the top 30 earlier this year. "Maya played top-10, top-5 tennis. Obviously she's a great player," Gauff said. "She seems like an even, chill girl. I do think if anyone was ready for the moment, it would be her."

Williams announced on Wednesday that she tweaked her right knee toward the end of the first set but said she still hopes to play doubles with sister Venus later in the week. Serena, a 23-time Grand Slam singles champion who won seven of her titles at Wimbledon, did not ask for medical treatment during the match and did not meet with media afterward.

"Serena tweaked her right knee at the end of the first set and was therefore excused from her media obligations by the Wimbledon and WTA medical teams," said Jill Smoller, Williams' agent. (AP)

Praggnanandhaa joint second after opening day of Grand Chess Tour

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Zagreb (Croatia)

Grandmaster R Praggnanandhaa began his campaign in the Zagreb leg of the Grand Chess Tour with a victory over top seed Vincent Keymer of Germany before drawing his next two games to finish the opening day of the rapid section in joint second place. Praggnanandhaa held France's Maxime Vachier-Lagrave and compatriot and world champion D Gukesh in hard-fought draws to end the day on four points, here on Wednesday.

Alireza Firouzja of France emerged sole leader on five points after winning his first two games and drawing with Anish Giri of the Netherlands in the third round. With each rapid win worth two points, Firouzja moved ahead of Praggnanandhaa, Giri, Vachier-Lagrave and Keymer, who recovered from his opening-round defeat with two victories.

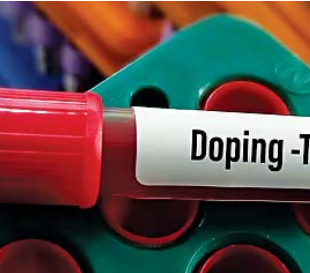
After winning the Norway chess classic ahead of Magnus Carlsen, Praggnanandhaa went on an attacking spree against Keymer in what will be hailed as a masterclass in the future.



The fury of white pieces was there for everyone to see as Praggnanandhaa launched his forces right at the opponent king and cashed in on the full two points in a mere 26 moves.

In the second round of the day, the Indian ace drew with Vachier-Lagrave who had started off with a finely crafted victory over World champion Gukesh.

India remains on top in June list of global doping offenders



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India remained on top in the Athletics Integrity Unit's (AIU) global list of dope offenders, accounting for 162 names, once again highlighting the huge magnitude of the problem that plagues the country's sporting landscape. Kenya took the second spot with 148 names in the list, followed by Russia with over 60 cases.

The list includes persons serving bans for doping offences. It also includes persons who have committed non-doping violations such as tampering, evading testing, trafficking, or missing whereabouts, which carry the same penalties as a doping offence. The Athletics Integrity Unit is an independent anti-doping watchdog established by World Athletics. It has jurisdiction over international level athletes and their support staff.

India first surpassed Kenya in April this year and it remained unchanged in June as well. In April, India was also designated as a country with "extremely high" risk of doping by World Athletics after topping the list of doping offenders for the past two years.

In a decision taken recently by the Athletics Integrity Unit (AIU) Board, Athletics Federation of India (AFI) has been re-categorised from Category B to Category A under Rule 15 of the World Athletics' Anti-Doping Rules.

Srikanth retires; Aakarshi, Tanya enter 2nd round in Canada Open

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Markham (Canada)

Kidambi Srikanth retired early from his opening match due to fitness issues even as Tanya Hemnath and Aakarshi Kashyap emerged as the only Indian shuttlers to progress to the women's singles second round at the Canada Open Super 300 event badminton tournament here.

The 33-year-old Srikanth, who registered a runner-up finish at the US Open Super 300 last Sunday, was lagging 10-11 against Paris Olympic bronze medallist Lee Zii Jia of Malaysia in the men's singles opening round when



he decided to throw in the towel after consulting with coach B Sai Praneeth.

Aakarshi saw off Anna Tatranova of France 21-14, 21-12 to set up a meeting with

fourth seed Beiwen Zhang of the USA, while Tanya prevailed 21-16 21-18 over USA's Disha Gupta in another match. She will face Japan's Riko Gunji next.

India's two-Test tour of Sri Lanka starts August 15

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Colombo

India's two-Test series against hosts Sri Lanka will be played in Galle and Colombo from August 15 to 27, the home board SLC announced on Thursday.

The series is part of the World Test Championship. The first Test will be played at the Galle International Stadium from August 15, while the second will be at the SSC from August 23, read a statement from Sri Lanka Cricket. India, who have made two finals but never won the WTC title, are currently fifth in the standings, while Sri Lanka are sixth.

India will also tour New Zealand this year for a two-



match Test series in November-December.

India had begun the Shubman Gill captaincy era with a commendable 2-2 draw in England before

winning the home series against the West Indies.

However, the mighty hosts were whitewashed by South Africa at home last year, raising serious

questions over the batters' ability to play spin. The Sri Lankan spinners in their own backyard will provide another stiff challenge to the Indian batters.

Asian Games not an exposure trip: Mandaviya

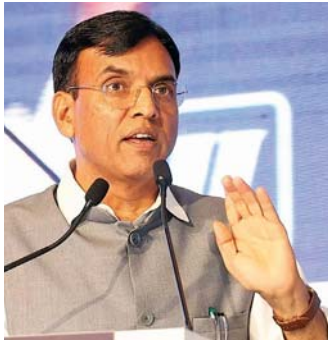
PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya on Thursday asserted that Asian Games is not "an exposure tour" and the athlete contingent size would be capped at 600 to ensure that only those who can deliver head to Japan for the September 19 to October 4 showpiece.

In an interaction with the media here, Mandaviya made it clear that "travellers looking to make up the numbers" won't be cleared for inclusion in the final contingent for Aichi-Nagoya.

"Let me make one thing clear that Asian Games is not an exposure tour; it is a platform for athletes to make the country proud with their best performance. So, as I have repeatedly stated, only those who can deliver will travel," he said.

"Exposure can be gained elsewhere. It doesn't have to be the Asian Games. Anyone looking to



secure jobs through participation certificates will not be cleared. The Games are about performance and we will ensure that," he asserted while addressing queries on whether athletes from poorly-performing disciplines should be considered, though he refrained from taking names.

In its selection criteria unveiled in 2025, the ministry had made it clear that only those with "realistic chance of winning a medal"

would be considered for multi-sport events, including the Asian Games, through selection trials that would be videographed and overseen by independent observers. In addition, it had also stated that only the top six in continental rankings would be eligible. The cut-off means that the Indian football team would not be travelling to the Games this time due to their plummeting rankings.

"We have communicated this to everyone that those NSF's (National Sports Federations) which are recognised by their International Federations, can send their recommendations to the Indian Olympic Association (IOA). The names will be scrutinised by the Sports Authority of India (SAI) and eventually approved by the ministry," Mandaviya said.

"We have tried to address the earlier practice of federations acting on a whim," he added.

Ministry promises spotless infra



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

With the country gearing up to host 11 international events in the next six months, including the world championships of badminton, the Sports Ministry has assured that top-notch facilities would be in place to ensure that all past criticism of playing conditions is suitably addressed.

The world championship of badminton is due to be held at the Indira Gandhi Indoor Stadium in the national capital from August 17. The venue had been lambasted for poor hygiene and maintenance standards by foreign players when it hosted the India Open in January this year. "The endeavour is to ensure

that facilities are top notch. The minister is keeping a watch on the preparations. We are working towards changing the negative mindset and perceptions," a Sports Ministry source said. After the India Open fiasco, which dented the country's image, the ministry had stepped to establish protocols for upkeep of Sports Authority of India infrastructure, including quarterly review of the venues by the minister.

Before the world event, the national capital will also be hosting the Commonwealth Table Tennis Championships in which 35 countries, including Australia, England, Canada, and South Africa are expected to participate from July 28 to August 4.

BAI introduces BWF's new 3x15 scoring system

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The high-intensity 3x15 format will take effect across domestic rankings, zonals and national championships from this month onwards with the Badminton Association of India (BAI) implementing the new BWF scoring system across the domestic circuit to ensure a seamless transition for the Indian shuttlers.

The Yonex-Sunrise All India Senior Ranking Tournament, scheduled to be held in Regional Sports Centre in Ernakulam from July 7 to 14, will be the first tournament to introduce the new format.

Under the revised format, matches will continue to be played as best-of-three games



under rally-point scoring, but each game will now be played to 15 points instead of 21. A two-point lead remains mandatory from 14-all, with games capped at 21 points, where the next point becomes decisive at 20-all.

The shorter format which will be rolled out by the Badminton World Federation (BWF) from January next year is expected to increase intensity, accelerate momentum shifts and place greater emphasis on tactical precision and quick decision-making.